

Govt unveils smart substation, launches Solarise East drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Sunday unveiled the first-of-its-kind 2 x 1,000 kVA smart pad-mounted substation at Amar Mohalla, Gandhi Nagar, and 'Solarise East', a community-driven programme launched to promote the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana and Delhi Solar Policy to accelerate rooftop solar adoption across East Delhi.

The initiatives were inaugurated by Harsh Malhotra, Union Minister of State for Road Transport & Highways and Corporate Affairs, and Ashish Sood, Delhi Power Minister, at an event held at

Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University, Surajmal Vihar.

Gandhi Nagar's narrow lanes, intense commercial activity and scarcity of land make the expansion of conventional power infrastructure exceptionally difficult.

At Amar Mohalla, the existing 1,620 kVA substation was operating at nearly 92 per cent loading. Additional capacity was required to meet present demand and future growth, but there was no space to build a conventional 2,000 kVA substation. BYPL's answer was to reimagine the substation itself.

Developed and commissioned at a cost of approxi-

mately ₹1.60 crore, the installation comprises two compact 1000 kVA pad-mounted substations. Together, they have added around 380 kVA of capacity and will strengthen electricity supply for approximately 1,400 consumers in and around Amar Mohalla.

The installation occupies nearly 80 per cent less space than a conventional substation. Each unit integrates the transformer, ring main unit and low-voltage panel on a common frame within a sealed, metal-enclosed and touch-proof structure. Its factory-assembled, plug-and-play design is safer, easier to operate and requires less on-



site construction, maintenance, support quicker fault isolation, address overloading and voltage concerns, and strengthen reliability during peak demand.

Installing the equipment in the narrow lanes adjoining

Gandhi Nagar Market required meticulous planning, careful equipment and cable layout, coordination with residents and traders, and work during restricted hours to minimise disruption to traffic and commercial

activity. Speaking on the occasion, Malhotra appreciated the efforts of the Delhi Power Department in meeting the record power demand this summer.

He also stressed that the Delhi Government is working diligently to meet the futuristic and ever-growing power demand of the national capital. He further stressed that these two initiatives by BSES are the right steps in this direction.

Delhi Power Minister Ashish Sood said, "Good governance is not just about solving today's challenges; it is about preparing for tomorrow's opportunities. Every substation we modernise and

every rooftop we solarise is a step towards a stronger, greener, and more self-reliant.

Delhi Government's ₹1,427 crore investment in power infrastructure, the successful management of the record peak power demand of 8,748 MW without major outages, reaffirmed the Government's commitment to delivering Reliable, Affordable, Smart and Green Power while making Delhi's electricity network future-ready."

Together, the initiatives reflect the changing face of electricity distribution. The Gandhi Nagar substation demonstrates how compact engineering, automation and digital intelligence can

strengthen the network where every square metre matters, while Solarise East will help consumers turn their rooftops into sources of clean power and savings.

Commenting on the initiatives, a BSES spokesperson said, "Aligned with the Delhi government's vision of a Viksit Delhi, the Gandhi Nagar substation and Solarise East represent two sides of the same energy future. One uses compact engineering and digital intelligence to deliver reliable power where every square metre matters. The other will help consumers harness the sun and generate clean electricity from their rooftops."

Delhi records warmest July night in five years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With the minimum temperature of 31 degrees Celsius on Sunday, Delhi recorded the warmest July night in five years, according to the India Meteorological Department. The city had logged a minimum temperature of 31.7 degrees Celsius on July 1, 2021.

The maximum temperature logged at the Safdarjung, Delhi's base station, was 38.3 degrees Celsius, 3.1 notches above the seasonal average, according to the IMD.

The minimum was 3.8 notches above the season's average. It was also the second instance this month of the minimum temperature touching 31 degrees, after a similar reading was



recorded on Friday.

Among the weather stations in Delhi, Palam recorded 37.6 degrees Celsius, Ayanagar 37.2 degrees Celsius, Lodhi Road 36.7 degrees Celsius and Ridge at 36.6 degrees Celsius.

The minimum temperature at Lodhi Road was 30 degrees Celsius, Ayanagar 29.4 degrees Celsius, Palam 29 degrees Celsius and Ridge

27.6 degrees Celsius. No rainfall was recorded at any of the five observatories between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm on Sunday.

Weather models from both the India Meteorological Department (IMD) and leading international forecasting agencies indicate that rainfall activity will increase significantly over the next several days as mul-

tiple weather systems become active simultaneously. The revival is likely to bring down daytime temperatures, improve air quality and ease the persistent humid conditions across the National Capital Region.

The weather department has predicted a generally cloudy sky with moderate rain on Monday, with the maximum and minimum temperatures expected to settle around 36 degrees Celsius and 26 degrees Celsius, respectively, the IMD said.

Relative humidity oscillated between 68 per cent at 8.30 am and 50 per cent at 5.30 pm. The air quality was recorded in the 'moderate' category at 4 pm, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 169, the Sameer app showed.

Government to procure 2 lakh national flags from SHGs for Har Ghar Tiranga 2026 campaign

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government will procure around two lakh national flags from Self-Help Groups (SHGs) for the Har Ghar Tiranga 2026 campaign, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Sunday.

She said the initiative will combine the spirit of patriotism with livelihood generation for women and community groups across the Capital.

The government plans to distribute more than 15 lakh national flags across Delhi ahead of Independence Day as part of the nationwide campaign. In addition to procurement from online mar-



ketplaces, a significant share of the flags will be produced by eligible Self-Help Groups identified through the State Urban Livelihood Mission.

Chief Minister said the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign is not limited to hoisting the national flag but also aims to strengthen patriotism,

national unity and public participation. She said the government wants every section of society to become part of the campaign while creating opportunities for economic empowerment.

The Chief Minister said involving Self-Help Groups in the production of national

flags reflects the government's effort to link welfare programmes with sustainable livelihood opportunities. Members of these groups will not only earn an income but will also contribute directly to a national campaign centred on the Tricolour.

According to the Government, around two lakh national flags will be manufactured by eligible Self Help Groups organised under the State Urban Livelihood Mission. The mission works to improve the livelihoods of the urban poor by promoting Self Help Groups, encouraging entrepreneurship, and supporting skill development and self-employment.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it known to the General Public at large that our clients, **Mr. Lala Ram Verma**, S/o Late Sh. Ganga Dan, aged about 77 years, and my wife, **Smt. Bimla Devi**, W/o Shri Lala Ram Verma, aged about 74 years, both residents of **F-66, First Floor, Kalkaji, New Delhi-110019**, hereby declare that their son, **Mr. Dev Verma**, S/o Shri Lala Ram Verma, aged about 43 years, alongwith his legal Representatives, **R/o S-67, 3rd floor, Greater Kailash-II, Opposite K.K. Mangalam School, South Delhi, New Delhi-110048**, have been debarred and disowned by them from all their movable and immovable properties, whether self-acquired or otherwise and severed all their relations with him and his legal representatives due to their conduct, misbehavior cruel attitude and personal reasons towards our clients, they are living separately at the aforementioned address.

Our Clients further declare that Mr. Dev Verma and his legal representatives shall have no right, title, interest, claim, or concern in any of our properties, present or future, and they are not authorized to represent them or deal with any of their assets or affairs in any manner whatsoever. Our Clients further declare that any person dealing with Mr. Dev Verma or his legal representatives in respect of my clients' properties or on their behalf shall do so entirely at his/her own risk, cost, and consequences. They shall not be responsible or liable for any act, omission, transaction, commitment, or liability incurred by them.

Chand Singh (Advocate) Ch. No. 1009, Lawyer's Chambers Block, Rohini District Courts, Rohini, New Delhi-110085

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that **M/s RB Fruttech Pvt. Ltd.**, through its Director, **Mr. Ritesh Gidwani** has approached our client, **HDFC Bank Limited**, for availing a loan against the property bearing Shop Property No. C-38, admeasuring 636 sq. ft., situated at New Subzi Mandi, Azadpur, Delhi thereinafter referred to as the "said Property". **M/s RB Fruttech Pvt. Ltd.** acquired the said Property by virtue of two Sale Deeds both dated 26.12.2025. Doc. No. 2025/15/12/1163 and Doc. No. 2025/15/12/1164, duly executed by **Mrs. Deepa Kukreja** (holding 75% share) and **Mrs. Seema Bhayana** alias **Seema Kukreja** (25% share), respectively. Our client has been informed that the following original title documents pertaining to the said Property have been lost/misplaced. In this regard, two FIRs have already been lodged on 03.07.2026 and 10.07.2026, respectively; 1. Original Mutation Letter dated 13.02.2013 issued by DDA in favour of **Mrs. Reena Gulati**. 2. Original Relinquishment Deed dated 13.06.2017, executed by **Shilpa Arora**, **Sanal Arora** and **Kamlesh Rani** in favour of **Rajat Arora**, Doc. No. 6789. 3. Original Release Deed dated 14.07.2017, executed by **Rajat Arora** in favour of **Chand Kishore**, registered as Doc. No. 9404.

The general public is hereby informed that if any person who finds or comes into possession of the said documents is requested to return the same to the undersigned. Further, if any person has any claim, right, title, interest, charge, lien, mortgage, tenancy, possession, or any other claim whatsoever in respect of the aforesaid property, the same must be notified to the undersigned in writing, alongwith supporting documentary evidence, at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which such claim, if any, shall be deemed to have been waived and abandoned.

Kamali Kant Gupta (Advocate)
Unit No. FF-2, First floor, Mahavir Metro Tower Sec-4, Vajishai, Gzb., U.P., Mob. 9810063351



M.P. POWER GENERATING COMPANY LIMITED
O/O EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR (MATERIAL MANAGEMENT)
(Govt. Of M.P. Undertaking)
ISO 9001:2015 Certified, CIN-U 40109MP2001SGC014882
BLOCK No.8, GROUND FLOOR, SHAKTI BHAVAN, VIDYUT NAGAR, RAMPUR, JABALPUR 482008 (M.P.)
Phone No. : 0761-2702700, E-mail : cesnmpmgcl@rediffmail.com
Website : www.mppgcl.mp.gov.in, ed.materialmgmt@mppgcl.mp.gov.in
Date : 17.07.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT) No. CE (MM) NIT-298

"Through e-tendering process only"

M.P. Power Generating Co. Ltd. invites Electronic Tenders from reputed/established Manufacturers/ Authorized Dealers/ Authorized Distributor/Suppliers/Contractor/Service Provider/Firm for the following Items/ Works for various Power Stations of MPPGCL:

S. N.	Tender ID	Tender Particulars	Estimated Tender Cost (Rs. in Lakhs)	EMD (Rs. in Lakh)	Date and Time for closing of online Submission	Date and Time for opening of e-Tender
1	2026_MPPGC_505863_1	Procurement of Seals for Rotary Air Pre-Heater of PH-III SGTPS Birsinghpur, PH-IV STPS Sami, PH-I & II SSTPP Dongalia	44.00	0.88	10.08.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	12.08.2026 from 15:30 Hrs. onwards
2	2026_MPPGC_505867_1	Procurement of Heating Elements (Baskets) of PH-IV STPS Sami.	252.00	2.52	10.08.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	12.08.2026 from 15:30 Hrs. onwards
3	2026_MPPGC_505865_1	Procurement of Heating Elements (Baskets) of PH-III SGTPS Birsinghpur.	968.5	9.68	10.08.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	12.08.2026 from 15:30 Hrs. onwards
4	2026_MPPGC_517404_1	Procurement of Printed Stationery for various offices at HQ Jabalpur, Thermal and Hydel Power Stations of MPPGCL	72.00	1.44	10.08.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	12.08.2026 from 15:30 Hrs. onwards
5	2026_MPPGC_518880_1	Supply of Ferric Alum to ATPS-Chachai, STPS-Sarni, SGTPS-Birsinghpur and SSTPP Khandwa of MPPGCL.	492.04	4.92	10.08.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	12.08.2026 from 15:30 Hrs. onwards
6	2026_MPPGC_512360_1	Supply of Grinding Rolls (Roller Liners) and Bull Ring Segments (Table Liners) in High Chrome Metallurgy for MVM32F Coal Mill installed in PH-II (2 X 660 MW) SSTPP Dongalia MPPGCL	717.00	7.17	10.08.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs.	12.08.2026 from 15:30 Hrs. onwards

These tenders are being invited through an e-tendering system. For viewing detailed NIT, downloading tender documents and participating in Electronic Tenders, for any clarifications and/or due date extension or corrigendum, please visit the website www.mptenders.gov.in regularly. Any clarifications and/ or due date extension or corrigendum shall be issued on the website www.mptenders.gov.in only.

M.P. Madhyam/126971/2026 // SAVE ELECTRICITY // CHIEF ENGINEER (MM)

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Sanat Kumar Konai, Father of- No.15574843X
Hav Gautam Konai, R/o- Vill- Singul, PO- Joypur, Dist- Murshidabad, W.B.- 742159, have changed my name from Sanat Kumar Konai to Sanat Konai, vide affidavit dated 18/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(204)C
I, Nivu Konai, Mother of- No. 15574843X Hav Gautam Konai, R/o- Vill- Singul, PO- Joypur, Dist- Murshidabad, W.B.- 742159, have changed my name from Nivu Konai to Nibhurani Konai, vide affidavit dated 18/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(205)C
I, No.13880320F **Ex-Nk (TS)** Mohamad Ali Choudhury R/o Vill- Lambabasti, P.O- Karaikandi, PS- Lakhipur Dist- Cachar, State- Assam PIN- 788101 have changed my spouse's Name & Date of Birth in my records from Meharunnesha, DOB- 01 Mar 1969 to Meharun Nessa, DOB- 01 Oct 1969 vide affidavit dated 17/07/2026 before 1st Class Magistrate, Silchar, Cachar, Assam.

PD(206)C
I, Pardeshi Ram Sahu, Father of- No.15711097P Hav Ramesh Kumar Sahu, R/o- Vill- Deorimath, PO- Kikirda, Teh- Hasoud, Dist- Sakti, Chhattisgarh- 495661, have changed my name from Pardeshi Ram Sahu to Pardeshi Sahu, vide affidavit dated 18/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(207)C

I, No.14840512M **Hav** Kameswararao Alla, R/o- Vill & PO- Brahmanatarai, Teh- Palasa, Dist- Srikakulam, Andhra Pradesh- 532220, have changed my daughter's name from Yasmitha to Alla Yasmitha, vide affidavit dated 18/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(208)C
I, Gurbari Bai Sahu, Mother of- No.15711097P Hav Ramesh Kumar Sahu, R/o- Vill- Deorimath, PO- Kikirda, Teh- Hasoud, Dist- Sakti, Chhattisgarh- 495661, have changed my name from Gurbari Bai Sahu to Gurbari Bai Sahu, vide affidavit dated 18/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(209)C
I, No.4343400X **Ex-Nk** Nityalal Barman, resident of Vill- Kaspur Bagerkonda, P.O- Saiganga, P.S- Udarbond, Dist- Cachar, State- Assam, PIN- 788031 have changed my spouse's Name & Date of Birth in my records from Suproba Barman DOB- 16 Apr 1962 to Suprova Barman DOB- 01 Dec 1965 vide affidavit dated 10/07/2026 before 1st Class Magistrate, Silchar, Cachar, Assam.

PD(210)C
I, Lohar Jayashri Ratilal, W/o- No.14677277M Nk Pavar Dipak Kumar Ranchhodhbhai, R/o- G-121/2, Vrajdhara, Society- 2, Makarpura Gidc MI Estate, Makarpura, Vadodara, Gujarat- 390010, have changed my name from Lohar Jayashri Ratilal to Pavar Jayshri Dipak, vide affidavit dated 18/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(211)C
I, Narendar Singh father of Vishal Chaudhary, R/o 9/22, Eklayya Vihar, Sector-9, Vasundhara, Ghaziabad, U.P.- 201012 declare that My name Narender Singh and Narendar Singh are one and the same person. I will full responsible for the above said both names.

PD(212)C

DDA plants 6.62 lakh saplings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has planted more than 6.62 lakh trees and shrubs within days of launching its Mega Plantation Drive, achieving close to 30 per cent of its overall target for the season.

According to the DDA, the tally includes over 37,000 trees and more than 6.25 lakh shrubs planted across the city's parks, ridge forests, biodiversity parks and other green zones.

The DDA said the exercise is being carried out under the



direction of Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, who has asked officials to focus on ecological restoration and expansion of the city's green cover. The LG has also directed departments to monitor the plantations closely to ensure the saplings survive, the statement said.

BJP says Wangchuk's hunger strike was politically motivated



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra on Sunday alleged that activist Sonam Wangchuk's hunger strike at Jantar Mantar was politically driven. He claimed that it was organised to cause disruption ahead of Parliament's Monsoon Session rather than to address concerns over the alleged NEET paper leak.

Malhotra said the appearance of senior lawyers, including Members of Parliament Kapil Sibal and Vivek Tankha, before the Delhi High Court on Sunday, seeking interim relief for Wangchuk, showed that the activist was acting as a "political pawn" of opposition parties rather than as an independent campaigner.

According to Malhotra, the Delhi Police action to remove Wangchuk from Jantar Mantar was carried out in line with directions issued by the Delhi High Court. He said this was also

the reason the High Court had declined to grant interim relief on a petition filed on Wangchuk's behalf.

Referring to the protest, Malhotra said Wangchuk began his hunger strike on June 28 as part of a demonstration backed by the Aam Aadmi Party, Communist parties and the Congress. He noted that a re-examination of the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test, which he described as satisfactory, had already been conducted on June 21, before the strike began.

Malhotra argued that this timeline indicated the hunger strike was not intended to raise student grievances but to create disruption "from the streets to Parliament" during the Monsoon Session.

The statement was issued by the Delhi BJP's media department. Wangchuk, the Aam Aadmi Party, the Congress, and the Communist parties named in the statement have not yet responded to the allegations.



Traffic advisory issued ahead of Monsoon Session, CJP's march

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Ahead of the Monsoon Session of Parliament and the proposed 'Chalo Sansad' march by the Cockroach Janata Party, the Delhi Traffic Police on Sunday issued an advisory warning of heavy vehicular movement and restrictions around the Parliament complex, and security has been further intensified across the New Delhi district. As per the advisory, special traffic arrangements have been put in place in the New Delhi Range, with commuters being asked to plan their journeys and allow extra travel time.

Delhi Police has declared the Cockroach Janata Party's (CJP) proposed "Sansad Chalo" march on July 20 unauthorised, warning that participants attempting to approach Parliament could face detention or arrest. Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) Sachin Sharma

shared a public advisory on X on Sunday, stating that the "Delhi Police categorically clarifies that no permission has been sought or granted for any such protest march/procession." The prohibitory order under Section 163 BNSS (formerly Section 144 CrPC) is currently in effect in the New Delhi district, according to the DCP's post.

"Accordingly, protest marches, processions, demonstrations and assemblies of five or more persons are strictly prohibited, except at the designated protest site at Jantar Mantar, with prior permission," the post read.

Security has been significantly tightened across central Delhi, including additional barricades, police pickets, and intensified checks around Jantar Mantar, Parliament Street, Central Vista, and Connaught Place, with vehicles undergoing extensive screening.

"Accordingly, protest marches, processions,



A Rapid Action Force (RAF) official keeps vigil during the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) protest at the Jantar Mantar in New Delhi



PTI

demonstrations and assemblies of five or more persons are strictly prohibited, except at the designated protest site at Jantar Mantar, with prior permission," the post read.

The DCP warned that any person violating these prohibitory orders could face prosecution under Section 223 BNS and other applicable laws. "Delhi Police appeals to all citizens to respect the law, refrain from participat-

ing in any unauthorised gathering or march, and cooperate in maintaining public peace, safety and security," the post read.

To ensure safety, the Delhi Police has deployed additional personnel, strengthened barricading and is conducting intensive vehicle checks at key entry points, sources said on Sunday. Police sources mentioned that the CJP has not obtained permission for the

proposed march. "We are determined not to allow any unauthorised march towards the high-security zone," they said.

Delhi Police has deployed additional personnel, strengthened barricading and is conducting intensive vehicle checks at key entry points, sources said on Sunday. Security has been strengthened around Jantar Mantar, Parliament Street,

Central Vista, Connaught Place, Shankar Chowk and other key installations, while rapid response teams have been positioned to respond to any contingency.

Several entry points have been converted into high-security zones with multi-layered barricades, enhanced surveillance, anti-sabotage checks and round-the-clock patrolling in New Delhi, Central Delhi and parts of

North Delhi, they said. A senior police source said elaborate preventive arrangements have been made to ensure law and order during the Parliament session.

"Every vehicle entering the New Delhi district is being thoroughly checked. Additional pickets have been set up at strategic locations, and reserve forces have been kept on standby. CCTV surveillance has also been intensified across sensitive areas," the source said.

According to the traffic police advisory, the roads likely to be affected are Rafi Marg, Motilal Nehru Marg, Maulana Azad Road, K Kamaraj Marg, Raisina Road, Rajendra Prasad Road, Parliament Street, Ashoka Road, Talkatora Road, Pandit Pant Marg and Rakab Ganj Gurudwara Road.

Traffic police also advised motorists to avoid key junctions and roundabouts, including Vijay Chowk, Boat Club, Rail Bhawan round-

about, Sunehri Masjid roundabout, Patel Chowk roundabout, Boota Singh roundabout, Prime Chowk roundabout, GRG roundabout and Jalebi Chowk roundabout.

As alternate routes, commuters have been advised to use Janpath, Man Singh Road, Akbar Road, Teen Murti Marg, Shanti Path, Maulana Abdul Kalam Azad Road, Kamal Ataturk Marg, Panchsheel Marg, Vinay Marg, Outer Circle in Connaught Place, Baba Kharak Singh Marg, RML roundabout, Mother Teresa Crescent Road, 11 Murti and Sardar Patel Marg. Motorists have been requested to remain patient, follow traffic rules and cooperate with traffic personnel deployed at key intersections.

Sources said that security has been intensified in the New Delhi district, with the Delhi Police deploying additional personnel, strengthening barricades and conducting intensive vehicle checks at key entry points.

GTB hospital patient dies hours after fan falls on him

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 42-year-old man died at Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital in Delhi within hours of a ceiling fan falling on him while he was being treated in the emergency ward, according to hospital staff familiar with the incident. The patient, identified as Md Akbar, was struck by the fan on Saturday night while a nursing officer was administering treatment to him. The nursing officer also sustained injuries in the incident, hospital staff said.

Akbar had been brought to the hospital's emergency department on July 18 by his brother. He was admitted with complaints of hypertension, meningoencephalitis, and aspiration pneumonia, according to hospital staff who spoke on condition of anonymity.

Eyewitnesses, however, alleged that the nurse had been injured in a separate incident a few months ago and not during the current



episode. "I had gone to the ward to meet my brother when I saw the ceiling fan fall on a patient. I immediately recorded a video of the incident. The patient appeared to be around 50 years old and had been admitted just a day earlier. He was fine before the incident but later died. The doctors are saying the fan fell on a nurse, but I was present there and saw it fall on the patient," alleged Muhammad Aslam Qureshi, an advocate who claimed to have witnessed the incident.

According to eyewitnesses, the ceiling fan suddenly came

loose and fell directly onto the patient's bed, striking Akbar in the abdomen. He was immediately attended to by hospital staff.

The incident occurred at around 9.30 pm on Saturday in emergency ward 27, where Akbar was undergoing treatment. According to hospital staff, the ceiling fan detached from its fitting and fell directly onto the bed where he was lying. "The fan fell directly onto the patient's bed while treatment was being administered," a hospital staff member said, adding that the nursing officer attending to Akbar at the time was also

hurt. Akbar's death certificate recorded the time of death as 12.16 am, less than three hours after the fan fell on him. The certificate listed the cause of death as hypertension, meningoencephalitis, and aspiration pneumonia, the same conditions for which he had been admitted. The certificate did not list any injury caused by the falling fan as the cause of death, based on the details reviewed.

Hospital staff said Akbar's family members gathered at the hospital on Sunday morning after learning of his death. Family members questioned the quality of treatment given to Akbar and raised concerns about the circumstances surrounding the incident, according to hospital staff aware of the matter. A response from GTB Hospital on the incident is still awaited.

The extent of Akbar's injuries from the fan, and whether they contributed to his death, has not been offi-

cially detailed by hospital authorities. The death certificate attributes the cause of death to his pre-existing medical conditions rather than trauma from the fan, though the timing of the two events, the fan falling and his death occurring less than three hours later, has drawn attention to the case.

It is not yet clear what caused the ceiling fan to detach from the ward, or whether any inspection or maintenance lapses may have been involved. Hospital staff have not commented on record about the condition of electrical or mechanical fittings in emergency ward 27 at the time of the incident.

GTB Hospital is one of Delhi's largest government-run hospitals and handles a significant volume of emergency cases from across the city. Incidents involving infrastructure lapses in government hospital wards have previously drawn scrutiny from patients' families and health authorities in the past.

DU UG admissions: Over 81,900 candidates accept seats in first round

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 81,900 candidates have accepted the undergraduate seats allotted to them by the University of Delhi under the first round of the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS). Over 21,500 have confirmed their admissions after fee payment, according to updated data released by the varsity on Sunday.

The university said 81,979 of the 93,033 candidates allotted seats in the first round had accepted their allocation as of 2 pm on Sunday, taking the acceptance rate to 88.12 per cent.

Of these, 33,383 candidates had reached the stage where payment links had been generated after college verification, while 21,530 had completed the admission process by paying the requisite fees. This accounts for 23.14 per cent of the total allocations.

The figures mark an



increase from Saturday evening, when 79,404 candidates had accepted their allotted seats, 26,061 applications had been approved for fee payment, and 10,746 candidates had completed the admission process.

The first allocation list, announced on July 16, offered seats to 93,033 candidates against more than 71,000 undergraduate seats across 221 programmes in 67 colleges for the 2026-27 academic session.

The allocations were made from among over 2.08 lakh candidates who completed

Phase 2 of the admission process by submitting their programme and college preferences. A total of 15.94 lakh unique programme-college preferences were considered during the allocation exercise. Among special category admissions, 1,243 single girl child candidates and 242 orphan candidates, including 109 male and 133 female applicants, were allotted seats.

Candidates who have accepted their allotted seats can opt for an upgrade in subsequent rounds if they wish to be considered for a higher preference.

Govt moves to take over Janakpuri school over safety, financial violations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has issued a show-cause notice to the management of a private school in Janakpuri over alleged child safety failures, unauthorised operations and serious financial irregularities, while proposing a government takeover of the institution if its response is found unsatisfactory.

The Directorate of Education has given the school seven days to submit its reply. If the management fails to provide a satisfactory explanation, the government plans to initiate action that includes taking over the school's management, recommending cancellation of its land lease and seeking criminal proceedings against those responsible.

Education Minister Ashish Sood directed the Directorate of Education to take the strongest possible action against the school's managing trust and leadership. He said the Delhi Government has zero tolerance for any compromise on the safety and dignity of children. He stated that schools have both a legal and moral responsibility to protect students and warned



that institutions involved in serious violations would face strict action.

The action follows a multi-phase inquiry conducted by specialised committees of the Directorate of Education. According to the government, the investigation found serious administrative, financial, and child protection failures at the school.

The inquiry found that a nursery student was allegedly sexually assaulted inside the school's pre-primary wing on April 30, 2026. The government alleged that the school management did not report the incident to the Directorate of Education despite mandatory child protection requirements.

Officials also stated that when police visited the pre-

primary branch to investigate the incident, all 64 CCTV cameras installed at the premises were non-functional. The government alleged that the surveillance system had not been maintained because the school had not renewed its maintenance contract. The inspection further found that the school had been operating its nursery and kindergarten classes from a residential building in Narang Colony without approval. The basement of the same building was reportedly being used as an activity area for children.

According to the Directorate of Education, the school did not have a Child Protection Policy, a Child Protection Committee or a POC SO trained nodal officer.

CM seeks blessings at Kashi Vishwanath Temple on her birthday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta marked her birthday on Sunday with a visit to the Kashi Vishwanath Temple, where she performed a water-offering ritual (Jalabhishek) at the sanctum along with her family. She later visited the Kal Bhairav shrine, regarded as the guardian deity of the holy city, to seek blessings.

During her visit, the Chief Minister prayed for the happiness, health, and prosperity of citizens across the country. She also offered prayers for the nation's continued growth and progress in the coming years.

Speaking after the temple visit, the Chief Minister called it a deeply



personal and moving experience. She said performing the ritual at the temple alongside her family members on her birthday was a rare privilege she would always cherish.

The Chief Minister described Varanasi as one of the most significant spiritual centres in the country, calling it a living symbol of India's cultural and religious traditions rather than just a historic city. She said the atmosphere in the city reflects deep devotion, with faith visible in every-day life there.

The Chief Minister said the temple and its surroundings have long served as a source of strength for devotees who visit from across the country and beyond.

She added that the city continues to hold spiritual significance for mil-

lions of people who see it as central to their faith.

Talking about her experience at the temple complex, the Chief Minister said the renovated corridor connecting the Ganga riverfront to the temple has enhanced the overall experience for visitors. She noted that the chanting and devotional atmosphere around the temple reflect an unbroken tradition of faith that has continued in the city for centuries.

She said the spiritual environment in Varanasi motivates people to work towards service and dedication, both towards their communities and the nation. The Chief Minister added that such places continue to inspire people to contribute meaningfully to public life.

Govt caps cash withdrawal at ₹1,000 under Lakshmi Yojana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Women under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana will be allowed to withdraw only ₹1,000 of the promised ₹2,500 monthly assistance, with the remaining ₹1,500 mandatorily going to a recurring deposit (RD) account, a Government official said on Sunday.

The recurring deposit will have a three-year lock-in period, after which the accu-

mulated amount, along with the interest earned, will be credited to the beneficiary's bank account, he said.

The savings component is aimed at helping women build a financial cushion for the future, the official said.

The proposal for the scheme is yet to receive Cabinet approval.

The Delhi Government recently finalised the eligibility criteria for the scheme, renamed Delhi Lakshmi Yojana from its earlier name,



Mahila Samridhi Yojana.

The proposal will be placed before the cabinet and then sent to the lieutenant governor for approval before notification.

The official said the Government is planning to launch the scheme around Raksha Bandhan and is likely to place the proposal before the next Cabinet meeting.

An online portal has also been readied, he said.

Under the norms proposed, applicants will have to submit a self-declaration stating they have been residents of Delhi for at least 10 years and have no criminal record. They must also furnish Aadhaar cards, voter

identity cards and family members' documents to establish eligibility, he added.

Only one woman aged between 21 and 60 from each household will be eligible under the scheme. Where more than one woman qualifies, only the eldest will receive the monthly assistance.

Applicants whose family members have criminal records will also be disqualified.

Man dies, wife critical after falling from rooftop following alleged argument in Gandhi Nagar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A post-dinner sleep on the rooftop of their four-storey house in Gandhi Nagar turned fatal, leaving the husband dead and his wife in critical condition, following family allegations of the couple arguing on the terrace right before the fall. The family members described that an argument had happened between the couple shortly before the fall.

The deceased was identified as Varun Sharma. His

wife, Geeta, 29, is undergoing treatment at GTB Hospital, according to police. The couple lived with their family at Nanak Basti in Old Seelampur, under the jurisdiction of the Gandhi Nagar police station in East Delhi, a senior police officer said.

According to a preliminary police investigation, the couple had dinner with their family around 9 pm on Saturday and later went up to sleep on the rooftop of their house. Around 10 pm, family members heard the couple arguing on the terrace, fol-

lowed by the sound of someone falling, police said. When relatives rushed outside to check, they found both Varun and Geeta lying injured in the lane below the house.

The couple was immediately taken to the hospital, where doctors declared Varun brought dead. Geeta was referred to GTB Hospital due to the seriousness of her injuries, police said. Investigators said it has not yet been established whether the couple fell accidentally during the argument or



whether one of them pushed the other. A police officer said family members have not so far raised suspicions of

foul play but added that investigators are examining all possible angles before drawing conclusions.

Police said the case came to light after they received medico-legal case information from Dr Hedgewar Hospital, where Varun was brought dead by his brother, Arun Sharma. Geeta was also taken to the same hospital initially before being shifted to GTB Hospital because of the severity of her injuries.

According to police, Varun and Geeta were married in February 2019 and have a two-and-a-half-year-old son. Varun's body has been sent to GTB Hospital for a post-mortem examination, police

said, adding that further investigation into the circumstances of the fall is underway. Police have not yet disclosed what the argument between the couple was about, nor have they specified the exact nature of Geeta's injuries or her current medical condition beyond describing it as critical.

No case has been formally registered by police so far, based on the information available, and officers say further details will depend on the outcome of the post-mortem examination and

continuing inquiries with family members.

The incident has left the couple's young son without a parent for now, with Geeta remaining under treatment. Police have not indicated who is currently caring for the child. Officers investigating the case are expected to record statements from family members present in the house at the time of the incident, along with examining the terrace and the site of the fall, to determine the sequence of events leading up to the tragedy.

IN FOCUS



A girl holds a poster during a rally led by Shiv Sena (UBT) in support of activist Sonam Wangchuk's hunger strike in Mumbai on Sunday

PTI

Man booked for raping 14-year-old girl in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 14-year-old girl was allegedly raped by her father at their home in northwest Delhi's Jahangirpuri area, an officer said on Sunday. Police have registered a case under the relevant sections of the BNS and provisions of the POCSO Act. The accused, police said, remained absconding.

According to the FIR filed at Mahendra Park police station, the survivor said that on July 7, her father raped her when her mother and 10-year-old brother were away.

She alleged that he established forcible physical relations with her against her will and threatened to kill her and her mother if she revealed the incident to

anyone.

Police have booked the accused under Sections 64(2) (punishment for rape), 65(1) (rape) and 351(3) (criminal intimidation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, along with Section 6 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

The complainant resides with her mother and brother in Jahangirpuri, while her father lives at the Badli village. "The accused is on the run. Multiple teams have been formed to trace and apprehend him at the earliest," a senior police officer said.

Further investigation is underway. The survivor has been sent for medical examination, and her statement under Section 183 of the BNSS has been recorded, the officer added.

Akhilesh appeals for saving Jauhar University after demolition notice

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday urged the people to help stop the proposed demolition of buildings of Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Rampur, founded by party leader Azam Khan, and accused the BJP government of targeting the institution out of political vendetta.

The remarks come days after the Rampur Development Authority ordered the demolition of 38 of the university's 40 buildings, saying they were constructed without approval. The university has challenged the action, maintaining that the structures were built when the area was outside the Authority's jurisdiction.

In a post on X, the former Uttar Pradesh chief minister appealed to students, parents and people across the country to support efforts to save the university, describing it as a "temple of education".

He alleged that the BJP



Government was trying to make the university a victim of its "narrow politics" and was attempting to "bulldoze the dreams" of thousands of students and their parents.

Yadav said that if there were deficiencies in documentation, they should be rectified instead of demolishing the university.

He asserted that the institution served children from economically weaker sections who could not afford expensive private universities or education abroad.

He questioned whether the BJP had become "anti-youth" and claimed the gov-

ernment's actions reflected its "arrogance" rather than concern for students' future.

The SP chief alleged that the BJP was "against education" because educated people become aware of their rights and question injustice.

He also claimed that the action against Jauhar University was part of a "larger conspiracy" against students from all sections of society and accused the ruling party of pursuing a policy of political revenge.

Yadav, in another post on X, shared a copy of a purported order issued by Principal Secretary

(Housing) P Guruprasad in June this year providing a one-time window to regularise buildings constructed in development authority areas on the basis of maps approved by district panchayats.

The order fixes April 1, 2026 as the cut-off date and allows a 12-month period for regularisation. It says buildings conforming to the master plan and existing building by-laws, or otherwise capable of being regularised after verification, would be treated as valid.

Yadav said the BJP Government could, if it abandoned its "politics of vendetta", approve the map of Jauhar University in a day. He alleged that the government had used the same order to regularise thousands of buildings but was denying similar relief to the university, resulting in injustice to students and their families.

"The BJP should stop making excuses and save this temple of education," he said, adding that "prejudice is the most visible form of injustice."

Karnataka CM seeks central assistance as State braces for drought

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar on Sunday said the state was facing an alarming rainfall deficit, with reservoir levels dropping sharply.

He directed officials to treat drinking water security as the top priority while preparing for a possible drought declaration and seeking Central assistance.

Chairing a special Cabinet meeting followed by a nearly four-hour review with deputy commissioners, zilla panchayat chief executive officers and senior officials

from multiple departments, Shiva kumar said rainfall was nearly 60 per cent below normal in large parts of the state and instructed the administration to intensify field-level drought management measures. "We had a special Cabinet meeting to discuss the drought. Though it is Sunday, we held a four-hour meeting with all officers to review the situation. We should ensure that no one leaves the villages in search of work," the CM said, underlining the seriousness of the emerging drought situation.

Shivakumar said rainfall deficiency had been recorded in 178 taluks, with 158 receiv-



ing significantly below-normal rainfall, while the situation was particularly difficult in Vijayanagara district.

He said the state's reservoirs were in a worrying condition, with overall storage standing at only

about 40 per cent of the level recorded during the corresponding period last year.

"At present, the available water appears sufficient only for drinking purposes. There is no immediate problem with drinking water," he said,

adding that hydropower reservoirs had only around 20 per cent storage, while reservoirs in the Cauvery basin were about half full and those in the Krishna basin were at around 48 per cent.

The CM said the government had instructed officials to regulate water use carefully and continuously guide farmers on sowing decisions based on actual water availability. "Farmers should not be encouraged to sow crops without knowing whether irrigation water can be supplied, as that would create unnecessary hardship," he said.

Referring to Mandya dis-

trict, Shivakumar said only a limited quantity of Cauvery water had been released exclusively for drinking purposes. "I appeal to farmers there not to take up cultivation expecting irrigation water," he said.

The CM said groundwater levels had declined sharply across the state and water levels in tanks had also fallen significantly.

According to the review, 3,235 of the state's 3,817 minor irrigation tanks have less than 50 per cent storage, while 27,450 out of 32,504 Zilla Panchayat tanks also contain less than half their capacity.

Walkout sets tone for Monsoon Session

TMC rebel MP Sudip Bandyopadhyay, who attended the meeting along with Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, said they were invited and hence came representing the new party with 20 MPs. DMK, which is not part of the Congress led INDIA bloc, during the all party meeting urged the Government to come out with a clear formula on the Constitution amendment bill for providing 33 per cent reservation to women in Lok Sabha and state assemblies, asserting that the quota should be given on the current strength of the Lower House.

Birla urges consensus

At the meeting, members representing the Government and the opposition parties exchanged their views on the legislative and other businesses proposed to be taken up during the session. The members also suggested several matters of public importance and national concern for discussion during the course of the session. The BAC took note of the suggestions. The scheduling of discussions and allocation of time for various items of business will be finalised in accordance with the established parliamentary procedures and in consultation with the Government and leaders of the opposition parties, another official said. The Speaker expressed confidence that all members would work collectively to ensure a productive and dignified Monsoon Session in the larger public interest.

After the meeting, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said important bills that have been submitted by the Government have been allocated time. "The opposition has also made some suggestions, which we have noted. We have appealed to the opposition that when Parliament meets tomorrow morning, there should be no turmoil. If the opposition does not create turmoil, some bills will be taken up for discussion tomorrow," Rijiju said. Some bills are ready to be introduced, for which time has been allocated, the minister said.

Deputy leader of Congress in Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi said the opposition has clearly conveyed that it will offer constructive participation and support for the Government's bills, but in return, it expects the Government to demonstrate its moral responsibility and provide answers on critical public issues.

Among others, the BAC meeting was attended by rebel Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar.

Delhi HC backs Govt on Wangchuk shift

Angmo, present in court, expressed a loss of trust in Safdarjung Hospital and stated her preference to transfer Wangchuk to a facility where he would be more comfortable. In her petition, Angmo stated that despite repeated requests, the Safdarjung authorities disclosed only selective information to her and did not allow Wangchuk's transfer, thereby preventing independent veri-

fication of his condition. It was achieved clandestinely, despite Wangchuk's vital parameters being stable at the time of his removal from the protest site.

Justice Mini Pushkarna, during a special hearing on Sunday, noted that doctors at Safdarjung Hospital were monitoring Wangchuk and that no force was being used against him. "Since the Government has decided to shift Mr Sonam Wangchuk to a hospital on account of his medical condition, this court does not find the same to be an arbitrary action. Since the doctors at Safdarjung hospital are closely monitoring the health of Mr Sonam Wangchuk and have only administered oral fluids, potassium chloride and oral ORS without sugar with his consent, it cannot be said that any force is being used or that his bodily autonomy is being violated in any manner," the court stated. "No interim orders are required to be passed by the court at the present stage," the court added.

Additional Solicitor General (ASG) Chetan Sharma argued the Government was duty-bound to admit Wangchuk to a hospital due to his critical condition requesting the court to direct Wangchuk to cooperate with the doctors. "Needless to state that Mr Sonam Wangchuk will cooperate with the doctors in administering whatever medical intervention if necessary, in the circumstances, if he so chooses," the court responded. Justice Pushkarna said Wangchuk's wife, brother, and brother-in-law have been given continuous access to him at the hospital including being given a room.

Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, representing the petitioner, stated that they sought Wangchuk's transfer to Medanta Hospital, with the inclusion of Safdarjung doctors as part of the medical team there. He asserted that no order could force Wangchuk to accept treatment and noted that the July 16 order was issued ex parte. Wangchuk was not in detention and remained a free citizen. Sibal questioned whether an individual could be denied admission to a hospital of their choice. He also objected to the presence of police personnel near Wangchuk's room.

Doctors from Safdarjung Hospital and AIIMS briefed the court on Wangchuk's medical condition. The court issued notices to the Government, Safdarjung Hospital and the Delhi Police on Angmo's petition and asked them to respond within three days. The next hearing is scheduled for July 24.

Capital on high alert ahead of Parliament...

These security steps are common during Parliament sessions, when more activity from various groups is expected in the Capital.

A senior police source described the operation: "Elaborate preventive arrangements have been made to ensure law and order during the Parliament session. Every vehicle entering the New Delhi district is being thoroughly checked. Additional pickets have been set up at strategic locations and reserve forces have been kept on standby. CCTV surveillance has also been intensified across sensitive areas." Security is tighter around Jantar Mantar, Parliament Street, Central

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Vista, Connaught Place, Shankar Chowk and other important sites.

These steps follow new developments at Jantar Mantar, where CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke is still on an indefinite hunger strike. On Saturday, activist Sonam Wangchuk was shifted by the Delhi Police to Safdarjung Hospital. From the hospital, Wangchuk called on supporters to join the July 20 march.

Police have reiterated that all protests must follow the law and that no unauthorised gatherings will be allowed in high-security areas.

Authorities are monitoring the situation to prevent escalation and have arranged for medical support if necessary. Police have stated that measures are in place to maintain order and security in the Capital.

Ram temple trust, RSS set to meet over...

As per the agenda circulated by Krishna Mohan in a letter to the trustees on July 7, the July 22 meeting will take up confirmation of proceedings of the July 6 meeting as well as the special meeting at 3 pm the same day.

The July 6 meeting was the first Trust meeting after the alleged embezzlement of donations came to light. During that meeting, the Trust constituted a special committee to recommend amendments to the Trust deed and framed guidelines for the custody, valuation and disposal of offerings made by devotees.

The proposed discussion on the SIT's final report assumes significance as the State Government had ordered an inquiry into the embezzlement of donations received at the temple. The controversy has triggered administrative and legal action, with the probe expected to be a key issue before the trustees.

The VHP and RSS, both of which played pivotal roles in the Ram Jannabhoomi movement, view the current situation as a challenge requiring collective intervention by the wider Hindu spiritual community. Sources said that several decisions are expected at the July 23 VHP-RSS meeting. One main proposal is to appoint Krishna Mohan, currently the acting general secretary of the Shri Ram Jannabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, as the permanent general secretary.

By convening seers at Mani Ram Chhavni, a site associated with Mahant Nritya Gopal Das, president of the trust, the RSS and the VHP aim to plan their response. The participation of seers in the July 23 conference is expected to lend credibility to the trust's efforts to navigate the controversy. Sources suggest the conference may also discuss measures to strengthen financial oversight, improve communication with devotees and reinforce public confidence in the institution.

J&K worst hit as monsoon unleashes...

In West Bengal, the Indian Meteorological Department (IMD) has predicted heavy rainfall in the northern districts over the next two days,

India needs new anti-defection law, says MP Manish Tewari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Congress MP Manish Tewari stated that the top priority of the upcoming Monsoon Session, which begins on Monday, should be for Parliament to set aside all other business and consider the urgent need for a new anti-defection law.

The Chandigarh MP said on Sunday that the current composition of the Lok Sabha no longer aligns with the mandate given by the people during the 2024 parliamentary elections.

"Look, the fundamental point is that in 2024, the people gave a mandate, and the Lok Sabha was constituted in accordance with that mandate. Today, two years later, the composition of the Lok Sabha is no longer in line with that mandate. It is contrary to the people's mandate," he said.

Tewari argued that the foremost priority of this Monsoon Session should be for Parliament to halt all other work and discuss whether a new anti-defection law is necessary.

He highlighted the need to



end the opportunistic politics often referred to as "Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram", where politicians switch parties without regard to ideological or policy differences.

Additionally, Tewari mentioned the importance of identifying and highlighting genuine ideological or policy differences.

"A balance needs to be struck both inside and outside Parliament and the State Assemblies, because all these recent developments have worked to weaken Indian democracy," the MP said.

Parliament's Monsoon Session begins on Monday and will continue till August 13.

warning of possible landslides in the hilly areas and flash floods in low-lying areas of the region. The IMD said that water levels may rise in some rivers in the region, including Teesta, Torsa, Jaldhaka and Raidak, as incessant rain continued to batter the north Bengal districts of Darjeeling, Kalimpong, Jalpaiguri, Alipurduar and Cooch Behar since Saturday.

According to the IMD, extremely heavy rain is likely in the districts of Jalpaiguri and Alipurduar, and very heavy rain in the other sub-Himalayan districts. District authorities in Reasi, Rajouri and Poonch of J&K have appealed to residents to stay away from rivers and low-lying areas as rescue and restoration work continues.

The ongoing Amarnath Yatra and pilgrim traffic to the Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine have been suspended due to inclement weather. Authorities have urged pilgrims and locals to exercise caution. Officials prohibited onward movement from the Baltal and Nunwan, Chandanwari base camps in the Kashmir region, and the Bhagwat Nagar Yatri Niwas in Jammu.

CM Omar Abdullah, who was in Delhi for a proposed statehood protest, cut short his visit and returned to Jammu in the afternoon to oversee relief and rescue operations in the division. He also chaired a meeting here in the civil secretariat to take stock of the prevailing situation and other relief and rescue measures. The worst devastation has been reported from Surankote tehsil in Poonch district, where eight members of a family were feared dead. The neighbouring Rajouri district was also hit hard due to flash floods in the Darhall river.

While bodies of five persons, including a two-year-old boy Sofian Yasar were retrieved from the debris, a search operation was continuing to trace the remaining missing persons, the officials said.

Four members of another family were reported missing after their house was washed away by flash floods at Sangla village, they said, adding the missing persons include Abdul Hameed, his wife Sharifa Begum, daughter Areeba and sister Manira Begum. A 28-year-old woman, Nazia Kousar, was killed when her house collapsed in Noonabandi village. Her husband, Mohd Hafiz, and three children, aged between two and six years, were rescued with injuries and shifted to a hospital, officials said.

Shahzaib Ahmad (22) lost his life when his house collapsed at Sanglani-Surankote, while a minor girl identified as Iram drowned in a stream at Marhote. An unidentified body of a woman was also fished out from a stream near Dhundak Lathoong bridge, officials said.

One person was killed and another critically injured following collapse of nearly half a dozen houses in Haveli tehsil of Poonch district, the officials said. They said the body of a woman was also fished out from a river in Rajouri town, which was hit by flash floods following incessant overnight rainfall, forcing hundreds of residents to move to safer locations as floodwaters inundated low-lying areas.

Deputy Commissioner, Rajouri, Abhishek Sharma visited several flood-affected areas along with senior police and district administration officers. He said the rescue and relief teams, assisted by the local administration, were

engaged in evacuating affected families and assessing the damage, while local Congress MLA Ifthkar Ahmad said there was heavy damage to public and private property in the flash floods.

In Jammu, Police and the NDRF safely rescued a group of youths stranded in the middle of the Tawi River. The rescue team brought everyone safely without any casualties. Heavy rainfall in the region also triggered a massive landslide near the temple at Narsu on the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway. At least six shops were buried in the area. A major landslide also hit the Bandipora-Gurez road after a cloudburst.

Learn one more Indian language, Shah urges...

Referring to his three-day visit to the state, Shah said the Union and the State Government had held detailed discussions on governance and security. "We have discussed and taken several steps to stop infiltration, strengthen law and order and improve women's safety," he said.

Earlier, the Union home minister reviewed West Bengal's law and order, and border security system in a high-level meeting with Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari and senior senior bureaucrats including State Chief Secretary Manoj Agarwal, Home secretary Sanghamitra Ghosh, Director General of Police Siddh Nath Gupta, and IGP (CID) N R Babu.

MP Cabinet nod for UCC

The Bill also proposes a complete ban on polygamy and multiple marriages across communities and seeks to declare practices such as *nikah halala* illegal and punishable under law.

After the meeting, talking to mediapersons, the CM said, "The Uniform Civil Code reflects the principle of equality rooted in Indian culture and constitutional values. I congratulate my Cabinet colleagues and the people of Madhya Pradesh. The Bill is now ready to be introduced in the Assembly."

The proposed legislation aims to replace separate personal laws governing matters such as marriage, divorce, maintenance, inheritance, adoption, succession and live-in relationships with a uniform legal framework applicable to all citizens, except members of STs.

The draft was prepared by a Government-appointed committee headed by retired Supreme Court judge Ranjana Prakash Desai. The multi-member panel was tasked with examining existing personal laws and family-related legal practices before framing recommendations suited to Madhya Pradesh's social, cultural and economic conditions. The committee recommended that STs (Adivasis) be kept outside the ambit of the proposed law, taking into account constitutional safeguards and existing customary practices. It also emphasised gender equality while ensuring that religious ceremonies, traditional customs and cultural practices remain unaffected.

The Bill will now be introduced in the Assembly, where it will be debated and considered before being put to vote. If passed, Madhya Pradesh will become one of the few states to enact a UCC, following Uttarakhand, which implemented a similar law earlier.

CBI conducts multi-State searches in ₹1,109 cr Canara Bank fraud case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) carried out coordinated searches at six locations across four States, West Bengal, Odisha, Tamil Nadu, and Uttarakhand, on July 18, 2026, in connection with an alleged bank fraud of ₹1,109 crore involving M/S Gupta Power Infrastructure Ltd., a Bhubaneswar-based company. The case involves the alleged fraud against Canara Bank through various financial facilities extended to the company.

The CBI says the firm manipulated its stock values, inflated trade receivables, and falsified its financial Statements to obtain additional credit from the bank.

It is also alleged that the loan funds were siphoned off and used for other purposes.

The company is accused of evergreening, which means taking new loans or credit to pay off old dues and avoid having the accounts marked as non-performing assets.

These actions are believed



to have caused significant losses to Canara Bank.

The searches were carried out under warrants from the Court of the Special Judge, CBI, Bhubaneswar.

The operation covered the homes of four accused directors in Bhubaneswar, the company's registered office in Kolkata, and three manufacturing units in Kashipur (Udham Singh Nagar district),

Tiruvallur (Tamil Nadu), and Bhubaneswar (Odisha). Raiding multiple States at once was meant to match the company's wide operations and to prevent any evidence from being tampered with.

During the searches, CBI teams found several incriminating documents.

Investigators are now reviewing these materials, which could help uncover

the alleged financial irregularities and the diversion of funds. Seizing documents from homes, offices, and factories is important because it may help trace the company's transactions and decisions.

This is part of the CBI's work to investigate and prosecute major economic crimes that affect the banking sector.

The coordinated raids show the agency's ability to handle complex investigations across different States.

The company works in power infrastructure and has factories in several regions. It seems to have taken large loans from the bank.

By allegedly manipulating stock values and receivables, the company may have made its financial position appear better than it was, which could have led the bank to extend more credit than it deserved.

If these claims are proven, they show weaknesses in how banks check and monitor loans. The investigation is still ongoing. So far, no arrests have been made in this case.

Multi-agency security drill held at Parliament ahead of Monsoon Session

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A multi-agency mock drill was conducted by a joint team of security forces deployed at the Parliament House complex on Sunday ahead of Monsoon session. The session will begin on Monday and is scheduled to conclude on August 13.

The overall security of the complex, located in central Delhi, is rendered by the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) along with units of the Delhi Police, CRPF, NSG, NDRF and the security staff of the Parliament. CISF Director General Praveer Ranjan visited the Parliament House and reviewed the operational preparedness for the Monsoon session, the force said.

"The DG chaired a Sainik Sammelan, interacted with personnel, felicitated outstanding performers and emphasised continuous skill upgradation and the highest standards of CBRN (Chemical, Biological, Radiological and Nuclear) preparedness."

"The DG also called on



the Hon'ble Speaker, Lok Sabha and the Secretary-General, Lok Sabha, to review security arrangements," the CISF said in a social media post.

As part of the preparedness, the post added, a multi-agency mock drill involving various security forces and agencies apart from other stakeholders was conducted to validate the response mechanisms and strengthen inter-agency coordination.

The CISF was entrusted with the security of the Parliament in May 2024. The paramilitary functions under the command of the Union home ministry.

In a separate development, the force said in a Statement that it seized about 1,800 metrics tonnes

of coal in the last three weeks as part of a special operation conducted by it in coalfields of West Bengal and Jharkhand to curb the theft and pilferage of the precious fossil fuel.

"The CISF seized 1,798.72 metric tonnes of illegally mined, stored or transported coal worth approximately Rs 1.08 crore during intensive operations conducted across coalfields under its security cover over the last three weeks," an official Statement said.

The force also seized 84 vehicles, including heavy-duty trucks and modified motorcycles used for illegal transportation of coal, and filed 21 direct complaints against persons involved in illegal mining and coal smuggling.

Punjab BJP plays AAP Govt over law and order, says citizens feel unsafe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Punjab BJP president Kewal Singh Dhillon on Sunday accused the Aam Aadmi Party Government of pushing the State into "fear, lawlessness and financial bankruptcy", alleging a complete collapse of law and order under the Bhagwant Mann-led dispensation.

In a Statement, Dhillon claimed that the Punjab Government was being run through "remote control" by AAP's national convener Arvind Kejriwal from Delhi.

Referring to the recent daylight robbery of a street vendor in Nabha, he said such incidents reflected the deteriorating law and order situation in Punjab.

Cases of chain-snatching, theft and robbery have become routine and criminals were openly targeting people's hard-earned money, he alleged, adding that citizens, women and traders no longer felt safe in the State.

Govt to bring bill in RS to make insult to Vande Mataram criminal offence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government intends to bring a bill in the Rajya Sabha to make any obstruction or insult to the national song 'Vande Mataram' a criminal offence on Monday, the first day of the Monsoon Session of Parliament.

The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, has been listed in the agenda of the Rajya Sabha for Monday, with Home Minister Amit Shah set to introduce the bill.

The bill will amend the Prevention of Insults to



National Honour Act, 1971, which makes desecration of or disrespect toward the country's national symbols — including the national flag, the Constitution, and the national anthem — a criminal offence, carrying a punishment of up to three years'

imprisonment.

The bill seeks to give 'Vande Mataram', the national song, the same statutory protection as the national anthem, 'Jana Gana Mana'.

According to the provisions of the bill, any act causing obstruction in the singing of the national song or causing insult to it in any form would be made punishable.

The Government's push to accord the national song the same status as the national anthem comes amid the year-long celebrations of the 150th anniversary of 'Vande Mataram'.

GRAPEVINE

Have your cake and eat it too

A difference of opinion cropped up within the Congress in lending support 'openly' to the CJP protest, coupled with a hunger strike by climate activist Sonam Wangchuk at Jantar Mantar. While the grand old party maintained restraint in being vocal about the CJP and Wangchuk, the protestors received support from several political parties from the opposition side, including the Samajwadi Party. Grapevine has it that Priyanka Gandhi too expressed a desire to visit Jantar Mantar last week, but the Rahul Gandhi camp is understood to have prevented Priyanka from attending the protest. She was conditioned to hold back to avoid politicising as the party had conflicting narratives on the issue, as Rahul himself is leading several protest rallies in support of students, alleged paper leaks, etc. Congress, however, dispatched an emissary in the newly elected Rajya Sabha MP Pawan Khera, who also heads the grand old party's media and publicity wing.



Atmanirbhar assembly in India!

Grapevine is abuzz with the claims of Civil Aviation Minister Rammohan Naidu posting photo of C-295 Air Force Transport flight as Made in India. Fact was the Airbus model was assembled in Vadodara by Tata as part of the deal signed in 2021 with Airbus. People wonder why Civil Aviation Minister made such a claim on Air Force contract of assembling of transport flight in India. Official reports suggest that aircraft is being produced under \$ 2.6 Billion agreement with 16 delivered from Spain and 40 to be assembled at Vadodara facility as part of Make in India programme and the first assembled C-295 under this scheme was rolled on June 10.



Musical chairs at PHQ

Delhi Police Headquarters, popularly known as PHQ, is buzzing louder than a PCR wireless set, and a sudden change of guards has left several top cops gasping and scrambling for new chairs. One transfer order in the morning, and just like that, corridors that were "VIP zones" last week are now cold. Sources say the shake-up wasn't just routine. Some commissioners were reportedly caught off guard, learning about their postings from WhatsApp forwards before the official file landed. Tea was spilt, egos bruised. The grapevine in Darya Ganj is working overtime: Who's now suddenly "very close to the brass"? For now, nameplates are being changed, assistants are running with files, and everyone's smiling a little too widely in the elevators. In Delhi Police, peace never lasts. The next reshuffle is probably already drafted.



SC to decide fate of passport and visa services at key Indian missions



ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is set to hear on Monday a crucial appeal by the Centre challenging a Delhi High Court order that has thrown passport, visa, and consular services at Indian missions in Abu Dhabi, Kuwait, Singapore, and Canberra into uncertainty, affecting millions of Indians living abroad.

The Delhi High Court on July 15 cancelled the contract awarded to Kerala-based Alhind Tours & Travels for managing Consular, Passport and Visa (CPV) services at these four missions. The court ruled that the bid evaluation process was arbitrary and failed to adequately consider national security implications, despite objections from the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, representing the Centre, informed a Supreme Court bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Friday that the High Court's decision had rendered services at these missions "almost dysfunctional." He argued that a new operator cannot begin work immediately, prompting the apex court to list the matter for hearing on July 20.

The disruption is particularly severe for the large Indian diaspora. In the UAE alone, around 4.5 million Indians could be affected, along with applicants in Kuwait, Singapore, and Australia. Services impacted include passport renewals, Overseas Citizen of India (OCI) card processing, and other essential consular assistance.

VIKSIT BHARAT STARTS WITH YOU, SUBMIT YOUR ITR ON TIME

LAST DATE

Individual & HUF filing ITR-1* or ITR 2*

31

JULY 2026

Assessment Year: 2026-2027 | Financial Year: 2025-2026

Note: The Income Tax Return (ITR) for the Assessment Year 2026–27 will be filed under the Income Tax Act, 1961.

Important Notice

- File your ITR on the e-filing portal (eportal.incometax.gov.in).
- It is mandatory to file ITR 2 & Schedule FA/FSI if you have a foreign bank account, asset or income.

BENEFITS OF FILING ITR IN TIME

Avoid late fees and interest by filing your ITR on time.

ITR can be revised

FOR QUICK REFUNDS

Must check your AIS/TIS/26AS before filing your return

Do not claim incorrect deductions or exemptions

Provide accurate details of your income

Taxpayers should ensure that their mobile number, address, email ID, and bank details provided on the e-filing portal are correct and updated, as the Income Tax Department communicates through these registered contact details.

* ITR-1: For individuals being a resident (other than not ordinarily resident) having total income upto Rs.50 lakh and having Income from Salaries, two house properties, other sources (Interest etc.), long-term capital gains under section 112A up to Rs. 1.25 lakh, and agricultural income up to Rs.5 thousand.

* ITR-2: For Individuals and HUFs not having income from profits and gains of business or profession.

For more information and assistance, visit the Kar Saathi Chatbot on the Income Tax Department website: www.incometaxindia.gov.in

Income Tax Department
Government of India

For more information, please visit www.incometaxindia.gov.in

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States Focus



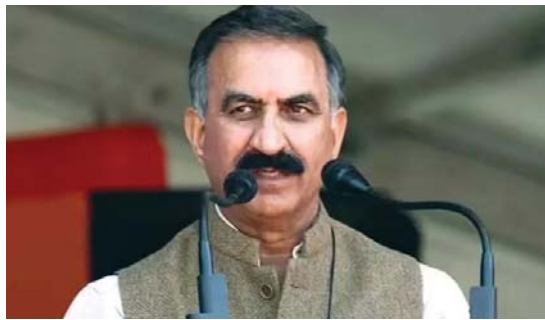
Bihar CM inaugurates 551 model schools, announces Dinkar varsity

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Sunday inaugurated 551 Saraswati Vidya Niketan model schools across the State, saying that his Government's goal is to ensure every child has access to technology-enabled and value-based education.

The CM virtually inaugurated the schools from a function in Begusarai and described the initiative as a historic milestone in the State's education sector.

Addressing the gathering, Choudhary said education is the greatest strength of a developed society and asserted that the State Government was carrying out comprehensive reforms to transform school education.

"Our objective is to create a learning environment where every child has access to modern, high-quality, technology-enabled and value-based education," he said. (PTI)



New industrial policy underway, will offer cheap power: CM Sukhu

Himachal Pradesh ensures round-the-clock power supply to industries and will soon introduce a new industrial policy with a provision of reduced electricity tariffs to attract more investment in the State, Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu said.

He was addressing the Chandigarh Leadership Conclave and the 23rd Annual General Meeting organised by TiE (The Indus Entrepreneurs Chandigarh) on Saturday, a statement issued here on Sunday said.

The chief minister said that the State Government was committed to providing every possible facility and support to investors and was poised to emerge as a national leader in green hydrogen production in the coming years. (PTI)

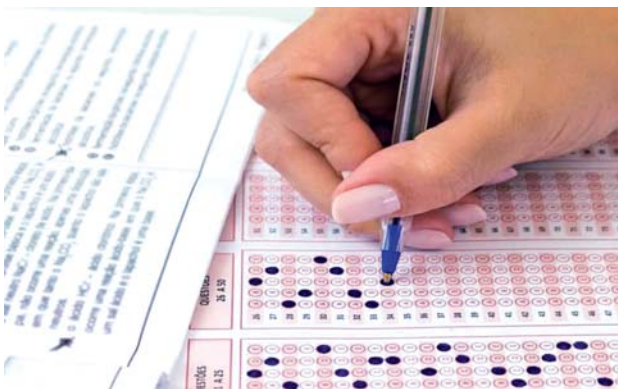
NTA warns NEET 2026 candidates against submitting fake, AI-generated OMR sheets

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Testing Agency (NTA) has issued an advisory to NEET-UG 2026 candidates and their parents, warning them not to submit fake or AI-generated OMR sheets when raising complaints about score discrepancies.

The warning comes after the NTA reviewed several complaints regarding differences between candidates' expected and declared NEET 2026 scores. During the verification process, the agency found that many of the OMR sheets submitted with complaints appeared to be fake or created using artificial intelligence (AI).

"NTA is closely monitoring and scrutinising all complaints. In the wake of many OMR sheets submitted for scrutiny turning out to be



fake/AI-generated, students and parents are advised to submit only original OMRs for scrutiny. Any fake/AI-generated OMR may invite legal action against the complainant," the agency said in an advisory. The results for the medical entrance were announced on July 16, with 11.21 lakh candidates qualifying the exam.

The NTA cancelled the May 3 exam on May 12 amid allegations of a paper leak; the CBI is investigating the matter, and the exam was re-conducted on June 21.

Following the controversy over the paper leak and alleged irregularities in the exam process, the Centre announced that the exam will

now be conducted as a computer-based test (CBT) instead of pen-and-paper mode.

Detailed deliberations have been ongoing for several years between the education and health ministries on whether to conduct NEET-UG in pen-and-paper or online mode.

The National Eligibility cum Entrance Test-Undergraduate (NEET-UG) is the country's largest undergraduate entrance exam, with nearly 25 lakh candidates registering annually. The NTA conducts the test every year for admission into medical colleges, where 108,000 seats are available for the MBBS course. Of these, approximately 56,000 are in Government hospitals and about 52,000 are in private colleges. Undergraduate courses in dentistry, Ayurveda, Unani and Siddha also utilise NEET results for admissions.

IAF begins Exercise Pitch Black 2026 at RAAF Base Darwin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Air Force (IAF) starts Exercise Pitch Black 2026 on Monday at the Royal Australian Air Force (RAAF) Base Darwin. Scheduled from July 20 to August 7, Exercise Pitch Black is the RAAF's premier biennial multinational air combat exercise, defence ministry said here on Sunday.

The exercise derives its name from its emphasis on night flying over the vast, unpopulated areas of northern Australia. In the exercise's 45-year-long history, this edition features a large number of participating forces, bringing together military personnel for complex large force employment and multinational air combat operations.

The IAF contingent com-



prises highly skilled Air Warriors, including pilots, engineers, technicians, controllers and other subject-matter experts. The contingent will operate the Rafale multirole fighter aircraft, supported by the C-17 Globemaster-III and the IL-78 Air-to-Air Refuelling aircraft in combat support roles.

The exercise will provide the participating forces with a valuable opportunity to

enhance interoperability, strengthen force integration and exchange operational best practices towards a collaborative conduct of operations in global scenarios.

Exercise Pitch Black 26 provides an excellent opportunity to validate expeditionary air operations over extended distances, enhance multinational interoperability and strengthen professional partnerships across the Indo-

Pacific region.

The exercise will enable participating air forces to operate in a realistic and challenging multinational environment, fostering greater operational synergy and mutual understanding. The IAF has previously participated in the 2018, 2022 and 2024 editions of the exercise, reaffirming its commitment to strengthening defence cooperation and regional security.

Mahua Moitra slams Govt for inviting rebel TMC MPs to all-party meet



TMC leader Mahua Moitra speaks to the media during an all-party meeting convened by the Government ahead of Parliament's Monsoon Session in New Delhi on Sunday

PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Trinamool Congress leader Mahua Moitra on Sunday questioned the Government's decision to invite rebel TMC MPs to an all-party meeting on the Monsoon Session of Parliament and said it went out of its way "to recognise them" when the Lok Sabha Speaker has not yet decided on their status.

Moitra also made it clear that her party could approach the court if Speaker Om Birla does not disqualify the 20 "traitor" MPs. "Today, all opposition parties led by the TMC staged a walkout in protest against the Parliamentary Affairs Minister's decision to invite the NCPI, which is an unrecognised party of 20 TMC traitors.

"The Speaker has not approved any merger. The TMC has filed 20 disqualification petitions, which are still pending. That has not been decided yet," she told reporters after emerging from the all-party meeting here.

As many as 20 out of 28 TMC MPs revolted against the TMC leadership following its defeat in assembly elections in West

Bengal and joined the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI).

Rebel TMC MPs Sudip Bandyopadhyay and Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar attended the all-party meeting, drawing protests from the opposition parties, which staged a symbolic walkout. The opposition members later returned to participate in the meeting.

Moitra contended that the strength of the TMC "continues to be 28 MPs" and, if that is the case, on what basis the rebels were invited for the all-party meeting.

"The Speaker has neither approved the merger nor decided on our disqualification petitions. Then how can the parliamentary affairs minister invite them, decide to grant them this recognition. He has done it on his own, outside the office of the Speaker," she said. Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju, however, defended the decision. "The NCPI requested recognition from the Lok Sabha Speaker; how can you ignore them? It is the Government's duty to invite everyone," Rijiju told reporters after the meeting.

President Murmu begins three-nation Europe tour

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Sunday embarked on State visits to Moldova, North Macedonia, and Romania to deepen India's ties with the three European countries across a range of sectors, including trade and technology, and to boost people-to-people ties. The first leg of her tour begins with a visit to Moldova on Monday, marking the first-ever visit by an Indian President to the Eastern European nation.

Shortly after her departure, the Rashtrapati Bhavan posted a message on social media, saying, "President Droupadi Murmu

embarks on State visits to the Republic of Moldova, the Republic of North Macedonia and Romania."

"This is the first-ever visit by an Indian President to Moldova and North Macedonia. The visit to Romania by the President of India is taking place after a gap of over three decades," it said. Murmu will hold delegation-level talks with Moldovan President Maia Sandu and meet the President of the Parliament, Igor Grosu.

She is also scheduled to interact with members of the Moldova-India Parliamentary Friendship Group, address a Business Forum, and meet with members of the Indian community.



President Droupadi Murmu being greeted as she embarks on State visits to Moldova, North Macedonia and Romania

PTI

According to a statement issued by the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Friday, India and Moldova enjoy warm and friendly relations and Murmu's visit would mark a significant and historical milestone and elevate

bilateral ties to a broad-based partnership. "There is good scope for mutually beneficial cooperation in the areas of agriculture, healthcare and pharmaceuticals, IT and education," it said.

At the invitation of the

President Gordana Siljanovska-Davkova, Murmu will visit North Macedonia from July 21 to 22, becoming the first Indian president to travel to the country. Murmu will hold bilateral talks with President Siljanovska-Davkova, meet Prime Minister Hristijan Mickoski, the President of the Assembly and also address the Assembly of North Macedonia.

She will also address the India-North Macedonia Business Forum. Both sides have a keen interest in deepening economic ties in priority sectors such as agriculture, pharmaceuticals, science and technology, Information Technology, and IT-enabled Services.

Fight should now be launched to change Govt that is not accountable: Uddhav

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Sunday attacked the BJP-led Centre, saying a fight should now be launched to change a Government that is not accountable. Addressing a rally in Mumbai, he accused the Government of stealing the future of the youth, referring to alleged irregularities in the NEET exam and student suicides tied to it, which have prompted activist Sonam Wangchuk to launch a hunger strike.



The criticism of the Government by Thackeray, whose party recently saw six of its Lok Sabha MPs switching over to the rival Shiv Sena, led by Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde, came on the eve of Parliament's monsoon session.

"A fight should now be launched to change a

Government that is not accountable. And this fight is not just about Sonam Wangchuk," he said. Thackeray asked how Wangchuk, who built solar tents for soldiers working in sub-zero temperatures and created ice stupas to address water woes in Ladakh, can be described as "anti-national".

He said the erstwhile UPA Government led by the then prime minister Manmohan Singh sent a delegation to hold talks with social activist Anna Hazare when he was on an indefinite hunger strike in 2011.

Jitendra Singh calls for nationwide Jan Andolan against lifestyle diseases

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Calling for a nationwide People's Movement (*Jan Andolan*) against cancer, diabetes, obesity and other lifestyle diseases, Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science & Technology and Earth Sciences, Jitendra Singh, on Sunday said India's response to these diseases must move beyond hospitals and become a mass public movement.

It should be centred on early detection, right medical

advice and evidence-based healthcare, he added.

The Minister said the country today faces not merely a lack of awareness but also the challenge of widespread health misinformation, making scientific communication and evidence-based health communication more important than ever for realising the vision of Viksit Bharat.

He was addressing the launch of "UNBROKEN: My Battle with Cancer and the Will to Lead", authored by Cancer survivor, eminent



Scientist and former Senior Adviser, Department of Science & Technology, Akhilesh Gupta.

The event was attended by eminent medical professionals, academic and scientific fraternity, senior Government



devotees have offered their hard-earned money with faith at Shri Ram Mandir — the theft of donations there is no longer hidden from anyone. Every member of the trust was selected by your Government. Your silence on this donation theft is unacceptable."

"Conduct an independent investigation immediately, make the full accounting public, and bring the culprits to the dock of law. The credibility of your Government now depends on your actions," the leader of opposition in Lok Sabha said.

The alleged theft of donations offered at the Ram temple surfaced in the first week of June and has so far led to the arrest of eight people and the resignation of two senior functionaries

from the Ram temple trust.

On June 25, police registered an FIR in the case on a complaint by the Trust.

In their letter, both Gandhi and Kharge told the prime minister that he announced the Trust's formation in Parliament on the Supreme Court's directions, but its members were solely appointed by his Government. It is public knowledge that the Trust's members are affiliated with the RSS, VHP and its affiliates, the Congress leaders said, adding the Trust's former general secretary was also his close associate.

They also demanded that the findings and the Trust's accounts should be made public so that every devotee knows how their offerings have been utilised.

officials, researchers and members of the scientific community, who came together to celebrate Dr Gupta's remarkable journey of resilience after overcoming cancer.

Describing the book as much more than a personal memoir, Jitendra Singh said it chronicles an extraordinary journey of courage, resilience, integrity and unwavering faith in science.

Having read the book in its entirety, he said it offers important lessons not only for patients battling serious illnesses but also for doctors,

scientists, administrators and young professionals, demonstrating how determination and the right medical guidance can transform adversity into inspiration.

Referring to India's rapidly changing disease profile, Dr Jitendra Singh said non-communicable diseases have emerged as one of the country's biggest public health challenges. Cancer, diabetes, obesity, fatty liver disease and other metabolic disorders are rising across all regions and are increasingly affecting younger populations.

Kerala BJP faces allegations of siphoning election funds

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

BJP's Kerala unit is facing allegations of siphoning off election funds. Many committees of the BJP for the past two weeks have filed petitions to the BJP State President to conduct a probe against general secretary S Suresh and secretary MP Anjana, who was in charge of the Assembly election management. According to many party leaders, the fund siphoning has crossed more than ₹12 crores, which was meant to distribute to the campaign of candidates of BJP.

The allegations started pouring soon from party insiders, after the election was over, seeing the change of lifestyle of Suresh and Anjana. Major allegations were selling party flags to candidates and district units, which were delivered free of cost from BJP's central unit. The complaints filed by many party leaders say that the party flags were sold for more than ₹3 crores.

Media report that the BJP



Kerala BJP headquarters in Thiruvananthapuram

State unit has conducted an internal audit and found the allegations were true and is expected to submit the report to State president Rajeev Chandrasekhar on Monday. BJP leaders in the state unit in charge of the campaign are also facing allegations of siphoning off funds meant for media advertisements and social media campaign.

The complaints show that Anajana had deposited a lot of money in four banks to close her personal loans, soon after the elections. Anjana was also facing allegations for taking loans

from party controlled cooperative banks and non-payment of it. Recently, the president of a co-operative bank controlled by the BJP had committed suicide due to non-payment of huge loans by party colleagues. She purchased an expensive car, said the complaints filed to the state president and central leadership, seeking a probe against Anjana and Suresh.

Audio recordings had earlier emerged on the siphoning of party funds, meant for the road show of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, during the election

campaign. Many BJP leaders allege that general secretary Suresh is the real culprit, using Anjana as a cover. They point out that Suresh was from a poor family and is now living a luxurious lifestyle, having huge assets. The same is the case with his aide Anjana, who recently got plum posts in the party.

One recording reportedly contains a representative of a company that supplied party flags, confirming that the state secretary Anjana received a commission of ₹31 lakh for the purchase of flags. Another audio recording obtained by local media allegedly features a state committee member discussing how ₹16 lakh could be siphoned off by creating a fake bill. The complaints say that fake GST bills were also created, and a lot of fake bills were created for the use of helicopters and cars during the election campaign. Siphoning of funds happened across Kerala, especially in Thiruvananthapuram, Kollam, Kozhikode and Thirissur districts, say the complaints.

Himanta inspects proposed Assam cultural site in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday inspected the site earmarked for the proposed Assam Cultural-cum-Convention Centre and Naamghar at Dwarka Sector 17 in New Delhi.

The proposed project is aimed at fulfilling the long-standing aspiration of the large Assamese diaspora residing in Delhi-NCR and neighbouring areas by creating a dedicated cultural and community space in the national Capital.

Speaking to the media after the inspection, the Chief Minister said that the Government of Assam will establish a Naamghar — the Neo-Vaishnavite community prayer hall introduced by Srimanta Sankardeva and Madhavdeva — along with a modern Assam Cultural-cum-Convention Centre.

The proposed complex will serve as a vibrant hub for the Assamese community, providing a common platform to celebrate festivals, marriages, organise cultural, literary and social events, and strengthen the cultural bond among Assamese people living away from their home State.



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma

FILE PHOTO

It may be recalled that during his meeting with the then Lieutenant Governor of Delhi, Anil Baijal, on September 5, 2021, the Chief Minister had requested allotment of land for setting up the cultural centre and Naamghar. The subsequent allotment of land has paved the way for the project, which will further strengthen Assam's cultural presence in the national Capital.

Sarma said construction of the Assam Cultural-cum-Convention Centre is expected to begin in January next year. The Centre will house a Naamghar on the top floor and a multipurpose hall capable of accommodating around 300 to 400 people for community gatherings, social functions and cultural events.

Later, the Chief Minister inspected the newly constructed Assam House at

Dwarka Sector 13, which is nearing completion and will be inaugurated shortly. The foundation stone of the new Assam House was laid by the Chief Minister on April 22, 2023.

Constructed on a 1,000 square metre plot with a total built-up area of approximately 30,000 square feet, the building comprises a three-basement, ground plus four-floor (3B+G+4) structure built at an estimated cost of ₹21.66 crore.

The new Assam House has been designed to cater to the growing needs of people from Assam visiting the national Capital. A large number of patients from the State travel to Delhi regularly for specialised medical treatment, while a sizeable number of students pursue higher education in the city. The facility will provide them with comfort-

able, affordable and convenient accommodation. The building will house one VVIP suite, 18 guest rooms, 13 dormitory beds, one two-bedroom (2 BHK) unit and two one-bedroom (1 BHK) units for resident staff. It will also feature modern amenities including a cafeteria, reception and lounge, kitchen, common toilets, passenger lifts, car lifts and adequate parking facilities.

Reviewing the progress of the project, the Chief Minister expressed satisfaction with the quality of construction. He noted that while the old Assam House on Lokapriya Gopinath Bordoloi Marg had been reconstructed a few years ago, the existing Assam Bhawan on Sardar Patel Marg is being redeveloped and a modern new facility is coming up in its place.

The Chief Minister announced that both the new Assam House at Dwarka and the redeveloped Assam Bhawan on Sardar Patel Marg will be inaugurated on or before Durga Puja this year. He also said that the Karbi Bhawan and Dimas Bhawan at Dwarka are at various stages of construction and will further enhance facilities for people from the State visiting the national Capital.

Tiger found dead in Panna reserve; third in three months

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

An adult male tiger was found dead in the core area of the Panna Tiger Reserve (PTR) on Saturday, marking the third tiger death reported in the reserve in the past three months and raising fresh concerns over wildlife monitoring and conservation in one of Madhya Pradesh's most prominent tiger habitats.

The carcass was discovered by a forest department patrol team during routine surveillance in a remote hilly area of the Brijpura Beat under the Kishangarh Core Range. According to officials, forest personnel initially assumed the tiger was resting after spotting it lying motionless in the dense forest. However, when the animal



showed no movement for a considerable time, the team became suspicious.

Following standard protocol, the patrol team first observed the tiger through binoculars from a safe distance. After confirming that there was no movement, officials trekked nearly three to four kilometres from the nearest motorable road to reach the spot. On examination, they found the tiger dead and immediately

informed senior officers.

Panna Tiger Reserve Deputy Director Virendra Kumar Patel said a preliminary inspection indicated that all body parts of the tiger were intact, suggesting there was no immediate evidence of poaching. Officials also found no visible external injuries, wounds or signs of a territorial fight with another wild animal.

Patel said the inspection of the surrounding area also

revealed no indications of suspicious human activity or interference. Although the forest department is treating the case as a suspected natural death at this stage, he stressed that the exact cause of death can only be determined after the post-mortem examination and forensic analysis are completed.

The tiger's carcass has been sent for post-mortem, and biological samples have been collected for forensic examination. Forest officials said all possible angles are being investigated before reaching any final conclusion.

The latest incident has added to growing concerns over tiger mortality in the reserve. Earlier this year, the decomposed skeleton of a male tiger was found near the roadside in the Gangau area several days after its death,

raising questions over surveillance and timely monitoring within the reserve.

In another incident, a young male tiger rescued from Tara Village died under suspicious circumstances despite being fitted with a radio collar for continuous monitoring. That death had also prompted an internal inquiry.

With three tiger deaths reported within a span of three months, conservationists are expected to closely monitor the outcome of the ongoing investigation. While forest authorities maintain that there is no prima facie evidence of foul play in the latest case, the repeated deaths have once again brought the effectiveness of monitoring and protection measures in the Panna Tiger Reserve under scrutiny.

Kharge urges Union Govt to aid J&K flood relief efforts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Sunday expressed grief over the loss of lives due to the floods in Jammu and Kashmir and urged the Central Government to provide all assistance to the Union Territory to ensure swift rescue and relief to affected families.

He also demanded compensation for the families of victims from the PM CARES Fund.

"I am deeply distressed by the tragic loss of lives and the devastation caused by the flash floods and incessant rains in the Jammu division of Jammu and



Kashmir, particularly in Poonch and Rajouri. My heartfelt condolences to the bereaved families. I pray for the speedy recovery of the injured and the safety of all those affected," Kharge said in a post on X.

"I urge the Union Government, the LG office to provide all required assistance to the State Government and work in close coordination to ensure

swift rescue, relief and rehabilitation for every affected family," he said.

Kharge also appealed to all Congress leaders and workers to extend every possible help to the affected people during this difficult time.

"The families of the deceased should be provided adequate compensation without delay, through the PM CARES Fund," he said.

At least 11 people were killed, and seven others went missing as torrential rains triggered landslides and flash floods in the twin border districts of Poonch and Rajouri in Jammu and Kashmir on Sunday, prompting a multi-agency rescue operation.

AI-171 crash victims' kin seek black box data

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Families of those killed in the AI-171 flight crash here on Sunday demanded that the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) make the black box data and cockpit voice recorder (CVR) transcript public or share them with their lawyers.

They also questioned the agency's decision to "withhold" the material while promising only a final investigation report.

The London Gatwick Air India flight AI-171 crashed shortly after takeoff from Ahmedabad's Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel International Airport on June 12, 2025, resulting in India's



deadliest aviation disaster in decades.

The Boeing 787 Dreamliner plunged into the BJ Medical College hostel complex, killing 241 of the 242 passengers on board and 19 people on the ground.

Representatives of the victims' families met here to

discuss the AAIB's recent affidavit before the Supreme Court, in which the agency said it would not release the black box data or the CVR transcript.

They also demanded greater transparency in the probe, a memorial at the crash site and the signifi-

cance of simulator tests in the ongoing investigation.

Addressing reporters after the meeting, Romin Vahora, who lost his brother, niece and aunt in the tragedy, questioned how portions of the cockpit conversation had surfaced soon after the crash if the authorities believed such material should not be made public. "If they never intended to release the data, why did they release a cockpit voice recording transcript (as part of the preliminary report) just a few days after the crash?" Vahora asked, claiming that the families wanted to know whether the selective disclosure was meant to "shift the blame onto the pilots or mislead the victims' families".

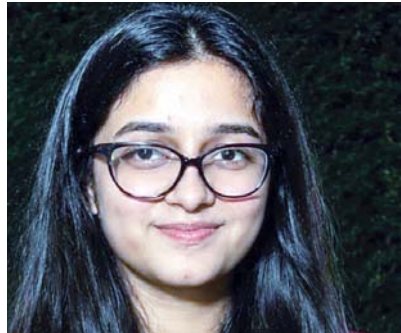
Adya Singh tops Bihar Foundation NICE 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The Bihar Foundation National Inter-College Crossword Expedition (Bihar Foundation NICE 2026), jointly organised by Extra-C and the Crossword Federation of India (CWFI) with the support of the Central Bank of India, witnessed an outstanding display of talent as girls made a clean sweep of the top four positions in the latest round of the national championship.

A special mention goes to Adya Singh of St. Stephen's College, New Delhi, who emerged as the Round Topper, securing the first position with an exceptional performance.

The latest round once again showcased the growing popularity of crossword solving as an educational activity that nurtures analytical thinking, logical reasoning, language proficiency, creativity and problem-solving skills



among college students across India.

V Krishna Sai Gayatri of BITS Pilani, Hyderabad Campus; Dhara Mittal from Gujarat National Law University, Gandhinagar; Vijval Ekbote of Indraprastha Institute of Information Technology, Delhi (IIIT-Delhi); and Bhargav Vinayak of CCL were the other successful students.

Congratulating the winners, the

organisers observed that the clean sweep by girls in the top three positions is a remarkable achievement and reflects the increasing participation and excellence of young women in intellectual competitions. They also commended the outstanding performances of participants from colleges and universities across the country, reaffirming the growing national appeal of the championship.

The organisers have announced that the N-Round of Bihar Foundation NICE 2026 will be held on July 26, 2026.

Expressing their gratitude, the organisers thanked the Bihar Foundation for lending its name to the championship and acknowledged the valuable support of the Central Bank of India, whose continued association has strengthened the mission of promoting knowledge, innovation and intellectual excellence among India's youth through crossword-based learning initiatives.

Most of PM's guarantees have been fulfilled; Bastar is now moving towards rapid development: Ramvichar Netam

Agriculture and Tribal Development Minister Ramvichar Netam speaks to *The Pioneer* Raipur Editor Dr AN Dwivedi on farmers' welfare, tribal development, Bastar, and the Government's performance.

Q: To what extent has 'Modi's Guarantee' been fulfilled in Chhattisgarh? How much remains to be done?

A: Most of the guarantees made under Modi's Guarantee have already been fulfilled, and our Government is committed to implementing the remaining promises as soon as possible. One of our historic decisions has been increasing farmers' income by procuring paddy at ₹3,100 per quintal, the highest procurement price in the country. We are providing pucca houses to lakhs of poor families, while eligible women receive ₹1,000 every month under the Mahtari Vandan Yojana. We have also taken firm action against those involved in the alleged CGPSC recruitment scam. Our Government is promoting digitisation and ensuring transparency in governance.

Q: As Agriculture Minister, what

are the major achievements of your Government for farmers over the past two-and-a-half years?

A: The welfare of farmers has been our highest priority. Chhattisgarh is the only State procuring paddy at ₹3,100 per quintal, and procurement is being carried out up to 20 quintals per acre. We are also encouraging crop diversification by providing an incentive of ₹15,000 per acre for cultivating alternative crops. Farmers are benefiting from the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi Yojana, while the crop insurance scheme is providing financial protection against crop losses. Our objective is to make agriculture more profitable and sustainable.

Q: Allegations regarding shortages of fertilisers and seeds continue to surface. What is the actual situation?

A: There is absolutely no shortage of fertilisers or seeds in Chhattisgarh. Against the target of 15.55 lakh metric tonnes, more than 14 lakh metric tonnes of fertilisers — around 90 per cent of the requirement — have already been made available. Similarly, 96 per



Agriculture and Tribal Development Minister Ramvichar Netam

PIONEER PHOTO

cent of the required seed stock has been secured. We have also ensured the availability of alternatives such as NPK and Single Super Phosphate (SSP). The shortages witnessed in the past occurred during the previous Congress Government due to black marketing. Today, our farmers are receiving timely supplies.

Q: You have served as a minis-

ter several times and have also been a Rajya Sabha MP. Do you aspire to become the Chief Minister?

A: I have always considered myself a disciplined worker of the Bharatiya Janata Party. Whatever responsibility the party has entrusted to me, I have carried it out with complete dedication. Decisions regarding leadership are entirely the prerogative of the party.

My responsibility is to continue serving the people sincerely.

Q: As Tribal Development Minister, what is your Government's roadmap for the socio-economic upliftment of tribal communities?

A: Tribal welfare is one of the Government's foremost priorities. We are committed to improving education, strengthening economic opportunities and preserving tribal culture. More than 60 per cent of Chhattisgarh falls under Scheduled Areas, while Tribal Sub-Plan areas account for over 65 per cent of the State. We are implementing a wide range of schemes, including college scholarships, hostel and ashram facilities, online scholarship disbursement, student meal assistance, tuition support, food security programmes, Eklavya Model Residential Schools, the Vidyarthi Utkarsh Yojana, Prayas Residential Schools, and the PM-JANMAN initiative. Skill development and livelihood generation are also being promoted to ensure long-term economic empowerment.

Q: With the decline of Naxalism,

what is the Government's development roadmap for Bastar?

A: Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, with the strong resolve of Union Home Minister Amit Shah and the courage of our security forces, Bastar has emerged from the shadow of Naxalism. The Government's focus is now firmly on development. Infrastructure projects are progressing rapidly, tourism is being promoted, industries are expanding, and commercial agriculture is being encouraged to generate employment for local youth. For decades, development in Bastar was stalled because of Naxal violence. Basic amenities could not reach many villages. That situation has changed, and people are now receiving the benefits of Government schemes. Bastar is entering a new era of peace and development.

Q: The BJP currently holds all 14 Assembly seats in the Surguja division. Will Surguja continue to play a decisive political role?

A: Certainly. The people of Surguja gave the BJP a resounding

mandate because of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's guarantee and the Government's development-oriented policies. With 14 Assembly seats, Surguja plays a crucial role in Government formation. Development in the region is progressing rapidly, and I believe the people will continue to support the BJP in the future as well.

Q: Despite holding several important positions over the years, you have largely remained free from controversy. What do you attribute this to?

A: Public service has always been my only objective. The people elected us to work for their welfare, and I have always tried to ensure that Government schemes reach every eligible beneficiary. Wherever I travel, I receive affection and blessings from the people, which inspires me to work even harder. I consider myself merely a dedicated worker of the party, and I am deeply grateful to the people of Chhattisgarh, especially the voters of Balamrupur, for repeatedly placing their trust in me and giving me the opportunity to serve.



Editor's
TAKE

Skyroot's moment,
ISRO's test

While private participation has broadened India's space ecosystem, the country must ensure that ISRO does not lose talent to emerging ventures

On July 18, a rocket that owed nothing to the Indian Space Research Organisation raced through the sky over Sriharikota and did what no Indian company had ever done: it reached orbit. Skyroot Aerospace's Vikram-1, flying under the mission name Aagaman – Sanskrit for “arrival” – made India only the third country after the United States and China to host a privately built orbital launch vehicle.

It is a genuine milestone. It also lands amid the loudest talent crisis ISRO has faced in years, and the timing is not a coincidence. The scale of Saturday's achievement is easy to understate. For six decades, reaching orbit from Indian soil has meant one thing: ISRO. Vikram-1 breaks that monopoly, built by a company founded only eight years ago by two former ISRO engineers who started with a team of ten in Hyderabad and first touched space with a smaller suborbital rocket back in 2022. That the rocket flew customer payloads on its very first attempt, rather than merely proving instruments, suggests Skyroot is not just demonstrating a capability but opening for business. That matters because it validates a bet New Delhi placed in 2020, when it opened spaceflight to private capital after decades of treating it as an exclusively sovereign function.

The reasoning was that ISRO, superb at frugal science missions, was never built to chase the fast-growing small-satellite launch market. Vikram-1 is the first hard proof that reasoning held: India can now offer commercial customers a private alternative to the PSLV and GSLV, edging toward the model in which NASA shares American skies with SpaceX and Rocket Lab rather than flying every mission itself. But the same fortnight that proved the private-space bet also exposed its price. More than a hundred ISRO scientists have resigned or taken voluntary retirement in recent months – enough that the Department of Space, just four days before Vikram-1 lifted off, moved to block routine exits of scientists working on Gaganyaan and other flagship missions.

The pull is not mysterious: start-ups founded largely by ISRO alumni offer two to three times government pay, equity, flat hierarchies, and freedom from layered bureaucracy. Those leaving are not junior hires; many carry specialised experience from missions such as Chandrayaan-3 and SpaDeX, and they are exiting a public agency already facing missed deadlines on some of its own flagship launches – for a private sector that, not incidentally, just launched India's first private orbital rocket. Optimists call this redistribution rather than drain, likening it to how engineers cycle between NASA and SpaceX in a maturing market. That comparison could prove right – but only if India's space ecosystem grows large enough to absorb the churn, keeping ISRO staffed for the missions only a state agency can run even as it keeps seeding the companies extending India's reach commercially. Vikram-1 shows what that ecosystem is capable of when it works. Whether ISRO stays intact enough to keep supplying it, mission after mission, decade after decade, is now the harder question hanging over India's space programme.

Recep Tayyip Erdogan's decade of power

A decade after surviving the failed coup attempt that shook Turkey to its core, President Recep Tayyip Erdogan has emerged not merely as the country's longest-serving modern leader but as one of the defining geopolitical figures of the twenty-first century



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

On July 15, 2026, Recep Tayyip Erdogan marked ten years since the night warplanes bombed Turkey's parliament, telling a crowd in Ankara that the network Turkey blames for the coup attempt has lost its guard but remains dangerous - this despite the death, in Pennsylvania in 2024, of the exiled cleric at the center of it all, Fethullah Gülen. That the threat still needed naming, a decade on and well after its supposed architect died, says less about what remains of Gülen's network than about how load-bearing July 15 has become for everything Erdogan has built since. Turkish outlets critical of the government reportedly weren't accredited to cover the commemoration at all.

The same week offered a sharper illustration of the method than any anniversary speech could. As NATO leaders gathered in Ankara for the alliance's summit on July 7 and 8 - Turkey's second turn hosting the full membership since 2004 - a courtroom outside Istanbul pressed on with the trial of Ekrem Mamolus , the jailed mayor and Erdogan's most credible electoral rival, on corruption charges spread across more than four hundred co-defendants and a combined sentencing demand north of two thousand years. Ekrem Mamolus was ejected from his own hearing days into the summit; his lawyer called the ruling arbitrary and outside the law. Human rights monitors have called the case, and the parallel removal of more than a dozen elected opposition mayors, a politically driven effort to clear the field before Turkey's next presidential vote.

That overlap points to something the familiar story of an elected strongman riding a strong economy tends to miss: Erdogan does not meet every threat with the same tool. Where a challenge arrives wrapped in votes - Ekrem Mamolus , or Selahattin Demirtas, the Kurdish politician the European Court of Human Rights has repeatedly ordered released since 2018 and whom Ankara has kept in prison regardless - the instrument is the courtroom, applied patiently and indefinitely. Where a threat arrives wrapped in weapons, the instrument is negotiation. In 2025, after four decades of insurgency and more than 40,000 deaths, the PKK held a ceremony in northern Iraq and burned its weapons; by mid-2026 Erdogan's government was drafting legislation, together with pro-Kurdish lawmakers his coalition had



TURKEY
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AUTHORITY.
PARLIAMENTARY
OVERSIGHT
WEAKENED

The writer is a columnist
based in Colombo

spent years branding as terrorist proxies, to formalize the group's dissolution. It is a genuine settlement no predecessor achieved. It also sits oddly next to Ankara's reported success, described this year in Israeli press accounts, in persuading Donald Trump to shelve a Mossad-backed plan to arm Kurdish militias against Iran. Whether the fighters in question are burning weapons in Sulaymaniyah or being organized by Israeli intelligence, Turkey's answer to Kurdish paramilitary power has been the same: neutralize it, by whatever means the moment allows.

Foreign policy runs on the same instinct for turning constraint into leverage. Hosting NATO gave Erdoğan a stage, and he used it in a way only he would think to: sending all thirty-two visiting leaders home with an engraved Gümüşay .357 revolver from the state manufacturer MKE, a gift so unusual that several delegations had to check their own gun laws before deciding whether to keep it, hand it to a museum, or leave it with their embassy - one leader joked that his own gift to Erdogan, a shipment of maple syrup, looked badly outmatched, while another only learned he had received a revolver at all after landing back home, and passed it to a police museum. It doubled as a sales pitch, delivered days before Washington was expected to lift sanctions tied to Ankara's 2019 purchase of Russian S-400 missiles - part of a rapprochement one American official described to reporters as a “special chemistry” between the two presidents. The wider pattern holds: Erdoğan supplies armed drones to Ukraine while buying Russian gas, criticizes Israel's

conduct in Gaza in some of the bluntest language of any regional leader while keeping Washington close, and has spent the past year quietly reopening trade and diplomatic doors across the Gulf that stayed shut for most of the 2010s.

What that formula cannot paper over is the economy Turks actually live in. Annual inflation, after peaking above 80 percent in recent years, has been climbing back through 2026, running above 32 percent in the spring as an energy shock from the Iran war pushed up fuel and food prices - even as the central bank held its policy rate at 37 percent, the highest in the G20. The lira has slid past 47 to the dollar, down roughly 17 percent against the currency over twelve months.

Finance minister Mehmet Simsek's return to economic orthodoxy since 2023 has rebuilt some investor confidence, but it runs on the same logic as everything else: manage the pain rather than end it, and bet that voters credit the direction of travel more than they punish the distance still to go.

None of this looks like a leader coasting on the memory of a defeated coup. It looks like a governing method that has been generalized far past July 15 - conciliation for enemies who can hurt him with force, litigation for rivals who can beat him with votes, and a foreign policy built to extract leverage from exactly the contradictions that would sink a less agile government. Even the Kurdish settlement may serve a second purpose.

Turkey's constitution caps Erdoğan at two terms, due to expire with elections now targeted for April 2028, and the only routes past that cap run through parliament: 360 of its 600 members calling an early vote, or a larger bloc rewriting the charter outright. His coalition currently holds 321 seats on its own. The pro-Kurdish DEM party holds 56 - exactly the kind of bloc a movement freshly persuaded to lay down its weapons might be willing to lend the president who ended its war. Whether that arithmetic works, whether a currency still hunting for its floor holds, and whether an opposition that keeps producing candidates even as Ankara jails them can ever actually compete, are the questions the next two years will answer - not whether Erdoğan's command of July 15 endures, but whether a country this size can keep being governed by anniversary alone.

Age bars for social media: Necessity or choice



KAJLEEN
KAUR

2ND
OPINION

Social media for the present generation is more than a form of simple communication; it is a holistic mechanism for socialising, education, entertainment and recognition. It has transformed the way children and adolescents engage with and explore their lives, in contrast to previous generations. However, of late, there has been a public furore on the downside of the online exposure, including digital addiction, cyber-bullying, misinformation, mental health and behavioural issues at this tender age. Many countries are thereby implementing an age limit for social media use.

The minimum age for most major social media platforms today is 13 years, which is mainly to secure adherence to data protection laws like the Children's Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA) in the United States. But with lax enforcement, the majority of children have access to social

media long before the recommended age. Age restrictions demonstrate the importance of protecting children during their developmental period. Research shows that while adolescents' critical cognitive and emotional abilities are developing, exposure to endless content on social sites hinders their potential intellectual growth. Excessive social media use has been associated with increased anxiety levels, depression, sleep disorders, and social comparison among teenagers. In a world where information spreads rapidly without any authentication, the young users are the most affected, as they are not able to mindfully decide about its repercussions before absorbing or spreading it.

India is at an even higher risk, with one of the world's largest populations of internet users, affordable smartphones, low-cost data, and unregulated usage. It has certainly helped in digital empowerment with more information and educational content, but has also exposed young users to cyber threats, online harassment, digital scams, and harmful content. The age restriction is also critical to safeguard society from any immature digital actions by this section of the population, which may be unintentional but can result in unprecedented adversities. Quoting a recent personal anecdote of an encounter with a young girl in her early teens, popular enough, but not to my knowledge, who creates digital content for her social media channels. She randomly requested me for a brief general interaction for a video, which seemed casual and harmless enough. When I received the video-bite through some forward messages, I discovered the clip had been

edited and presented unexpectedly and unpleasantly to make it a subject of mockery, for engaging viewership. What followed were the insensitive and distressing comments on the video. It was unignorable, and therefore, I had to lodge an official cybercrime complaint to get the clip removed from all the platforms. Undoubtedly, the young generation possesses remarkable technological skills, yet lacks the sense needed to understand the serious consequences of their digital pursuits. The irresponsible content targeting people can damage social reputation, bearing serious repercussions. They also lack awareness of the importance of digital ethics, informed consent, privacy, and legal accountability. The importance of age bars on social media can therefore not be denied. The more pressing issue is how age restrictions are implemented. Robust age-verification and platform accountability, parental and teachers' engagement, and digital literacy education are all important factors in effective regulation. Many countries, including Australia, the UAE, China, and several European countries, have mandated strict age verification methods like facial scans or ID checks instead of relying on self-declaration as an effective mechanism to enforce age limits.

What is needed, therefore, in this digital era is a comprehensive approach that includes protection, education, accountability, empowerment and wise engagement with technology.

The writer is an Assistant Professor at Sri Guru Gobind Singh
College of Commerce, Delhi University

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Right to protest must be protected

The The forcible removal of activist Sonam Wangchuk from his hunger strike at Delhi's Jantar Mantar has raised serious concerns about the handling of peaceful protests in a democracy. Reports indicate that police personnel surrounded him with white bed sheets to block public view before shifting him to Safdarjung Hospital, citing medical advice and a Delhi High Court directive. While the authorities have a responsibility to safeguard the health of fasting protesters and maintain public order, such actions must be carried out transparently and with utmost sensitivity. The use of visual barriers, allegations of rough handling and restrictions on recording the operation have inevitably created suspicion and eroded public confidence. Equally worrying are reports of minor injuries during the commotion and the subsequent attempt to remove other fasting student activists. Peaceful dissent is an integral part of democratic life, and law enforcement agencies must ensure that necessary interventions do not appear coercive or excessive. The continuing protests over the NEET controversy underline the need for dialogue rather than confrontation. A democratic government should respond to public grievances through engagement, accountability and transparency. Respecting the right to peaceful protest ultimately strengthens democratic institutions.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Parliament must deliver, not disrupt

As Parliament begins its Monsoon Session, the nation expects serious deliberations rather than repeated disruptions and political point-scoring. The government has every right to defend its policies, while the Opposition has an equally vital responsibility to scrutinise them constructively. Every hour lost to adjournments is an opportunity denied to the people. India today faces pressing challenges, including AI-driven job disruption, widening employment gaps despite economic growth, agricultural transformation, urban distress and shifting global supply chains. These issues require informed, evidence-based debate and bipartisan cooperation.

Citizens expect thoughtful discussions, not continuous disruptions that diminish the dignity of the institution. Frequent deadlocks also send an unfortunate signal to global investors about India's ability to build consensus on long-term economic reforms, infrastructure development, ease of doing business and regulatory certainty. At the same time, the government cannot avoid discussions on sensitive issues. Parliament is the highest forum of democratic accountability. Both the Treasury and Opposition benches must rise above partisan politics and focus on constructive debate. The country's aspirations deserve a Parliament that works responsibly.

BRIJ B GOYAL | LUDHIANA

Action must match anti-corruption promise

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Joseph Vijay's pledge to take stern action against corruption is a welcome assurance at a time when public confidence in governance depends on transparency and accountability. Such a commitment can restore faith in institutions, provided it is backed by consistent and impartial implementation. The government could reinforce this resolve by officially observing International Anti-Corruption Day on December 9 with statewide awareness programmes highlighting ethical governance, citizen participation and mechanisms for reporting corruption. However, combating corruption requires more than symbolic gestures or occasional crackdowns. The law must be enforced equally against both those who demand bribes and those who willingly offer them. Selective action undermines credibility.

Development initiatives can achieve their intended objectives only when public resources are managed honestly and efficiently. Strong institutions, transparent procedures, independent oversight and prompt action against wrongdoing are essential to ensure accountability at every level of administration. If the government translates its commitment into sustained institutional reforms, Tamil Nadu can emerge as a model of clean governance and inspire public confidence.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

PIC
TALK



A manufacturer of chessboards displays designer chessboards ahead of World Chess Day in Amritsar. The city produce premium handcrafted wooden chess sets that are exported to several countries.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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HYDROGEN-POWERED TRAIN
SIGNALS A GREENER FUTURE

This refers to the report, “PM flags off India's first hydrogen-powered train” (July 18). The inauguration of India's first indigenously developed hydrogen-powered train is a landmark achievement for Indian Railways and a proud moment for the country.

With this initiative, India joins a select group of nations that have successfully introduced zero-emission hydrogen technology in their railway systems. Designed, engineered and built in India, the NaMo Green Rail produces only heat and water vapour during operation, making it a clean and sustainable alternative to diesel-powered locomotives.

Although India has electrified nearly its entire 70,000-km railway network, hydrogen trains offer a practical solution

for routes where electrification remains difficult or uneconomical. They will also reduce dependence on imported fossil fuels while supporting India's net-zero commitments and the National Green Hydrogen Mission. Successful examples in Germany and Japan, along with India's Jind-Sonipat pilot, demonstrate the immense potential of this technology. At the same time,

Indian Railways must continue reforms in safety, infrastructure modernisation, capacity expansion, congestion management and rationalisation of passenger and freight tariffs. Green technology and systemic reforms together will ensure a safer, faster and more sustainable railway network for millions of commuters.

P VICTOR SELVARAJ | PALAYAMKOTTAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com.
In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Science & technology in ancient India and its relevance today

The scientific and technological past of ancient India is not just a chapter of history, but a guide for the present and future. It showcases a wide spectrum of human genius – from mathematical abstraction to precise surgery and excellent metallurgy. Indian education systems now need to include this heritage in the core curriculum



SAROJ SHARMA

Aryabhata, Sushruta, Charaka, Varahamihira, and Bhaskaracharya.

Centres of learning such as Nalanda, Vikramshila, and Takshashila brought philosophy, astronomy, mathematics, and medicine together under one roof. Aryabhata's Aryabhatiya (c. 499 CE) worked out trigonometric formulas, argued that the Earth itself moves, and calculated its circumference at 39,968 kilometres. Bhaskaracharya's Lilavati laid early groundwork for algebra, and Brahmagupta set out the rules for negative numbers. The Sushruta Samhita is the earliest known text on detailed surgery, including plastic and cataract techniques, while the Charaka Samhita reads like an encyclopaedia of internal medicine. Nagarjuna's Rasashastra covered medicinal preparation, the Surya Siddhanta calculated eclipses and planetary motion, and Varahamihira's Panchasiddhantika merged five astronomical traditions into one. The rust-free Iron Pillar of Delhi (c. 400 CE) still puzzles metallurgists, and Vastu Shastra drew its architectural principles from the sun's movement, wind, and a balance of five elements. We live amid artificial intelligence, generative tools, private spaceflight, AR/VR, 5G, drones, humanoid robots, and 3D printing – alongside deepening environmental crises, rising mental health difficulties, and ethics that haven't kept pace with the technology. That gap is worth naming – and worth asking what earlier Indian thought, built around balance rather than pure output, might still offer.

Ayurveda and the Practice of Staying Well

Ayurveda, India's traditional medical system, treats mind and body as one connected whole. Its purpose is captured in a well-known line: "Swasthasya swasthya rakshanam, aturasya vikar prashamanam cha" – protect the health of the well, and cure the disease of the sick. That aim hasn't aged. Ayurvedic learning follows daily and seasonal rhythm. Dinacharya prescribes waking before dawn, exercise, bathing, and reflection. Rutcharya divides the year into six seasons – Shishir, Vasant, Grishma, Varsha, Sharad, and Hemant – each calling for dosha adjustments; summer's rising Pitta and Vata, for instance, call for cooling foods and plenty of water. Diet follows six tastes – sweet, sour, salty, pungent, bitter, and astringent – eaten according to one's digestive strength, since, per the Charaka Samhita, weak digestion is the root of nearly every illness ("Roga sarve mandagnau"). Mentally, Ayurveda describes temperament through three gunas – Sattva, Rajas, and Tamas.

The stakes are real: diabetes, hypertension, obesity, and heart disease are now widespread enough to strain health systems worldwide – only one country has more adults with diabetes than India. Ayurveda's answer – dosha balance through Dinacharya, Rutcharya, and the Trayopastambha, or three pillars of health – speaks directly to this. Recognition extends well beyond India: the WHO estimates 80–90 percent of people worldwide use traditional medicine and now treats such systems as essential healthcare, reflected in its choice to host the WHO Global Centre for Traditional Medicine in India. AIIMS Rishikesh has run a Tridosha-based AYUSH department alongside conventional treatment since 2017, the same year the All India Institute of Ayurveda in New Delhi became fully operational; the National Institute of Ayurveda continues expanding research and training.

Children today carry real strain from exam pressure and constant social media exposure. Patanjali answered these centuries ago: his second yoga sutra, "Yogaschitta vritti nirodhah," defines yoga as the stilling of the mind's fluctuations – peace through mastering restlessness, not eliminating its causes. The National Education Policy 2020 makes a related point, insisting self-understanding deserves as much attention as academic content.

India's older texts – the Vedas, Upanishads, Bhagavad Gita, and Ayurveda – treat mental health as one part of a wider picture spanning body and spirit. The Atharvaveda's descriptions of mantras and healing sound anticipate what's now marketed as sound therapy and mindfulness. Patanjali's Yoga Sutras set out an eight-limbed path – Yama, Niyama, Asana, Pranayama, Pratyahara, Dharana, Dhyana, and Samadhi – for developing body, mind, and spirit together. Practised regu-



AI-GENERATED VISUAL REPRESENTATION

THE NATIONAL EDUCATION POLICY 2020 CALLS FOR WEAVING INDIA'S VEDIC AND CLASSICAL SCIENTIFIC HERITAGE INTO STEM EDUCATION, RESTORING CONTINUITY WHILE ENCOURAGING BOTH INDIGENOUS PRIDE AND GLOBAL ENGAGEMENT.

The author is a renowned educationist and currently the Vice-Chancellor of Ranchi University

larly, it builds flexibility, strength, and immunity, supports digestion and breathing, eases stress and anxiety, sharpens concentration and memory, and nurtures self-knowledge, a steadier outlook, and empathy.

Global recognition is hard to overstate: when the UN marked the first International Yoga Day on June 21, 2015, 177 countries backed it. India has since made yoga compulsory in schools, and institutions as prominent as Harvard and Stanford now research its effects. A similar pattern holds for the environment. Despite real scientific progress, climate change and lifestyle disease keep worsening, partly because students rarely learn to treat environmental care as central rather than optional. Older Indian thought treated nature as alive and conscious. The Atharvaveda's line "Mata Bhumih Putroham Prithivyah" – the Earth is our mother, we are her children – framed protecting the planet as a spiritual duty. Forests were designated Aranyak or Tapovan and protected; trees like the peepal and neem were revered as Devavriksha; water systems relied on rainwater harvesting, now being revived out of necessity; and the Panchatantra and Hitopadesha taught compassion toward animals through childhood fables.

Agriculture followed the same logic – mixed cropping and organic manure – long before synthetic fertilisers and pesticides brought side effects now well documented, alongside worsening air, water, and land pollution. Bringing Vedic, Puranic, and folk ecological traditions back into education could address this at the root. India's space programme shows the heritage still has momentum: Mangalyaan (2014) and the Chandrayaan missions, through Chandrayaan-3 (2023), extend rather than break from a much older tradition of Indian mathematics and astronomy. Teaching traditional models – the classical twelve zodiac signs, say – alongside Kepler's laws could sharpen students' mathematical-astronomical thinking. The National Education Policy 2020 calls for weaving India's Vedic and classical scientific heritage into STEM education, restoring continuity while encouraging both indigenous pride and global engagement. Vastu Shastra is a disciplined study of how buildings relate to their surroundings – oriented around the sun's path, wind, the Earth's magnetic field, and a balance of five elements to secure natural light, airflow, and energy efficiency, much of it mapping onto what's now called green building design: passive cooling, natural lighting, rainwater harvesting, and solar power.

The overlap goes beyond concept. LEED-certified buildings following Vastu's preferred northeast-facing layout – the Ishan corner – have cut energy use by up to 30 percent in some studies. Researchers at IIT Kharagpur found that Vastu-style courtyards, built around natural daylight and cross-ventilation, use roughly 40 percent less energy than typical passive-cooling designs, while local materials also cut the carbon footprint. The National Education Policy 2020 supports bringing Vastu into architecture curricula; pairing temple and haveli case studies with green-certification training and solar-analysis software could help students apply this heritage to climate-resilient design.

Ancient India's scientific and technical achievements – spanning mathematical abstraction, surgical precision, and metallurgical skill still not fully explained – deserve a real place in the core curriculum, not as nostalgia but as proof that science has always been a shared human project Indian scholars helped shape.

The aim is not blind imitation of the past or glorification of unscientific claims, but to provide education rooted in cultural foundations with a global perspective. This will help children understand that science is a universal human endeavor in which their ancestors also made significant contributions. It will encourage them to adopt a multidisciplinary, comprehensive, and sustainable approach.

The hidden economy behind every AI prompt



ANURADHA P S

The majority of people associate AI with a chatbot, an image generator or a coding assistant. But these are merely the buildings that have a face. There is another economy behind them, an invisible economy that operates in the name of data, computing power, electricity, human work and public infrastructure. We use it every day, but do not fully appreciate who's creating the value, who's taking the value, who's really paying for the value.

Each 'prompt' from the AI generates something bigger. But there is an invisible economy to getting that seemingly easy answer; chips and electricity, water and human labour and billions of dollars of investment. AI is the next Industrial Revolution. However, there is an important point to the comparison. All industrial revolutions had their own infrastructure. The infrastructure of AI is not so visible. It has factories that are data centres. It's using data as its raw material. It operates on electric fuel. It has an assembly line process, and a number of thousands of human workers train, test, and fine-tune intelligent systems.

This hidden infrastructure is growing exponentially. PwC has estimated that AI will have the power to add up to US\$15.7 trillion to the global economy by 2030. These figures are often touted as the harbingers of the promise of AI. Much less consideration is given to the source of that wealth, the ownership of infrastructure that produces it, and who will benefit from it.

The solution is as simple as a question. When a user requests an email be drafted or a spreadsheet be analysed by AI, the request goes through extremely fast networks to data centers with specialized processors. These are not regular computers, but powerful graphics processors (GPUs) that can calculate trillions of calculations per second for thousands of dollars. The reason why the response is so quick is that gigantic investments have already been made in semiconductor manufacturing, cloud computing and networking infrastructure.

It has just emerged that intelligence isn't light. Nor is it free of pollution. According to the International Energy Agency (IEA), data centres used approximately 415 ter-

awatt-hours of electricity in 2024, which amounted to about 1.5% of global electricity consumption. Each prompt thus comes with an invisible energy cost and connects AI policy with the discussions around renewable energy, grid resilience and sustainable infrastructure.

Another little talked-about expense comes even further down the list:

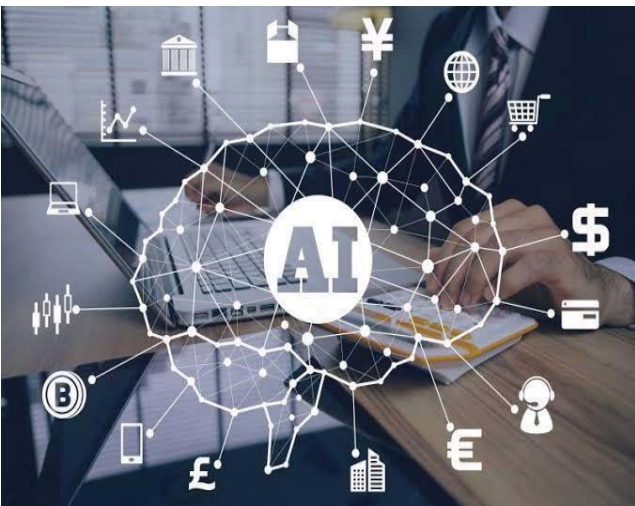
people. Although the popular notion is that AI generation will replace human jobs, it still relies on a huge amount of people to label images, check translations, moderate and filter out harmful content, and evaluate the responses of the models. Much of their work is hidden in plain sight, frequently spread out across the developing rest of the world, done away from the spotlight of AI success. All polished AI answers have a human judgment component which users are not aware of.

Traditionally, economists have called such uncompensated expenses externalities, and AI is ushering in a new era of digital externalities. Costs that the user may not have in mind include those in the electricity grid, water resources, cloud infrastructure, copyright issues and human labour. The costs of intelligence are distributed through a complex economic system, and thus seem free. The invisibility applies to value creation as well. All interactions with AI create economic value. The accuracy of models is enhanced by users' questions.

AI becomes a core part of businesses as a tool. Cloud providers rent computations. Manufacturers of chips are providing ever more advanced equipment. In this fledgling value chain, the most lucrative positions go to companies who own their data and infrastructure for computation. This is a chance and a strategic dilemma for India. Through Aadhaar, UPI and DigiLocker, the country has created one of the most revered ecosystems of digital public infrastructure in the world that can serve millions while scaling, showcasing how digital systems can scale. India also has more than 900 million Internet users, which produce one of the world's most prolific sources of digital data. However, having a digital scale won't guarantee AI leadership.

Without the ability to develop its own AI, India is at risk of becoming a data exporter and an AI importer. The next big step in digital policy needs to go beyond promoting the use of AI. It needs to prioritise the enhancement of domestic computing power, semiconductor manufacturing, providing affordable computing to start-ups, investing in AI research, establishing high-quality public datasets and establishing clear regulations that engender trust. The debate surrounding AI has mostly centered on the question of whether AI will lead to job displacement. That's a very important question, but possibly not the most important one.

According to the International Monetary Fund, AI could impact approximately 40% of all jobs around the world. Equally important, though, is who will be the owners of the infrastructure on which AI creates wealth. Its long-term consequences will not only be related to innovation, but also to institutions, investment and public policy. Each AI prompt is thus more than just a digital conversation. It is an economic exchange that is part of an extensive global system of energy, infrastructure, investment and human effort. Although the technology is invisible, its economic impact is not. Each prompt has an invisible cost; its value is invisible, and its infrastructure is invisible. The hidden economy is the first step towards a technologically transformative, economically fair, and viable AI revolution.



The writer is Professor Department of Commerce CHRIST (Deemed to be University)

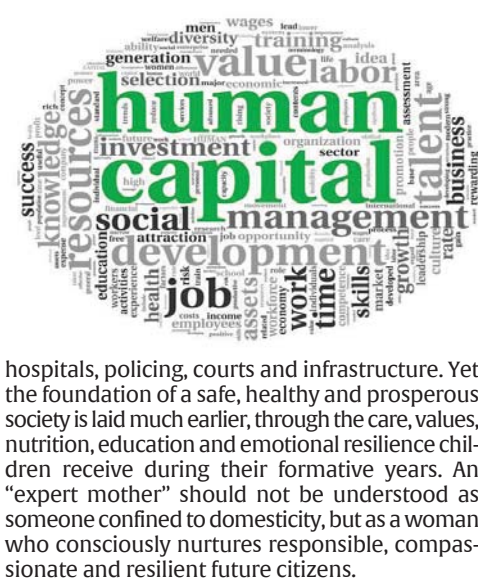
If nation-building begins with people, then human capital begins at home



NAVITA SRIKANTH

a young adult joins the civil services or the armed forces. Nation-building begins at home. This is not merely a cultural or philosophical argument; it is also an economic and developmental one. Multilateral institutions increasingly recognise that a nation's greatest asset is not its natural resources or infrastructure, but its people. The World Bank's Human Capital Index reflects this reality: a country's future productivity depends upon the health, education and development of its children today. Human capital begins long before a young adult enters the workforce. It begins in early childhood. In that sense, parenting, and particularly the nurturing that takes place during a child's formative years is among a nation's earliest and most important investments in human capital. Human capital is therefore not simply an economic indicator; it is a measure of how effectively societies prepare future generations to become productive, responsible and peaceful citizens.

Viewed through the lens of preventive governance, social development and development economics, the larger truth behind Uttar Pradesh Governor Anandiben Patel's remark, "Whether you become an IAS officer or a teacher, first become an expert mother," becomes clear. The Governor's remarks invited a deeper reflection: Who builds the future of a nation? A nation is built one generation at a time. Every child who grows into a responsible citizen, ethical public servant, entrepreneur, scientist, soldier or judge begins life within a family. Before any profession is chosen and before any institution imparts knowledge, a child's earliest values, emotional security, discipline and sense of responsibility are nurtured at home. Modern societies rightly celebrate professional achievement. Yet they often overlook perhaps the most demanding and consequential responsibility of all: raising children who embody compassion, integrity and civic responsibility. The child of today will determine tomorrow's rule of law, social harmony, innovation, economic productivity and whether societies choose peace over conflict. While her words generated controversy, they also opened an important conversation that extends beyond politics to development economics and preventive governance. They invite a collective reflection at all levels - global, regional and national - on how societies invest in human capital from the earliest years of life. Far from being regressive, the Governor's remarks can be understood as forward-looking because they place human development at the centre of nation-building. Governments invest in schools,



hospitals, policing, courts and infrastructure. Yet the foundation of a safe, healthy and prosperous society is laid much earlier, through the care, values, nutrition, education and emotional resilience children receive during their formative years. An "expert mother" should not be understood as someone confined to domesticity, but as a woman who consciously nurtures responsible, compassionate and resilient future citizens. My conviction is also shaped by professional experience. During my investigative work in Colombia, including efforts to support the reintegration and mainstreaming of families of former Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia (FARC) into civilian life, I witnessed first-hand the transformative role women played in rebuilding fractured communities. One of our approaches was to engage and economically empower women so they could stand on their own feet while envisioning a different future for their children, one centred on education,

dignity, opportunity and social inclusion. In communities emerging from conflict, we found that empowering women and strengthening their role as mothers was among the most sustainable pathways to long-term resilience. When a mother begins to see realistic opportunities for her child's education, employment and integration into mainstream society, she becomes a powerful force for change within the family and the wider community. That experience taught me an enduring lesson: investing in women and motherhood is not merely a social welfare measure. It is an investment in human capital, peacebuilding and national resilience. In many fragile settings, the long-term challenge is not simply ending conflict but preventing its recurrence. Mothers often become the first line of defence against the intergenerational transmission of violence by helping shape aspirations grounded in opportunity rather than conflict. Across much of the world, motherhood and professional life are not separate identities but parallel responsibilities. Women routinely balance parenting with demanding careers, managing homes while leading institutions, businesses and global teams. Be it Sweden's generous parental support or Switzerland's emphasis on parental involvement in a child's formative years through the traditions such as the 'Mittagspause' and 'TagesMutter' convinced me that across Europe, valuing and supporting parenthood was viewed not merely as a private family matter but as a societal investment. Similar thinking was evident at the World Bank and Novartis where family-friendly policies enabled

parents to devote meaningful time to their children. The corporate world in India was no different. While spearheading Ernst & Young's Diversity & Inclusion Portfolio alongside my role as Partner and National for Fraud Investigation & Dispute Services, I consistently advocated for enabling workplaces where women in client-facing leadership roles did not have to choose between professional excellence and family responsibilities. The debate, therefore, should not be framed as a choice between motherhood and professional achievement. Women have every right to pursue careers, lead institutions and shape public life. Equally, if they choose motherhood, society should recognise it not as an interruption to achievement but as one of its highest forms. Raising responsible, ethical and compassionate citizens is itself an act of nation-building and one of the earliest investments in a country's human capital. It is no coincidence that across civilisations humanity continues to invoke the metaphor of "Mother Earth" to symbolise nurturing, preservation and renewal. These are qualities essential to building resilient societies. Public discourse is best served when ideas are evaluated on their substance rather than through partisan lenses. Whether one agrees entirely with the Governor's choice of words is secondary. The more important question is whether modern societies have undervalued one of their greatest investments in the future: nurturing the next generation.

The author is a financial, governance, geopolitical and security analyst



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 Order Order

BCI declares AIBE results with 65.92 pass per cent



The Bar Council of India (BCI) declared the result of the All India Bar Examination (AIBE-XXI), with an overall pass percentage of 65.92.

"The AIBE-XXI was conducted on June 7 across 292 examination centres in 60 different cities where a total of 1,75,701 candidates appeared in the examination," a release issued on Saturday said.

It said that out of 1,75,701 candidates, 1,10,909 male candidates, 64,784 female candidates and 8 transgender candidates appeared in the exam.

According to the release, the examination was conducted smoothly and in an orderly manner, ensuring fairness, transparency and adherence to the prescribed norms.

The AIBE-XXI was conducted under the direct supervision and guidance of the Monitoring Committee of the All India Bar Examination of the Bar Council of India, headed by former Supreme Court judge Justice Hima Kohli.

"The result was directed to be calculated based on 100 marks. However, the Monitoring Committee noticed that though the cut-off marks for qualifying the AIBE-XXI Examination were fixed at 45 for General candidates and 40 for SC/ST/PwD candidates; however, after perusal of the question paper and result summary, the committee unanimously decided to moderate the result and reduce the qualifying marks by three (3)," the release said. (PTI)

UP: Woman gets life term for murdering 4-year-old son



A court here has sentenced a woman to life imprisonment for murdering her four-year-old son in 2024.

Additional District and Sessions Judge Lokesh Nagar on Saturday convicted Aadesh Devi and also imposed a fine of ₹60,000 on her, Additional District Government Counsel (ADGC) Mukesh Chauhan said.

The incident took place on June 12, 2024, in Jalalpur Hasna village.

Devi had attacked her son, Harsh, with a spade and then attempted to set him on fire after placing him on a pile of wood. Her husband, Kapil, who returned home from the fields, rescued the child and rushed him to a hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

The police had registered a case on Kapil's complaint, arrested the accused and filed a charge sheet after completing the investigation, the ADGC said. (PTI)

Calcutta HC orders halt in demolition of Abhishek Banerjee's office

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Sunday ordered status quo on the demolition of the Diamond Harbour court said the matter would be heard by the regular bench.

The court, however, declined to grant relief on the petitioner's plea alleging that political workers and miscreants had looted documents from the office while the police remained mute spectators, observing that the petition did not disclose that any complaint had been lodged with the police.

The South 24 Parganas district administration began demolishing the TMC MP's party office on Saturday after finding it was allegedly constructed without an approved building plan and in violation

tion with a different matter.

Directing that status quo be maintained with regard to the demolition of the five-storey building on Diamond Harbour Road, the court said the matter would be heard by the regular bench.

The court, however, declined to grant relief on the petitioner's plea alleging that political workers and miscreants had looted documents from the office while the police remained mute spectators, observing that the petition did not disclose that any complaint had been lodged with the police.

The South 24 Parganas district administration began demolishing the TMC MP's party office on Saturday after finding it was allegedly constructed without an approved building plan and in violation



Right to life vs right to protest: The legal conflict at Jantar Mantar



RANJIT KUMAR SINHA

On the morning of July 18, 2026, the Delhi Police conducted an early morning operation to pick up Sonam Wangchuk from the protest site at Jantar Mantar.

He had been on an indefinite hunger strike for 21 days, and his health had severely deteriorated due to prolonged fasting. The police entered the barricaded area, placed him in an ambulance, and shifted him to Safdarjung Hospital, New Delhi, for essential medical care.

A key factor behind the timing of the police action was a major upcoming event. The Monsoon Session of Parliament was scheduled to begin on July 20, 2026. On that exact same day, the organizers had planned a massive "Chalo Sansad" (March to Parliament). Authorities stepped in to clear the area in advance to manage security and prevent the protest from spreading.

According to the law enforcement agency, the action taken by the Delhi Police was based on a direct intervention by the judiciary. The activist was shifted to the hospital in compliance with recent orders issued by the Delhi High Court and acted on expert medical advice to



safeguard his life. The High Court had stepped in after a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) was filed on July 14, 2026. Recognizing that the activist had lost significant weight and faced severe health risks, the petitioner moved the court to seek urgent medical intervention and judicial protection for his life.

The High Court heard the petition and officially disposed of it on July 16, 2026. While closing the matter under case number W.P.(C) 9498/2026, the judges noted the government's assurance that a formalized mechanism of daily monitoring by government doctors was in place. To ensure absolute safety, the High Court explicitly recorded the framework in its final order:

"We only observe that the life of every citizen is precious and all medical efforts ought to be made by the Government authorities to save the same. We appreciate the stance taken by the learned Solicitor General and, accordingly, direct that the

medical condition of Shri Sonam Wangchuk shall, clinically and otherwise, be regularly monitored on a daily basis and, depending on the opinion of the doctors, whatever medical intervention is required to check his deteriorating health condition, shall also be taken."

The core constitutional provision the High Court was dealing with-and enforcing-in this matter was Article 21 of the Constitution, which guarantees the Right to Life and Personal Liberty.

While the text of the order does not explicitly name the article, the court's operative reasoning directly derives from it. The Bench's foundational premise that the life of every citizen is precious is the exact legal phrasing used by courts in the country to enforce the State's constitutional obligations.

Under Indian jurisprudence, the Right to Life imposes a positive duty on the State to safeguard human life, provide essential medical care, and prevent a citizen

from dying due to starvation or health failure, even during a voluntary hunger strike.

To trigger this protection, the petitioner moved the High Court under Article 226 of the Constitution, which empowers High Courts to issue writs, orders, or directions to the Government for the enforcement of fundamental rights.

The High Court used this constitutional tool to bypass standard administrative delays and directly ordered the Central and Delhi Governments to initiate daily medical monitoring.

Despite the judicial backing, the subsequent police action has highlighted a direct clash between different constitutional principles. While the State acted under the mandate of protecting life, supporters viewed the police response as a severe restriction on democratic rights.

The entire controversy centers on how both sides interpret the law regarding public protests versus personal liberty.

Supporters, family members, and legal aides argue that the police action was a violation of fundamental rights. They contend that a peaceful hunger strike is a protected form of democratic expression under the freedom of speech and the right to assemble peacefully.

Furthermore, they argue that removing an individual and attempting to administer medical care without the express consent of the person or their family

directly infringes upon personal liberty.

Activists and organisers point out a distinct gap between the High Court's text and the actual police operation. They emphasize that the High Court did not explicitly order the police to clear the protest site or forcefully evict the organisers.

From their perspective, the administration used the court's medical welfare directives merely as a legal shield to dismantle a peaceful demonstration.

The dispute over personal liberty has now moved from the protest site to the hospital ward. After being admitted to Safdarjung Hospital, the Ladakh-based activist refused to accept intravenous fluids or medical treatment. At the same time, his family has demanded that the hospital share his official medical reports with full transparency.

In contrast, the Delhi Police and state authorities justify the intervention by pointing to their legal obligations. The High Court had explicitly ruled that whatever medical intervention was required to check his deteriorating health condition must be taken based on the evaluation of Government doctors.

Because medical experts warned that prolonged fasting posed an immediate risk to his vital organs, the authorities maintain they were bound by the court's command to safeguard his life.

The state further argues that the right to life takes

precedence over the right to continue an indefinite fast when death becomes a distinct possibility.

Legally, if an individual's health crosses a life-threatening threshold, authorities face the risk of being held accountable for negligence. The administration contends that letting a citizen cross into critical organ failure without intervening would violate the State's ultimate constitutional duty to preserve human life.

To prevent such deep institutional standoffs from repeating, both sides need to choose open dialogue over conflict. When protests reach a standstill, the focus should shift to peaceful discussions. Creating a trusted space to talk allows everyone to address the real issues instead of clashing in public.

A positive approach requires mutual respect. The government must respect the right to peaceful protest. At the same time, organisers must protect the health of their leaders. Cooperating on medical care keeps the focus on the cause and prevents a life-threatening crisis.

The best path forward is to move from the streets to the negotiating table. By holding structured meetings with officials, both sides can find a solution. This approach honours public demands while keeping everyone safe and orderly.

The writer is a senior journalist covering legal affairs

NGT pulls up authorities over illegal dairies on Yamuna floodplains

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has pulled up authorities over the continued operation of illegal dairies on the Yamuna floodplains, directing the MCD and Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) to file fresh reports.

The green body was hearing a plea alleging that authorities had failed to implement its April 2024 order directing the removal of illegal dairy farms from the Yamuna floodplain, particularly a major encroachment in Chak Chilla village near Mayur Nature Park.

In an order dated July 15, a bench comprising NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert member Afrooz Ahmad said the authorities had failed to ensure full compliance despite clear directions.

The bench examined a status report filed by the DPCC after inspections in the "O-

Zone" — a protected area where no construction is allowed — where officials found scattered encroachment shelters (jhuggis), temporary cattle sheds, fodder and heaps of cattle dung.

"Several temporary animal shelters with fodder for feeding cattle are also observed... Heaps of cattle

dung were also observed at several dispersed locations," the bench noted, referring to inspections conducted in areas below the DND Flyover, Namo Bharat RRTS corridor, and near New Friends Colony.

It said, "The reply of the DPCC reveals that the order of the tribunal has not been complied with. The temporary animal shelters with fodder for feeding cattle were observed in the site inspection by the officers of the DPCC, and in the site inspection, heaps of cattle dung were also found, and 50-60 bovine animals were found grazing in the open grasslands."

Use of swear words, profanities, vulgar expletives will not amount to obscenity: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi



The Supreme Court has said that mere swear words, profanities and vulgar expletives, however offensive or uncivil, will not amount to obscenity.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and Vipul M Pancholi — while hearing a man's plea challenging a high court order that confirmed the trial court's conviction of him under Section 294 of the Indian Penal Code (IPC) — observed that abusive or vulgar language by itself does not constitute the offence of obscenity under the Section.

"For an utterance to be considered

obscene, it must be shown that it was lascivious, appealed to prurient interests and had the tendency to deprave and corrupt the minds of those who are exposed to it.

"Tested on this anvil, even if all the allegations levelled in the complaint are

taken at their face value and accepted to be true in entirety, the same cannot be held to be obscene," the top court said in a judgment on Friday.

It said that such words, however abusive, unpalatable or uncivil, do not satisfy the requirement of Section 294(b) of IPC.

"It is nobody's case that use of such words caused annoyance to others in a public place, which is a mandatory ingredient of the Section, much less to the complainant. In the absence thereof, we find that the offence under Section 294(b) IPC is not made out," the bench said.



Nirmohi Akhara seeks public trust status for Ram Temple trust

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Nirmohi Akhara has approached the Supreme Court seeking a direction to the Centre to reconstitute the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Theerth Kshetra Trust, which manages the affairs of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, as a "public trust".

In its application filed before the apex court, Nirmohi Akhara has sought directions declaring that the existing structure and composition of the trust as a "private trust" was inconsistent with the spirit and intent of the top court's November 2019 verdict in the Ram Janmabhoomi-Babri Masjid land dispute case.

The application has been filed in the disposed of matter in which the apex court on November 9, 2019, delivered a landmark verdict that paved the way

for the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

The 2019 verdict also directed the Centre to allot a five-acre plot to the Sunni Waqf Board for building a mosque.

The Nirmohi Akhara filed the application through Mahant Raja Ramchandracharya Ateet Guru Raghunath Das.

It has sought a direction to the Centre "to suitably recast the scheme and reconstitute the trust as a public trust and include therein structural safeguards for appropriate oversight of the decisions of the board of trustees by the seers of Ramanandi Bairagi Sampradaya with supervisory powers over the decisions of the board".

The application has also sought to lay down the guiding principles for the appointment of trustees by the Centre.

Delhi court orders Bangladeshi national's deportation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



A Delhi court has convicted a Bangladeshi national for fraudulently obtaining Indian identity documents and directed that he be deported to his home country after completion of legal formalities, police said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Sabu alias Shabu Sardar, was convicted by a city court on July 18 in a case registered by Paharganj.

According to police, the case stemmed from specific intelligence developed by a team on alleged Bangladeshi nationals residing illegally in Delhi

after assuming false identities. Acting on the input, police apprehended Sardar from Paharganj.

During the investigation, it was established that he had entered India illegally and had allegedly obtained an Indian passport, Aadhaar card, PAN card, bank account and other identity documents by concealing his

nationality and using forged credentials.

The investigation team collected documentary, digital and technical evidence, including passport and immigration records and forged identity documents, which established the accused's identity and illegal stay in the country.

The probe also established the alleged modus operandi adopted by the accused to procure genuine Indian identity documents based on false particulars, police said.

Faced with what the prosecution described as overwhelming evidence, the accused did not contest the charges and pleaded guilty.



Abhishek Banerjee being escorted by police and security personnel as he arrives to give his voice sample before a magistrate in connection with an investigation into his alleged intimidatory speech during the West Bengal assembly election campaign at the Bidhannagar court in Kolkata

PTI

of applicable rules, according to a senior official.

Stating that the building was his constituency office, the Diamond Harbour MP claimed that the office was built legally on purchased land and after obtaining requisite permissions.

The petitioner's advocate,

FROM THE WORLD

INDONESIA

5 rescued in shipwreck

Rescuers on Saturday evening found five survivors, including a 7-year-old girl, from a passenger boat that sank earlier in the week in eastern Indonesia waters and were searching for 20 other people still missing. The KM Nurul Salsa, which was carrying 78 passengers and crew, experienced engine failure and sank Wednesday about 43 nautical miles (79 kilometres) from the port in the Selayar Islands, in South Sulawesi Province.

The five survivors were found late Saturday afloat, clinging to a fish trap belonging to a local fisherman, Muhammad Arif Anwar, head of the Makassar Search and Rescue Office, said in a statement. At least one person is known to have died from the accident. The five survivors were found before dark and evacuated by a fishing boat. (AP)

PERU

Five dead in earthquake

A 5.5 magnitude earthquake shook the Andes region of Peru, killing at least five people, authorities said Sunday. More than 20 people were injured, and 300 have been displaced. The US Geological Survey reported quake struck on Saturday at 9.24 pm, with its epicentre located 2 km west-southwest of the city of Sicaya in Huancaayo province. It was 10 km deep. Peru's National Civil Defence Institute said in a statement that the total number of missing is still unknown. Several buildings collapsed or suffered structural damage, including local church and convent. Luis Vasquez, head of the local civil defence office, told journalists that use of rustic adobe materials in construction in that Andean area has contributed to greater impact and damage. (AP)

Rescuers in China search rubble for survivors of landslide that killed eight, left 34 missing

ANDY WONG/KANIS LEUNG
■ Chongqing (China)

Rescue crews used excavators on Sunday to comb through the rubble in search of survivors from a landslide in the southwestern Chinese city of Chongqing that killed at least eight people and left another 34 missing.

Massive amounts of rocks and soil roared down a slope and buried more than 10 residential buildings early Friday in Pengshui County on the outskirts of Chongqing.

On Sunday morning, about nine rescuers were seen carrying a sealed orange bag from the scene. It was not

US strikes Iran as Israel warns of widening conflict

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Dubai

The United States launched more airstrikes at Iran on Sunday in response to the killing of US troops, and Iran fired missiles toward Jordan that risked widening the conflict into neighbouring Israel.

Step by step, the US and Iran have returned closer to all-out war as last month's interim deal meant to permanently end the fighting has crumbled and shipping traffic in the Strait of Hormuz has largely stalled.

Both sides have targeted civilian infrastructure relied on by millions of people.

The US military said the latest strikes targeted Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard to retaliate for Friday's killing of troops in Jordan. The campaign, now in its second week, has seen the US target bridges, water desalination plants and electrical facilities in Iran. Tehran has hit US-allied countries throughout the Middle East.

Kuwait, Jordan and Bahrain again activated air defences for

incoming Iranian drones and missiles. Israel warned that missiles launched toward neighbouring Jordan could cause fire to spill over into Israeli territory for the first time in weeks.

The US military's Central Command said it hit "Iranian military coastal surveillance and air defence facilities, maritime capabilities and missile and drone storage sites." It said the attack was designed to degrade Iran's ability to control the strait and "swiftly punish Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps forces," a power base in Iran's theocracy that controls its ballistic missile arsenal.

Footage released by the US military appeared to show strikes carried out by fighter jets and by Tomahawk cruise missiles launched from the sea. One target site appeared to be in a valley of a mountainous region. The Guard often has missile bases and other military equipment tucked into mountain ranges.

Iran's atomic energy agency said US strikes targeted the construction site of a planned nuclear



power plant in the southwest, state television reported.

Satellite images from Planet Labs PBC of the Darkhovin nuclear plant site showed earth clearing but little construction as of July 9. Iran did not previously announce it as being targeted.

The International Atomic Energy Agency said the site, in the "very early stages of construction," con-

tained no nuclear material when the UN watchdog last visited.

Jordan's military said it shot down several Iranian missiles. The country hosts major US bases and relies on US air-defence systems. The missiles did not cause casualties or damage, according to Jordan's military.

Israel's military said Iranian mis-

siles launched toward the Jordanian port city of Aqaba just across the border could spill over, warning Israelis to expect the first air-raided sirens in weeks.

Eilat, the Israeli city that neighbours Aqaba, cited security officials as saying two interceptors were launched from its outskirts to prevent the fall of debris.

During the latest fighting, Iran has focused attacks on US-allied Arab states rather than Israel, which launched the war with the US on February 28.

Kuwait said one of its power and water desalination plants was attacked for the second time in two days, causing fires. Its Ministry of Electricity, Water and Renewable Energy said the power grid remains stable. In Kuwait, about 90 per cent of drinking water comes from desalination.

The secretary-general of the six-nation Gulf Cooperation Council, Jassem Mohamed al-Budaiwi, has accused Iran of war crimes for strikes on infrastructure and civilian facilities.

International humanitarian law generally protects civilian infra-

structure such as bridges and power plants from attack, but such sites can lose protection if used for military purposes. In such cases, attacks must be proportionate and minimise civilian harm.

US President Donald Trump has threatened to target Iran's power stations and bridges to try to compel Tehran to loosen its hold on the Strait of Hormuz, which saw one-fifth of global oil supplies transit before the war. Recent attacks suggest the US military is carrying out that plan.

The US in the past week reimposed a naval blockade on Iranian ports to halt its shipments of crude oil. The military on Saturday said it had redirected five ships and disabled one since then.

A maritime organisation overseen by the US Navy said Sunday that the threat to mariners is severe after previous Iranian attacks, "with deliberate hostile action considered highly likely." It said traffic remained low, with eight transits on Saturday and three on Friday. The daily average before the war was almost 140.

Afghanistan seeks deeper trade ties with India, pitches for easier business access

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kabul

Afghanistan's top trading body has called for expanding trade and investment ties with India, stressing the need to ease business procedures, remove administrative barriers and facilitate the issuance of business visas.

The proposals were discussed in Kabul during a meeting between Afghanistan Chamber of Commerce and Investment (ACCI) Chairman Sayed Karim Hashemi and Indian Ambassador to Afghanistan Yatin Patel.

The two sides held talks "in the framework of a strategic and diplomatic dialogue", according to a statement released by the trading body on Saturday.

The meeting comes amid a sharp decline in Afghanistan's transit trade with neighbouring Pakistan, which fell to \$367 million in FY26 from about \$5 billion in FY21, as Kabul increasingly shifted to alternative trade routes, including through Iran.

India has been strengthening connectivity with Afghanistan through Iran's Chabahar port, which pro-



vides direct access to the landlocked country while bypassing Pakistan, which does not allow overland transit of Indian goods to Afghanistan.

India-Afghanistan bilateral trade stood at \$907.85 million in 2025-26.

India has also been stepping up engagement with Kabul, with Afghan Agriculture Minister Mawlawi Ataullah Omari visiting New Delhi earlier this month.

According to the ACCI statement, Hashemi reaffirmed the trading body's commitment to strengthening long-

term economic cooperation with India and highlighted the importance of facilitating trade procedures and institutional development in the private sector.

Referring to his recent visit to India, Hashemi "stressed the need to sustain and deepen economic cooperation in the fields of agricultural exports, handicrafts, mining, and mineral resources."

"He also presented several strategic proposals aimed at increasing Afghanistan's exports, including expanding access to target markets,

improving logistics infrastructure, and facilitating the issuance of business visas," the statement added.

The Indian ambassador welcomed the proposals and "reaffirmed India's support in the identified areas of cooperation. He stated that plans are underway to organise joint trade exhibitions, specialised business forums, and the exchange of trade delegations between the two countries", the statement said.

The ACCI said both sides agreed to pursue sustainable cooperation in trade, investment and infrastructure development and strengthen long-term economic, political and cultural ties based on "transparency, efficiency and mutual benefit".

India-Afghanistan bilateral trade has largely remained around the \$1 billion mark over the past five years.

India has built the 218-km Zaranj-Delaram highway in western Afghanistan, linking the Iranian border with Afghanistan's ring road network, to facilitate trade and humanitarian supplies. The route is seen as a key component of India's connectivity strategy with Afghanistan and Central Asia.

India ties expected to stay course under new UK PM

ADITI KHANNA
■ London

Strategic experts forecast that the strength of the India-UK partnership will stay the course under incoming British prime minister Andy Burnham, who clinched the Labour Party leadership in the same week as the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) entered into force.

Burnham, 56, was elected unopposed on Friday and will take over from Keir Starmer at Downing Street on Monday after the formal choreography of the handover of power is completed. While much is expected to change, given the former mayor of Greater



British Prime Minister Andy Burnham

Manchester's pledge to do things differently, the one major constant in terms of foreign policy is expected on the India front.

"Over this past year, we have valued close engagement with the Greater Manchester authorities, particularly Mr Andy Burnham, whose energy and warm support has done much to

strengthen India-North-England ties," Vishakha Yaduvanshi, the Consul General of India in Manchester, told PTI.

As the first head of India's new diplomatic mission in the UK, Yaduvanshi views the Consulate's opening in March last year as a "landmark moment" that spotlights the tremendous poten-

tial of the north of England – "its industries, academia and sporting ethos" – within the India-UK relationship.

"His [Burnham's] 2019 visit to India, meeting with the former Indian high commissioner [Vikram Doraiswami] in December 2025, and his virtual participation in the India-North England Opportunity Summit [March 2026] reflect a longstanding commitment to this partnership," she said.

Burnham has spoken of "fond memories" from the visit that took in Mumbai, Bengaluru and Delhi seven years ago, coordinated by the Manchester India Partnership (MIP) – an organisation set up for businesses and universities to engage with India. (PTI)

Nigerian children pay the price for West Asia crisis as malnutrition, poverty surge

OPE ADETAYO
■ Sokoto (Nigeria)

Maryam Aminu was hardly surprised when the last of her six children was diagnosed with malnutrition in April for a second time. She was barely feeding the 18-month-old regularly, let alone with nutritious foods.

Although the family in northwest Nigeria has struggled with economic hardship, their situation deteriorated after February, when her husband, Shehu Aminu, lost his job as a taxi driver due to a spike in the retail price of petrol caused by the war in Iran.

"When she was diagnosed the second time, even though I suspected it, I was sad and angry because I knew why," Aminu said in the living area of their unvarnished two-bedroom house in the quiet town of Kware, Sokoto, as ash from the coal stove billowed into the room. "Times are tough, and

the food is not consistent."

Children relapsing into malnutrition has become an increasingly common occurrence in the state and across northern Nigeria, according to local health and aid workers, who cite knock-on effects from the Iran war.

Northern Nigeria, one of the world's poorest regions, is already under pressure from an insurgency crisis. Now, the conflict in West Asia has worsened food security for millions of people living in poverty, especially children.

At the same time, Nigerian President Bola Tinubu's vast economic reforms sparked high inflation after fuel subsidies were removed three years ago and the currency was devalued. A World Bank technical report this week stated that 139 million Nigerians are now poor or vulnerable to poverty.

If the war in the Middle East continues, up to 23.4 million addition-



al children could fall into monetary poverty – meaning a lack of income or consumption – by the end of the year, the United Nations children's agency UNICEF said in a report this week. It warned that at least 80 per cent would be in Africa and Asia.

"Children are paying the price for the escalating conflict in the Middle East, including children

far beyond the region," said UNICEF Executive Director Catherine Russell. "The longer this continues, the worse the consequences will be."

Amid the Iran war, the closure of the Strait of Hormuz – through which a fifth of the world's oil and gas passed before the war – sent a ripple effect across the world. A worldwide fuel shock drove up

the prices of everything from gas and groceries to fertiliser and airline tickets.

In Nigeria, fuel pump prices jumped from 800 naira (\$0.58) per litre in February to 1,400 naira (\$1.02) in April, with a knock-on effect on the prices of food and necessities.

US President Donald Trump has been trying to force Iran to fully reopen the route for months, turning to everything from airstrikes and naval blockades to negotiations and threats.

In Sokoto, where the soaring prices have brought more hardship for families, health workers told The Associated Press that they've been seeing more children returned to health facilities this year after falling back into malnutrition.

At a hospital in Sokoto, records shared with AP show nearly 40 children previously treated for malnutrition since February are currently under treatment again,

in addition to those not documented.

"I am worried and sometimes angry about the increasing numbers we are seeing," said health worker Halimah Muhammad.

Beyond current realities, soaring prices and economic hardship mean that children in poor households are more likely to be stunted in the long term, UNICEF's Russell said in an interview with the AP as she was visiting Sokoto this week.

"Their development will be compromised. They are less likely to stay in school because their parents are under so much financial stress. So the long-term implications for children are absolutely terrible," said Russell.

The war has also affected fertiliser supplies and prices, threatening the planting season and worsening the fate of mostly farming communities in northern Nigeria who have struggled

to access their farmlands amid a deadly conflict with armed groups.

"I wake up every morning unhappy, seeing I can no longer provide for my family," said Shehu, Maryam's husband. "Then, 2,000 naira could buy you a nutritious meal for the whole family. Now, you need 5,000 naira to buy what 2,000 naira would buy."

Most of their meals are pap, a kind of corn pudding, and rice. "There is no way to feed the children," he said.

People in northwest Nigeria are caught between regular attacks by bandit groups who specialise in kidnapping for ransom and Islamist militants who have been expanding their territory. The Iran war, analysts say, compounds the impact.

"This distant war offers no relief for the north's vulnerable," Ikemesit Effiong, a partner at SBM Intelligence, a Lagos-based geopolitical risk advisory, said. (AP)

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Deloitte projects 6.5%-6.8% GDP expansion in FY27



Deloitte India on Sunday projected India's economy to grow at 6.5-6.8 per cent in the current fiscal, with growth expected to strengthen in the second half of the year supported by festive demand, monetary easing, and a gradual stabilisation in global conditions.

In its latest edition of Economic Outlook report, Deloitte said India entered 2026 in a Goldilocks phase, with macroeconomic fundamentals appearing unusually well balanced, but geopolitical developments altered the global landscape with tensions in the Middle East disrupting critical shipping routes, triggering volatility in commodity prices and weakening investor sentiment. This resulted in a wider trade deficit, sustained capital outflows, and a sharp depreciation of the rupee against the US dollar within a matter of weeks. Against this backdrop, the RBI had last month lowered India's GDP growth estimates for current fiscal to 6.6 per cent, from 6.9 per cent estimated earlier. GDP grew 7.7 per cent in the previous (2025-26) fiscal.

Deloitte India Economist, Rumki Majumdar said the global environment has become more uncertain. (PTI)

‘Semicon 2.0 equity incentives to boost AI chip investment’



Provisions under Semicon 2.0 to provide incentives to Indian chip-making firms against equity are expected to drive largescale investment required for the development of advanced chips for technology such as artificial intelligence, a senior Government official has said.

Under Semicon 2.0, which has a budget of ₹1.27 lakh crore, the Central Government has prioritised chip design by Indian companies.

In an interview to PTI on Saturday, Ministry of Electronics and IT Secretary S Krishnan said advance chip design may need thousands of crores of investments.

“We intend to provide more funding. Otherwise, under design-linked incentive scheme, you get only about ₹15 crore. Now, to design high-end chips you need ₹1,000 crore or more.

“At the same time, the government can't give everything. This is why you have this combination saying that you get investment from a venture capitalist or somebody who believes that you will be able to bring out this chip, and we will co-invest,” he said. (PTI)

Naveen Jindal Group in nuclear talks with US, French firms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Naveen Jindal Group has initiated discussions with global nuclear technology providers including France-based EDF and Westinghouse of the US for its proposed nuclear power projects in India, a person in the know said.



The Group is also in discussions with State-owned Nuclear Power Corporation of India (NPCIL) to explore possibilities of sourcing technology for future nuclear projects with large module reactors (LMRs) of 700 MW and above.

The steel-to-ports conglomerate plans to develop around 18 GW of nuclear power capacity across multiple states with an estimated investment of ₹2 lakh crore, contributing to the Government's target of achieving 100 GW of nuclear power capacity by 2047.

Indian States should ramp up fiscal discipline and investment priorities



While averages are deceptive aggregate data blatantly lies. Disaggregated data can throw up surprises in all domains — be it in health-care or financial robustness of a country.

For instance, India being a federal structure the country's overall risk profile does not reflect individual contributions of the States. At the combined, all-State level, the picture may look reassuring. But the disaggregated numbers tell a different story.

Eighteen of India's 28 States breached the constitutionally mandated ceiling of 3 per cent of gross State domestic product (GSDP) on fiscal deficit in FY25. The CAG (Comptroller and Auditor General) called it the sharpest downfall since the pandemic year of FY21.

While some States lag behind, others compensate making the national average look good. But it's time to take a close look at the States and their investment priorities.

State-level fiscal stress isn't a self-contained problem. It intersects with a national growth trajectory that is



already under pressure due to the West Asia crisis. The IMF's projection for India crossing the \$5 trillion economy mark has slipped four years, to 2028-29.

Three different scenarios with a common baseline

Let me take Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, West Bengal, Rajasthan and Kerala. They are at the persistent core of India's most indebted states. Punjab's debt has not dipped below 40 per cent of GSDP since 2017.

Punjab has run a revenue deficit of at least 3 per cent of GSDP for six consecutive years, meaning its day-to-day spending routinely exceeds its day-to-day revenue. Interest payments alone consumed close to a fifth of its revenue expenditure in FY25. Add salaries and pensions, and committed, non-discretionary spending swallowed well over half of

everything the state spent on its revenue account. That leaves barely more than 1 per cent of GSDP for capital expenditure — the kind of spending that actually builds roads, power infrastructure or irrigation capacity rather than just servicing yesterday's obligations.

Take Odisha for example, it's a state that has posted a revenue surplus every year since 2016 regardless of which party governs it, funds its transfer scheme without any additional borrowing — the money comes out of revenue it already has left over. Maharashtra, by contrast, funds its Ladli Behna Yojana against a revenue account that is already in deficit, which means the scheme is effectively financed through borrowing, even though the state's overall debt load, at roughly a fifth of GSDP, remains com-

fortable by national standards. This is the crux of why a fiscal deficit ceiling alone will not tell the whole story — a State that borrows to build assets is in a fundamentally different position from one borrowing to pay salaries and interest, even if both show up identically against the 3 per cent limit.

Why this matters for India's growth story right now

Fiscally stretched states are the least equipped to close that gap through their own effort, because they have the least capital-expenditure headroom to invest in the infrastructure — power, roads, irrigation — that underscores real growth rather than budget-assumption growth. The Centre's 50-year interest-free capital expenditure loans to states, now sized at ₹2 trillion for FY27, have been a genuine cushion here. But they function as a subsidy States lean on rather than a substitute for building their own fiscal space, and they don't resolve the underlying revenue-deficit problem in states like Punjab or West Bengal.

This all lands at a moment when the Centre itself has less room to absorb shocks on States' behalf. The Government of India's own liabilities, net of on-lending to states, run above 55 per cent of GDP — nearly double the states' combined liability ratio. In a period of global market volatility and height-

ened sensitivity to sovereign and sub-sovereign credit signals, a handful of visibly over-leveraged States raises the cost of capital not just for themselves but, at the margin, for how international investors price India risk more broadly.

The compliance gap: Why CAG findings need muscle

States are required to table CAG reports in their legislatures, and in principle a Public Accounts Committee is meant to scrutinise them and produce an Action Taken Report. In practice, the rigour of that follow-through varies enormously by State, and there is no binding mechanism that converts a CAG finding into a fiscal correction. A State can breach the ceiling for successive years, appear in the CAG's tables each time, and face no change in its market borrowing terms or central assistance as a direct result.

The 16th Finance Commission's displeasure with this gap is visible in its recommendations. It explicitly pushed states to end off-budget borrowing — the practice of routing debt through State-owned entities or special purpose vehicles so it doesn't show up in headline fiscal-deficit numbers — and asked that the definition of deficit and debt be widened to capture it uniformly. That recommendation exists precisely because States have used such vehicles to stay

technically compliant while structurally over-leveraged.

Now somehow the states have to be inspired to comply. Another tricky observation that perhaps needs a deeper study is the social sector spend.

Social-sector spending — education, health, water and sanitation, housing, and welfare of scheduled castes and tribes — makes up a little over 40 per cent of the average budget in some states. But the states that spend the most on it are not the states with the best outcomes.

The uncomfortable fiscal fact is that the states with the most catching up to do are also the ones with the weakest revenue bases to sustain that spending without deeper borrowing.

This vicious cycle needs to be understood and addressed. This is where state leadership plays an important role. Freebies are counterproductive beyond a point. Make people work. Building infrastructure both physical and social will ensure citizens earn livelihood and states contribute meaningfully during economic headwinds.

As PM Modi says in a federal structure, the states have to be both competitive and cooperative for taking the country forward. Let's hope the state leaders are listening.

The author is a global thought leader and a futurist, who has served on the Board of Engineers India Ltd (Union Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas)

Aluminium industry seeks finance ministry support amid global trade pressures

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Aluminium Association of India has sought the finance ministry's support, citing shrinking export markets due to high US tariffs, rising protectionism in Mexico, Indonesia's capacity expansion, Russian dumping, and a surge in low-quality scrap and aluminium imports from Gulf and ASEAN countries.

In a representation to the Central Board of Indirect Taxes (CBIC), the association said since the world is using and promoting imports of only high-quality scrap, it is the need of the hour for India to establish similar quality standards.

It said that as major economies are protecting their domestic aluminium industries through higher import duties and other trade measures to attract invest-



ments, expand capacities and reduce import dependence, India should also strengthen safeguards.

It urged the government to continue the existing duty structure on aluminium products and consider higher basic customs duty and other trade measures to curb the surge in imports of poor quality scrap, citing examples of countries such as Mexico, the US and Canada, where

duties range between 15 per cent and 50 per cent. The association has requested to ensure that the final BIS standard titled 'Aluminium & Aluminium Alloy Scrap — Requirements & Conditions of Delivery' is notified without changes, saying it has already been approved by bodies such as NITI Aayog, and BIS.

It said that this will ensure that India does not become a dumping ground

for unchecked quality of hazardous global aluminium scrap. Once notified, it would classify aluminium scrap into different grades based on aluminium content, ranging from above 95 per cent to below 60 per cent, it said.

The association has urged the government to maintain the existing import duty on aluminium scrap until the pending BIS quality standard is notified and grade-wise HSN (harmonised nomenclature) codes are introduced.

This would allow the government to distinguish between high-quality scrap used by recyclers and lower-grade scrap with higher impurities, it said.

It also suggested raising the import duty to 7.5 per cent on low-grade aluminium scrap (Grades 3 to 7) thereafter to curb imports of poor-quality scrap into the country.



Gold, Silver face tough week on West Asia risks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Gold and silver are expected to remain on the back foot in the next week as traders assess the impact of the escalating West Asia conflict, firm crude oil prices and key global macroeconomic data releases, analysts said.

Investors will also closely watch a busy calendar of key numbers, including US weekly jobless claims and flash PMI, along with monetary policy decisions and key economic indicators from Europe and China, for fresh cues on global interest rates. The US military on Sunday carried out fresh airstrikes against Iran following attacks on American-linked installations in Jordan, further escalating tensions in an already volatile West Asia, they added.

“Momentum in gold remains corrective as investors look ahead to the Federal Reserve's meeting towards month-end. However, focus will remain on developments between the US and Iran,” said Pranav Mer, Senior Vice President, EBG — Commodity &

Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd. On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), gold futures for August delivery declined ₹2,572, or nearly 2 per cent, closing at ₹1.4 lakh per 10 grams. Silver for the September contract slumped ₹6,261, or 2.8 per cent, to ₹216 lakh per kilogram on the MCX.

“Gold extended its corrective phase last week as a stronger US dollar, firm crude oil prices, and expectations of prolonged higher interest rates continued to weigh on bullion,” said Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst — Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities.

He said every rebound in gold attracted fresh selling pressure, suggesting traders preferred booking gains rather than building fresh long positions. The rupee's mild correction offered little support as the stronger dollar continued to dominate sentiment. In global markets, Comex gold futures slipped \$95, or 2.3 per cent, to close at \$4,018.8 per ounce during the past week, while silver plunged nearly \$4, or 6.4% to \$56.32 per ounce in New York.

Commerce Secretary to visit Geneva for WTO review



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal is visiting Geneva this week for India's eighth trade policy review report, an official said.

The secretary is leading a team of Indian officials to the headquarters of the World Trade Organisation (WTO), the official said. The report will be released this month only.

Such reports include detailed chapters examining the trade policies and practices of the member. It also includes trade policymaking institutions and a country's macro-economic situation.

The frequency with which WTO members are reviewed depends on their share of world trade, according to the World Trade Organisation.

The four biggest traders (European Union,

United States, China, Japan) are reviewed every three years. The next 16 biggest traders are reviewed every five years (India falls in this category), and all other members are reviewed every seven years.

The objectives of the Trade Policy Review Mechanism, as expressed in an annex of the Marrakesh Agreement, include facilitating the smooth functioning of

the multilateral trading system by enhancing the transparency of members' trade policies.

According to the WTO's World Trade Statistics, between 2005 and 2024, India's share of global merchandise exports has nearly doubled, rising from 1 per cent to 1.8 per cent; similarly, its share in global commercial services exports has more than doubled, rising from 2 per cent to 4.3 per cent.

NITI Aayog to review industrial corridor framework

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government has launched a review of the institutional and implementation framework governing industrial corridors, industrial parks and integrated manufacturing ecosystems, seeking to identify bottlenecks and recommend reforms to accelerate project delivery and improve investor experience.

As part of the exercise, NITI Aayog will this week hold a stakeholder consultation to gather recommendations on policy, regulatory, institutional and implementation changes needed to strengthen India's industrial competitiveness and support its goal of becoming



a developed nation by 2047, sources said.

The review is being undertaken under the guidance of the High-Level Committee on Implementation of Viksit Bharat Goals (HLC-VB), chaired by NITI Aayog member Rajiv Gauba, which was constituted by the government to monitor key development programmes

and infrastructure projects and recommend measures to speed up implementation. The consultation will focus on five broad areas: project planning and land development, regulatory and institutional reforms, project execution and delivery, connectivity and logistics, and improving investor experience and future readiness.

Stakeholders have been asked to identify implementation bottlenecks, their underlying causes and practical reforms, while indicating whether the proposed changes require administrative action, policy or regulatory changes, legislative amendments or digital interventions.

They will be asked to flag implementation delays and propose fixes including in master planning, approvals, land allotment, contracting, and last-mile logistics connectivity, and to specify whether recommended reforms would require administrative action, regulatory changes, legislative amendments or digital interventions.

Reliance Retail Ventures Ltd to scale online business this year

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Reliance Retail Ventures Ltd (RRVL) will 'rapidly' scale its online business, expand dark stores and strengthen omnichannel capabilities, as the retailer expects these investments to translate into higher margins and earnings growth, a top company official said.

Outlining a three-year roadmap, Reliance Retail CFO Dinesh Taluja said the company will invest in the infrastructure of JioMart and omnichannel reach across platforms, even as margins have come under pressure from rising technology and



dark-store investments. “We are looking at growing our online businesses pretty rapidly during this year. We will expand dark stores. We will grow our omnichannel platforms. We will grow JioMart,” Taluja said in the company's earnings call.

Besides, it will also focus on improving the operational metrics around avail-

ability, speed, and reliability with a market-by-market focus on achieving positive unit economics.

“Each market, the unit economics, we need to have a clear path to positive unit economics. Accordingly, we are evaluating each and every market and focusing our investments in that manner,” Taluja said.

PROSPECT

Shah lays foundation stone for Amul's curd production plant in West Bengal



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during the foundation stone laying of the world's largest curd production plant under the Amul Bengal Dairy Project at the New Town Convention Centre in Kolkata

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday said the political change in West Bengal was unlike any witnessed in the country since Independence, asserting that the new BJP Government led by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari had revived the quest for “Sonar Bangla” after decades of misrule of the Left and TMC. While virtually laying the foundation stone and performing the bhoomi puja for the ₹700-crore Amul Bengal Dairy Project at Sankrail in Howrah, Shah said he had come to West Bengal “on behalf of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to



Editor of *The Pioneer* Kerala edition Bandi Sudhakar Goud called on the Governor of Kerala, Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar at Raj Bhavan, Thiruvananthapuram on Thursday and presented him with a copy of the newly inaugurated *The Pioneer* Kerala Edition. The Governor congratulated the entire *The Pioneer* team and conveyed his best wishes for the successful journey of the edition

Bio fertilisers: The scientific foundation of India's next agricultural revolution



India's agricultural journey, since Independence, has been one of remarkable transformation. From facing chronic food shortages during the 1960s, the country has emerged as one of the world's largest producers of food grains, fruits, vegetables, milk and several other agricultural commodities. The Green Revolution fundamentally altered India's agricultural landscape through improved seed varieties, expanded irrigation and increased use of chemical fertilisers. These interventions helped India achieve food security and transformed the lives of millions of farmers.

However, every scientific revolution demands continuous evolution. The challenges confronting Indian agriculture today are very different from those of five decades ago. The country now faces declining soil fertility, nutrient imbalance, increasing input costs, climate change, ground-

water contamination and shrinking cultivable land. Therefore, India's next agricultural revolution must focus not merely on increasing production but on ensuring that productivity is sustainable, environmentally responsible and economically rewarding for farmers.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has consistently emphasised that agriculture must move towards sustainability. His vision extends beyond increasing crop production. It seeks to protect India's natural resources while improving farmers' incomes and securing the future of coming generations.

Bio fertilisers: Need of the hour

India today feeds over 1.4 billion people and contributes significantly to global food security. At the same time, the world's population is projected to approach 10 billion by 2050, requiring a substantial increase in food production. Achieving this objective cannot depend solely upon greater use of chemical fertilisers because the ecological costs have become increasingly evident.

Climate change has further complicated the situation. According to the 2024 drought



assessment, 91 districts in India fall under the very high drought risk category, while another 188 districts are categorised as high drought risk. Rainfed agriculture, which supports millions of farmers, has become increasingly vulnerable to erratic rainfall and prolonged dry spells.

In such circumstances, improving soil health has become just as important as improving crop productivity. Healthy soils not only produce higher yields but also retain more water, withstand drought better and require fewer external inputs. This is where bio fertilisers assume national importance.

Unlike conventional fertilisers, bio fertilisers work with nature rather than against it. They contain ben-

eficial living microorganisms that naturally improve nutrient availability, enhance root development, restore microbial diversity and strengthen soil biology.

Instead of merely adding nutrients, they activate the soil's own biological processes, making agriculture more resilient and sustainable.

The hidden cost of excessive chemical fertiliser use

Chemical fertilisers played a transformative role in India's agricultural development, but decades of excessive and imbalanced use have created serious long-term consequences. Scientific studies indicate that crops absorb only 30 to 40 per cent of nutrients supplied through conventional chemical fertilisers. Nearly 60 to 70 per

cent of nutrients are lost through leaching, surface runoff and volatilisation. This not only increases cultivation costs for farmers but also contaminates rivers, groundwater and surrounding ecosystems.

India's ideal nutrient application ratio is 4:2:1 for Nitrogen, Phosphorus and Potassium. However, the present ratio has widened to nearly 10.9:4.4:1, indicating excessive dependence on nitrogen-based fertilisers, particularly urea. This imbalance has gradually reduced nutrient use efficiency and weakened soil fertility.

The findings of the All India Coordinated Research Project on Long Term Fertiliser Experiments, conducted by the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) over several decades, clearly demonstrate that continuous application of chemical fertilisers alone leads to deficiencies of secondary nutrients and micronutrients while reducing long-term productivity.

Excessive nitrogen application also contributes to nitrate contamination in groundwater, posing risks to human health and environmental sustainability.

Why bio fertilisers are a scientific solution?

Bio fertilisers represent one of the most significant scientific innovations in sustainable agriculture. Unlike chemical fertilisers, bio fertilisers do not directly supply nutrients to crops. They contain carefully selected beneficial microorganisms that naturally convert atmospheric nitrogen, insoluble phosphorus, potassium and micronutrients into plant available forms. These microorganisms colonise the root zone, stimulate plant growth, improve nutrient uptake and strengthen the soil ecosystem.

Scientific evidence from global field trials demonstrates that microbial bio fertilisers can improve crop productivity by 12 to 25 per cent, depending upon crop type and soil conditions.

Bio fertilisers restore soil organic matter, increase microbial diversity, improve water holding capacity, enhance drought tolerance, reduce disease incidence, suppress harmful pathogens and improve long-term soil fertility.

The writer is national coordinator of digital library and documentation, BJP

Rahul Himalian assumes additional charge as chairman, managing director, IRCTC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Rahul Himalian

Consequent upon the resignation of Sanjay Kumar Jain as Chairman & Managing Director (CMD), Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation Ltd. (IRCTC), the Ministry of Railways has entrusted the additional charge of the post of CMD, IRCTC, to Rahul Himalian, Director (Tourism & Marketing), IRCTC.

A senior and distinguished officer of the Indian Railway Traffic Service (IRTS) from the 1999 examination batch, Rahul Himalian has over 26 years of rich and diverse experience in the Indian Railways and IRCTC. He has been serving as a whole-time functional director on the Board of IRCTC, a Schedule 'A' Navratna Central

Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Railways, since February 16, 2024. In his capacity as Director (Tourism & Marketing), he has been providing leadership to key departments, including tourism, information technology, human resource development, infrastructure, administration and Rajbhasha.

Himalian has an outstanding academic record. He was the head boy and the best

student at The Lawrence School. He graduated in electrical engineering with a gold medal from NIT Hamirpur and completed his postgraduation in engineering from IIT Delhi, securing a perfect CGPA of 10.00. He was also awarded the prestigious President's Gold Medal for being the Best All-Round Student.

With the assumption of the additional charge of Chairman & Managing Director w.e.f. 20/07/2026, Rahul Himalian will lead the overall operations and strategic direction of IRCTC while continuing to discharge his responsibilities as Director (Tourism & Marketing). IRCTC extends its best wishes to Rahul Himalian and looks forward to the organisation reaching greater milestones under his leadership.

Pijush Hazarika visits Khumtai constituency, takes stock of projects

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati



Assam Agriculture and Irrigation Minister Pijush Hazarika on Sunday visited various areas in Khumtai constituency in Golaghat District and took stock of farming activities and irrigation projects.

The Minister visited Thuramukh in Khumtai and interacted with farmers there who were engaged in farming work despite inclement weather conditions. During the interaction, the farmers apprised the Minister of how they have profited by cultivating three crops a year and how horticulture crops like cucumber and bottle gourd have given them the most profits. Minister Hazarika

stressed the importance of adopting parallel cropping, like areca nut trees and black pepper, for multiplying farmers' income. The Minister also took stock of their issues like irrigation needs, market linkage for their produce, cold storage etc and assured them of strategic interventions to solve these problems.

Furthermore, the Minister reviewed the status of irrigation schemes being implemented in the district with the department officials.

He visited a lift irrigation project at Falangani and directed the engineers to make the project more efficient by taking necessary measures to meet the irrigation needs of a large area.

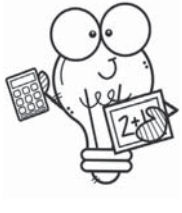
DAILY SUDOKU

	2		3		9	6	4	
	1		7					9
6	8						7	3
4			2					
	7						9	
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2	6						5	4
1					5		6	
	9	7	6		4		1	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (18.7.26)								
4	9	1	3	6	7	2	5	8
8	6	3	2	5	1	7	9	4
5	2	7	9	8	4	6	3	1
7	1	9	8	2	3	5	4	6
3	8	4	6	7	5	9	1	2
2	5	6	4	1	9	3	8	7
6	4	2	5	9	8	1	7	3
9	7	8	1	3	6	4	2	5
1	3	5	7	4	2	8	6	9

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
MONDAY | JULY 20, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
		9					
10				12			11
13	14						15
16							
17				18			
			19				
20	21				22		23
24				25			
			26				
27					28		
			29				
30							31

ACROSS

- Saucy in a novel way? (5)
- New ideas to which actors are deaf (5)
- One at the doctor's but without a complaint? (7)
- Two ways to try for admission (5)
- She's a setback for Aidan (5)
- Singer given heart by English National Opera (5)
- Removed from the rent book? (4,3)
- Gardens by the river (3)
- Neglect to order it (4)
- Possibly green article to be found in groups (6)
- It's tough with nothing in store (5)

DOWN

- Would irregular soldiers fire at it? (6)
- Rush to arrange out-of-the-way trips (6)
- It's a sort of fever! (3)
- Beast bringing wicked vice to the East End (5)
- Irked at having done any wrong (7)
- Sunny sort of celebrity? (4)
- Motor club? (6)
- Teacher makes that impatient noise, a bit out of sorts (5)
- Is such a brush one of a set? (5)
- One competitor of several in a rail system (5)
- Food to bake fresh, note (5)

- Merchant doing a swap? (6)
- Unable to move quickly (4)
- Bluff ruler of Westphalia (3)
- Less than presentable as an anagram, but sound (7)
- Sigmund, an informal fellow out of uniform (5)
- Is of negative nature and shows little dash (5)
- Grins stupidly at a pair of spectacles (5)
- It's quite normal that Mr Gore might take a turn (7)
- One cannot take a light view of such practices (5)
- Intends me to join a couple of Poles (5)

- Cook a stew that is never eaten (5)
- Cupidity, it seems, is the desire for more than just a cup (5)
- Naturally enough, the ears play a part in it (7)
- Vegetable served in the gunners' mess? (6)
- It's easy for one to get fifty in front (6)
- It may strike one as a neat motto (6)
- In which dancers express disapproval to us? (5)
- Finance sport to a good end (4)
- Its violent impact puts heart into drama (3)

SOLUTION (18.7.26)

- ACROSS

3. Bio-st
8. Got up
10. Ought
11. Boo
12. Ba+rd
13. Ca-pit-ol
15. Towel
18. Coy
19. P-irate
21. Now-here
22. Iron
23. P-od

DOWN

1. To bat
2. Rub-ic
4. Oval
5. Sort-ly
6. Tu-D-or
7. Sheet
9. To-p
12. Boyhood
30. B-esom
14. T-ow
16. W-ally
17. L-ends
19. P-ri-n-ces
24. Soundly
26. Crated
29. Cue (queue)
31. Ha-Des
32. Peddles
34. Paris
35. Gus
36. D-EN-IM
37. Medic
38. Dekko

DWCD, Sangath organise orientation, felicitation programme under NAMASTE initiative

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Department of Women and Child Development (DWCD), Government of NCT of Delhi, in collaboration with Sangath, successfully organised an orientation and felicitation programme under the NAMASTE (Neurodevelopment and Autism in South Asia: Treatment and Evidence) Programme, reaffirming its commitment to strengthening Early Childhood Development (ECD) services across the National Capital Territory.

The programme focused on promoting the early identification and timely intervention for children with developmental delays and disabilities through a community-based screening approach. The initiative aims to equip frontline functionaries with the knowledge and skills required to identify developmental concerns at an early stage, ensuring

timely referral, intervention, and improved developmental outcomes for children.

The orientation session sensitised Anganwadi functionaries and supervisory staff on the objectives, implementation framework, and significance of the NAMASTE Programme. The initiative is expected to further strengthen community-based early childhood services by enhancing the capacity of frontline workers and improving access to developmental support for children and their families.

The event was graced by Rashmi Singh, secretary,

Department of Women and Child Development, Government of NCT of Delhi, who commended the dedication and tireless efforts of the field functionaries in delivering quality early childhood development services. Addressing the gathering, she emphasised the importance of early screening, timely intervention, and coordinated community-based action in ensuring the holistic development of every child.

During the ceremony, the Secretary felicitated Sadhana Singh, District Officer, East District; Abhishek Singh, Child Development Project Officer

(CDPO); Sandeep, Child Development Project Officer (CDPO); Rahul Verma, District Coordinator, East District; all supervisors of East District; and the best-performing Anganwadi workers of East District in recognition of their exemplary dedication, unwavering commitment, and outstanding contribution towards the successful implementation of the NAMASTE Programme.

The programme concluded with a renewed commitment by the department and its field functionaries to strengthen inclusive, community-based early childhood development services through sustained capacity building, effective implementation, and collaborative efforts.

The recognition of outstanding performers served as an inspiration for all Anganwadi functionaries to continue their dedicated service towards ensuring the holistic growth, development, and well-being of children across East District.

CUTS International calls for harmonised bike taxi rules

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Policy research group CUTS International has urged States to adopt a harmonised regulatory framework for bike taxis to improve first-and-last-mile connectivity and ensure commuter safety.

Launching the report “Harmonising Bike Taxi Regulations in India”, BJP National Spokesperson Gopal Krishna Agarwal said, “As India strengthens its ease of living agenda, an integrated mobil-

ity ecosystem can become a vital driver of connectivity, employment, productivity, and sustainable growth.”

The report highlights regulatory divergence across Delhi, Kerala, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu and

West Bengal, creating uncertainty for workers and platforms. It finds bike taxis cost ₹8-10 per km versus ₹15-18 for autos and provide monthly net incomes of ₹25,000-30,000 to operators.

CUTS (Consumer Unity & Trust Society) has recommended a structured authorisation of non-transport motorcycles, platform-led accountability, harmonised safety and insurance standards, period-based permits, and incentivised EV transition instead of blanket bans.

BRIEFLY

Denish Das emerges as most pricey player at APL's auction



All-rounder Denish Das emerged as the most expensive buy during the marquee player round of the inaugural Assam Premier League (APL) player auction on Sunday, with Barpeta Braves securing his services for ₹12.60 lakh. Sumit Ghadigaonkar was the second-highest buy among the marquee players, joining Charaideo Sunrisers for ₹12.20 lakh, while experienced batter Sibsankar Roy was acquired by Barak Legends for ₹12 lakh. Ayushman Malakar and Swarupam Purkayastha completed the top five marquee buys, with Tezpur Titans and Jorhat Stallions securing them respectively for ₹11.80 lakh each. The marquee player round saw the franchises compete for some of Assam's leading domestic cricketers as they began assembling their squads for the APL, which will commence on August 1. The APL was launched by the Assam Cricket Association in June with the objective of creating a professional and sustainable platform for emerging cricketers while also elevating the standard of domestic cricket across the state. The eight franchises in fray are Jorhat Stallions, Tezpur Titans, Dibrugarh Warriors, Barak Legends, Nagaon Rangers, Barpeta Braves, Guwahati Royals and Charaideo Sunrisers. Among the other notable acquisitions from the marquee player pool, Barak Legends added Abdul Ajij Kuraishi for ₹8.40 lakh and Bhargab Lakhar for ₹5.20 lakh. Barpeta Braves secured Saurav Dihingia for ₹7.80 lakh, while Dibrugarh Warriors added Saahil Jain for ₹7.20 lakh and Jitumoni Kalita for ₹6.20 lakh. The auction continued through the day with franchises looking to build balanced squads from the wider pool of players going under the hammer.

(PTI)

Russell out of Belgian Grand Prix in a blow to F1 title chances



George Russell retired on lap one of the Belgian Grand Prix on Sunday after contact with Lewis Hamilton in a heavy blow to his Formula 1 title chances. Russell was trying to retake a place from Lewis Hamilton around the outside when the Ferrari driver clipped his rear wheel and sent him spinning into the gravel trap. That brought out the safety car. Russell raised his hands in disbelief before leaving the stranded car. "Car crossed over right in front of me," Hamilton said. Russell's Mercedes teammate Kimi Antonelli, the standings leader, was leading after he took pole position Saturday in qualifying. Russell has been struggling to match Antonelli's pace in recent races and has suggested an issue with the Mercedes car may be holding him back.

(AP)

Mbappe passes Messi for career WC record

ALANIS THAMES

■ Miami Gardens

Kylian Mbappe made history at the World Cup on Saturday. He would have preferred a different outcome. The France star moved past Argentina's Lionel Messi for the career World Cup scoring record with 22 goals, scoring twice in a 6-4 loss to England in Saturday's third-place match. Mbappe finished this World Cup with 10 goals, two more than Messi in the race for the Golden Boot, which is awarded to the tournament's top scorer. Should he remain ahead of Messi after Argentina plays Spain in Sunday's final, he would become the first player to win

the Golden Boot twice. "I would have preferred not to be the top scorer in history," Mbappe told Fox Sports in French, "and play in the match tomorrow."

Les Bleus missed out on a chance at playing in their third straight World Cup final when they lost to Spain in the semifinals.

Mbappe scored eight goals to win the Golden Boot four years ago in Qatar, where France lost to Messi and Argentina in a penalty shootout in the final.

His 10 in this year's tournament matched the third most in a World Cup. Just Fontaine had a record 13 goals for France in 1958, Sandor Kocsis of Hungary scored 11 in 1954,



and West Germany's Gerd Muller had 10 in 1970.

Mbappe's quest for the Golden Boot appeared to be going nowhere when France trailed 4-0 at halftime.

Then Mbappe and France came alive in the second

half. He flicked a shot past England goalkeeper Dean Henderson in the 48th minute to begin a rally for Les Bleus, who also got goals from Bradley Barcola and Ousmane Dembele. Michael Olise added two assists,

Messi has work to catch Mbappe for Golden Boot, 3rd Golden Ball in reach

BRIAN MAHONEY

■ New York

Lionel Messi has quite a climb to catch Kylian Mbappe for the Golden Boot.

The Argentina superstar has won just about everything in soccer except for the award for being the leading scorer at the World Cup, and he's now two behind Mbappe after the France striker upped his total to 10 goals in a wild third-place game. Even if Messi can't get there, a record-extending third Golden Ball as the tournament's best player seems well in reach after Sunday's World Cup final against Spain in East Rutherford,



New Jersey. He's already the only player to win the award multiple times since it was first given in 1978, and sparking Argentina's run to a second straight final at age 39 gives him a strong case

for another. "He is the history. He is the legend," Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni said.

The other awards to be presented Sunday for performances at the World Cup are the Golden Glove for the top goalkeeper, and the Best Young Player Award, given to the top player 21 years old or younger. Spain is in good shape to win at least one if not both of those, with Unai Simon allowing only one goal in seven games and 19-year-old Yamine Lamal providing the dazzle up front and showing why he is already considered one of the most promising players in the world.

(AP)

Saka's hat trick lifts England past France in WC third-place game

ALANIS THAMES

■ Miami Gardens

England and France delivered a thriller in a World Cup match that was supposed to be an afterthought.

A day before Lionel Messi and Argentina were set to try and defend their title in a highly anticipated final, Bukayo Saka scored three goals to lead England past Kylian Mbappe and France 6-4 in a wild third-place game.

Mbappe surpassed Messi's record for World Cup goals, scoring twice in the second half. The 27-year-old star has 22 goals in his career and 10 in this World Cup, two ahead of Messi in the Golden Boot race.

It was the highest-scoring World Cup game since Hungary beat El Salvador 10-1 in 1982, and the 10 goals

were the most in a third-place match.

Saka had goals in the 37th minute and in first-half stoppage time, then added his third on a penalty in the 87th for his second career hat trick with England. The Three Lions also got goals from Declan Rice and Ezri Konsa to build a 4-0 halftime lead, and they hung on against a relentless France attack in the second half to secure their second-best finish in the World Cup. England won its only title in 1966.

"I hope that the players can be proud of that in some time," England coach Thomas Tuchel said. "We are fiercely competitive, so we almost don't allow ourselves to be proud of third place because 18 months ago we set the highest goal. We set the



highest dream to chase, and we were very, very ambitious with our dream to make it to the final and win the World Cup. So it's very, very painful if you miss out."

Tuchel said he viewed England's World Cup run as a success despite its collapse in the semifinals. The Three Lions blew a 1-0 lead against Argentina and lost 2-

1 when Messi assisted on two late goals.

Tuchel was criticized for his tactical decisions in the loss, with many wondering what it will take for England to end its decades-long wait for another trophy.

He said Saturday's result was the first step toward closing the gap with teams like Argentina and France.

setting a record with seven in this World Cup, one more than Brazil's Pele, who had six assists in 1970.

France pulled within 4-3 on Mbappe's second goal, when he beat Henderson again with a left-footed strike from about 14 yards in the 66th minute to pass Messi's career mark of 21 goals.

"There were two very different halves," Mbappe said. "During the first one, I can understand why some people think we made fools of ourselves and didn't do the jersey justice. I'd say instead that we were human — and we can't afford to be. We were completely stunned, and they really shook us awake." He said French players wanted to

win for Didier Deschamps, who coached his final game with the national team.

"In the end, we didn't win, and that's a shame for the coach," Mbappe said. "The first half gives the impression that we let him down - that's not at all how we wanted him to feel. This match isn't going to tarnish Didier Deschamps' legacy." France won the World Cup under Deschamps in 2018, lost a gut-wrenching final to Argentina on penalties in 2022, and was shut down offensively by Spain in the semifinals. It was a disappointing end to Deschamps' 14-year tenure after his star-studded squad was among the favorites to win another World Cup.

(AP)

Sam Burns in sole lead at Birkdale, Theegala at T-52

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Royal Birkdale (US)

Sahith Theegala played his best round of the week, a two-under 68 to rise to T-52 after the third round of 154th Open at Royal Birkdale.

The Indian American golfer, who had missed the last three cuts at the Open, birdied second and the seventh and turned in 2-under before he bogeyed the 10th. Two more birdies on the 14th and the 16th saw him get to 3-under and a Top-25 position before a closing bogey and pushed him down. The other two Indian origin players, Aaron Rai



and Akshay Bhatia had earlier missed the halfway cut.

Meanwhile, Sam Burns moved into pole position to win his first Major Championship after emerging from the chasing pack to take a two-shot lead into the final round. The American entered the third round three

shots adrift of 36-hole leader Lucas Herbert but produced an assured 65 to reach ten under at Royal Birkdale.

Ryan Fox earlier surged into contention with the third 62 in two days — a feat achieved by Herbert and Burns on Friday — to get to eight under, where he was joined by Si Woo Kim after a 67 by the South Korean.

American Ryan Gerard, who is competing in his Open debut, is at seven under alongside Herbert of Australia, with Ludvig Aberg, Tommy Fleetwood, Bryson DeCham beau and defending champion Scottie Scheffler among 18 players within six shots of the lead.

The biggest takeaways from the 2026 World Cup

JAMES ROBSON

■ Atlanta

The World Cup final between Spain and defending champion Argentina marks the end of the biggest tournament in the competition's history. At the final whistle in New Jersey on Sunday, a record 104 games will have been played across almost six weeks and three countries.

The supersized tournament delivered thrilling action on the field, with upsets, dramatic comebacks, spectacular goals and stand-out performances by the biggest stars of the game.

It also generated controversy, from political tensions surrounding Iran's participation to criticism against innovations such as hydration



breaks, which were unpopular among many fans.

Here are some key takeaways from the 2026 World Cup in the United States, Mexico and Canada.

More teams, more drama: A newly expanded 48-team format raised concerns about lopsided matches and a lack of jeopardy in the group

stage. Tell that to Cape Verde, Congo and even Curacao, which all made history and won new fans.

Cape Verde held Spain to a draw in its opening game, advanced to the round of 32 and gave Argentina a scare before eventually losing 3-2 in extra time in a World Cup classic. Cape Verde's goal-

keeper Vozinha became a breakout star at the age of 40, gaining millions of followers on social media.

Congo also advanced beyond the group stage and pushed England before eventually losing, while Curacao was still in with a chance of making the knockouts going into its final group match.

FIFA opened its door to more teams and they proved they could compete on soccer's biggest stage.

The big stars delivered: The race for the golden boot became a who's who of the world's top players with Lionel Messi, Kylian Mbappe, Erling Haaland, Harry Kane and Jude Bellingham firing on all cylinders. Mbappe led the way ahead of Sunday's final with 10 goals in the tourna-

ment and a record 22 career World Cup goals. Messi had eight in this World Cup and 21 in total with one game to go.

Cristiano Ronaldo couldn't lead Portugal to success in what he said was his last World Cup, while Spain's teenage sensation Lamine Yamal — the star of the Euros two years ago — had to work his way into the tournament after overcoming injury.

Big tech, big complaints: Video reviews known as VAR were at the center of a number of contentious decisions, ruling out huge goals for Germany, Croatia and Egypt. Egypt coach Hossam Hassan launched a furious tirade after Argentina staged a spectacular comeback from 2-0 down to win 3-2 in the round of 16.

(AP)

Tommy Lad does enough to keep alive hopes of British Open in his hometown

DOUG FERGUSON

■ Southport (England)

Tommy Fleetwood has been dreaming about winning a British Open since he was a wee lad in Southport who could only sneak onto Royal Birkdale late in the evening. He's not about to stop dreaming now.

Even with a pair of bogeys on the final four holes, Fleetwood did enough Saturday — a 1-under 69, his third round under par this week — and was five shots behind Sam Burns.

He also had a record crowd at Royal Birkdale behind him. "There's no pressure on me at all really,



except for my own expectations," Fleetwood said. "And of course, it's a really beautiful thing that the town is so

hopeful for me and they want me to do well. I can't ask for any more from thousands and thousands of people out there.

"They've made a massive difference to me," he said. "Yesterday evening, the first tee every day, today when I was in contention, that stuff that I'll have for life. How many people in the golfing world get to experience that with the crowd that much on your side? It's been a very special week for me no matter what. If I can get it tomorrow, I could make it even more special. We'll see." The support is unlike anything he's ever heard, and for good reason. (AP)

World Cup integrity questioned by European rights body, urging FIFA to help protect 2030 WC

GRAHAM DUNBAR

■ Geneva

Europe's top human rights body questioned the integrity of the World Cup and urged FIFA on Sunday to help build a stronger framework for the 2030 edition being played mostly in Spain and Portugal.

"The next crisis has already begun. It has two names: money and power," the head of the 46-nation Council of Europe wrote Sunday in an open letter to its formal working partner FIFA hours before the final between Spain and Argentina in East Rutherford, New Jersey.

Swiss politician Alain Berset cited FIFA suspending a ban

for United States forward Folarin Balogun while under pressure from US President Donald Trump and the risk of fraud in the soccer body signing a prediction market as a World Cup sponsor. "When the rules bend under pressure, every result is open to doubt," Berset wrote about Balogun being freed from a mandatory one-game ban to face Belgium with a quarter-finals place at stake. Belgium won 4-1.

"Political influence has also moved onto the field," said Berset, who was twice a president of FIFA's home country Switzerland. "The sanction suspended mid-tournament came after a head of state called the pres-

ident of FIFA." FIFA signed a prediction market sponsor deal in April worth a reported \$150 million with ADI Predictstreet, one week after the Abu Dhabi-backed company was formally created. FIFA also has other commercial deals with the gambling industry for this World Cup.

Prediction betting has been criticized as rewarding insider trading, and Berset noted that in soccer it allowed wagers to be won on "moments a single player can produce without changing the score."

"It is an open door to fraud," he wrote. "And this World Cup has opened the door wider." The Council of



Europe (CoE) aired its concerns publicly despite having a formal working agreement with FIFA signed by its president Gianni Infantino in 2018. The inter-governmental body, which created the European Convention on Human Rights, has a stated mission: "To promote democracy, human rights and the rule of law across Europe and beyond."

When signing the FIFA-CoE memorandum of understanding eight years ago, Infantino said: "It is a natural relationship, as we share common values and goals: transparency, accountability, integrity, safety in sport and respect for human rights, for children's rights."

Infantino and Berset met in 2024 on the sidelines of the United Nations general assembly in New York.

FIFA's disciplinary ruling on Balogun was fiercely criticized by European soccer body UEFA, which said the decision "crossed a red line" in soccer's rule of law and transparency. FIFA has yet to publish documents explaining the reasoning of its disciplinary judge from the United Arab Emirates. "A sanction suspended under pressure, within days, with no reasons given," Berset wrote, before adding other concerns about the first 48-team, 104-game World Cup.

"The authority of referees called into question. Racist

abuse of players, some of it from elected officials. Betting on every pass, every card, every corner." The next men's World Cup will be staged mostly in Europe, with Morocco also co-hosting. Three South American neighbours, Argentina, Paraguay and Uruguay, are currently scheduled to host one game each at the start of the centenary edition in June 2030 to mark the original 1930 World Cup host Uruguay.

"So here is my proposal to FIFA," Berset wrote. "A working dialogue that starts tonight, to build the integrity framework of the 2030 World Cup before it is played." (AP)

England beat India in 3rd ODI to seal 2-1 series win

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

With his back against the wall and an illustrious career on the line, Rohit Sharma silenced his critics the only way he can, smashing one of his most celebrated centuries in recent memory, though it wasn't enough to prevent a 27-run defeat in the third ODI against England, as India surrendered the series 1-2 here Sunday.

Despite Rohit's magnificent 138, Shubman Gill's 77 and Virat Kohli's 74, India only managed 360 for 7 in pursuit of a mammoth target of 388 built on the back of a career-best 142 from Ben Duckett and 91 from Jacob Bethell.

The 13-ball 41 from Jos Buttler proved to be the decisive factor as England scored 82 in their last five overs.

With speculations about selectors and the head coach ready to move on from Rohit going forward, the 39-year-old former skipper faced enormous pressure going into the third and final game.

Rohit walked onto the hallowed turf of Lord's with a dual target: winning a series for India and saving his legacy, which was being tarnished by constant speculation from a section of the media.

He didn't raise his bat after completing his 34th ODI hundred – the first by an Indian batter at Lord's. Nor did he acknowledge the standing



ovation from the suits at the Members' Balcony after a 110-ball knock stitched with heart, hurt, and sweat.

It was the last time he played an ODI in England, and

people would talk for the longest time about how an ageing star showed resolve when the powers that be made him feel unwanted.

A stand of 147 with skipper

Gill and 113 with his old pal Kohli raised visions of an improbable victory.

For Rohit, there were 17 boundaries and five sixes – three off Josh Tongue – a pull, one down the ground, and one wide off long-on. There was a pulled six off Sam Curran (4/75 in 10 overs), who proved to be the bowling hero for England.

Curran's pace off deliveries at the death accounted for Ishan Kishan, Shreyas Iyer and Kohli in a space of seven deliveries to end any hopes that India would have harboured. Curran got able support from left-arm spinner Jacob Bethell (1/49 in 7 overs), a luxury India never had by playing a lone spinner in Axar

Patel. While India lost the series, one thing is for sure: neither Rohit nor Kohli will be going anywhere until the 2027 World Cup in South Africa.

On the day, Gambhir and Gill's planning went haywire and playing four pacers with combined experience of 51 games backfired badly.

Jasprit Bumrah's absence due to an impact injury on his left knee was a blow for India.

The four-pronged pace attack comprising Prasidh Krishna (2/69 in 10 overs), Arshdeep Singh (0/72 in 10 overs), Prince Yadav (1/79 on 10 overs) and Gurnoor Brar (0/97 in 10 overs), lacked both skill and experience against an in-form batting line-up.

Rohit is good enough to play for couple of years: Lalchand Rajput



HIMANK NEGI ■ New Delhi

Uncertainty might still be shrouding Rohit Sharma's future in ODIs, but his early mentor Lalchand Rajput believes that the former India captain is "good enough to play for couple of years", attributing the current struggles to natural "wear and tear" of two decades of cricket.

The debate over Rohit's place in India's plans intensified after reports suggested that chief selector Ajit Agarkar and head coach Gautam

Gambhir had informed the veteran opener that he was not in the roadmap for the 2027 ODI World Cup.

The speculation, however, was quickly dispelled by BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia.

"I don't believe in speculation. Unless it happens, then only we can talk about that. I still feel he is good enough to play for a couple of years," Rajput, who first watched Rohit as a youngster at the National Cricket Academy (now BCCI Centre of Excellence), told PTL. "He is fit

and has worked hard on his fitness. If you look at him now, he looks leaner. The way he batted in the last game, he showed glimpses of the Hitman. I think he is just one good innings away," said Rajput, who also served as Indian team's manager during the triumphant 2007 ICC T20 World Cup campaign.

Asked whether India should already be looking beyond Rohit, Rajput refused to indulge in the debate.

"It's a hypothetical question. Nothing is confirmed. Let's focus on Rohit because he is battling well, he has worked very hard on his fitness and has come back strongly. "When the time comes, we can talk about the future. Right now, after putting in so much effort on his fitness, he must have a mindset of playing till 2027. We should wait and watch," he added. So, what has led to Rohit's current struggle in England? "When you play for so many years, naturally your body goes through wear and tear. (PTI)

Whoever keeps performing should play: Kapil on RoKo

SUMAN RAY ■ Greater Noida

Legendary Kapil Dev asserted that even stalwarts like Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma are not a "certainty" in the Indian team but the veteran batters should be given a chance as long as they are performing.

Rohit, 39, and Kohli, 37, are at the fag end of their storied careers, but the former found himself in a pressure situation after two lowly outings against England in the ongoing three-match ODI series. "Certainty is never ever applied to anybody. Whoever keeps performing, keeps playing. It doesn't matter (who he is). I would say, you keep watching the performance and let them play as much as they can," Kapil told PTL during an



interaction at the Kapil Dev Sunil Gupta Hospital here.

Kapil said selectors and team management are best placed to take a decision on such senior players.

"Even Sachin Tendulkar had a lot of cricket left in him (when he retired). Let the

selectors do that job. I'm not going to say who's dropped. It's the selectors' and the team management's job. I'm assessing after watching television, so it's easy to talk about that. "Let's give the responsibility to the management and to the selectors

to pick the best team. If they lose, we should stand by them," he said. However, Kapil exhorted the fans to enjoy whatever little is left in the careers of these veterans.

"He (Rohit) is not 20 years old. He is almost 40, and everybody has to retire. But the amount of happiness he has given to everybody-not just Indian people, but everybody around the world – hats off to him," he said.

"What he has given us for so many years, we should be proud of that. And as much as he can play, or as the selectors or captain think, he should play," he added. The 1983 World Cup-winning skipper also urged the selectors to pick a team that can win matches for India, rising above factors like age etc.

"Transition is the method they want to use. It's ok, doesn't matter, let them. Tomorrow a new boy will come and he will take over. We just have to sit back, watch, and enjoy ourselves.

"I think it's taking time, but we have so much talent. They have to focus on who's going to play. Don't try to make too many shifts. Winning is the most important. If anybody is good, don't go by his age, don't go by his stature. You just have to pick a team that can win for India," he observed.

Kapil said teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi should be given time, considering he is just 15-year-old, to mature and meet his potential. "I don't want to talk about him too much. He has

the talent and just give him the opportunity. We've seen that talent, rest he has to work very hard.

A 15-year-old boy is a 15-year-old. But let him grow with his ability and talent." On the Indian team losing the T20I series against Ireland and England 0-2 and 0-4 respectively, Kapil said: "I think after they played so well for last 3-4 years, I never expected it to be as bad as that, but it happens. It's a cycle – (performance) goes up, comes down. Other teams try to catch up, and I think this is a new beginning for Indian cricket team. "My heart is always with Indian team. I hope they win all the matches. But they have to perform, they have to play well to win," he added. (PTI)

Players wear armbands as tribute to Sir Sobers



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

India and England players on Sunday wore black armbands at Lord's in the memory of the legendary West Indies cricketer Sir Garfield Sobers following his passing on Friday, the Indian team management said in a post.

captain and one of the greatest cricketers ever, Sobers breathed his last on Friday, 11 days shy of his 90th birthday.

"#TeamIndia is wearing black armbands to pay tribute to West Indies legend Sir Garfield Sobers following his passing on Friday," the Indian team management said in a post.

Vintage Sindhu stuns Yamaguchi to win maiden Japan Open title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Tokyo

Two-time Olympic medalist PV Sindhu produced a vintage display of attacking badminton to outclass local favourite Akane Yamaguchi in straight games, clinching her maiden Super 750 title at the Japan Open on Sunday.

The 31-year-old became the first Indian to win the Japan Open, combining relentless attack with tactical discipline and composure in the decisive moments to register a 21-17, 21-17 victory over the three-time world champion and end a title drought of almost two years.

"I'm very happy, I'm just out of words because it was 19 months since I had won,"



said Sindhu after the match.

"I think this one was very important to me because playing in the finals, coming to the finals is one thing but I think to win and stand on the podium getting that gold is a different thing.

"I'm happy that I'm on the

positive side and I think this gives me a lot of confidence. I think I'm very thankful to my coach, my parents, my support staff and of course my husband."

Sindhu's previous title came at the Syed Modi International in 2024. The

triumph is her biggest title since winning the World Championships in 2019. She had won the Singapore Super 500 in 2022. Yamaguchi was appearing in her sixth Japan Open final, while Sindhu had not beaten the Japanese in a completed match in four years. Their meeting at the Malaysia Open earlier this year ended with Yamaguchi retiring after the opening game. Sindhu's last full-match victory over her came at the Thailand Open in 2022.

On Sunday, however, the Indian dictated terms from the outset. She controlled the forecourt superbly, attacked with purpose rather than sheer power and repeatedly found answers whenever Yamaguchi threatened a comeback.

SELF-BELIEF PAID OFF, BUT MAINTAINING TEMPO KEY TO WORLD CHAMPIONSHIP MEDAL BID: SINDHU

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Tokyo

An emotional PV Sindhu said her unwavering self-belief had finally paid off after claiming her biggest title in six years at the Japan Open, vowing to carry the same tempo and composure into next month's World Championships, where she will bid for a record sixth medal.

Sindhu produced a vintage display of attacking badminton to outclass local favourite and three-time world champion Akane Yamaguchi 21-17, 21-17 on Sunday. "Well, actually I had tears in my eyes because it was very important for me

to win. Because I was really focusing hard and working hard on myself," Sindhu said.

Sindhu's previous title came at the Syed Modi International in December, 2024. The Indian ace triumph at Tokyo was her biggest since winning the World Championships in 2019. She had also won the Singapore Open Super 500 title in 2022. "I'm just out of words because it was 19 months since I had won. I kept believing that I could do it. Even though a lot of people were like, what's happening? Is it done or whatever it is? But I still believed in myself and I want to thank my family, coaches and support staff."

Keep myself away from external factors: Gill

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

India's Test and ODI skipper Shubman Gill has said keeping himself away from "external factors" helps him deal with pressure situations on and off the field.

Gill will be leading India in the third and final ODI against England here on Sunday, and a win will give the tourists a 2-1 series victory. "The way I deal with pressure is by keeping focussed on the things that are in my control and keep myself away from the external factors," said Gill during an interactive session at a diaspora reception hosted by the High Commission of India in London on Saturday. India's



T20I captain Shreyas Iyer, who had to deal with a couple of injuries in the recent past, thanked his teammates for inspiring him to make a comeback. "I just wanted to get out of the hospital. The calls from my team members gave me a lot of motivation to head back to my training and come back stronger," said during the session co-ordinat-

ed by India's Deputy High Commissioner to the UK, Kartik Pande.

Head coach Gautam Gambhir described the UK as a "special place", given the history between both countries which "can never be forgotten and should never be forgotten". "Indian cricket does not just belong to the people sitting in the dressing room. It belongs to every honest Indian cricket fan, who supports us selflessly and unconditionally," said Gambhir. BCCI vice-president Rajiv Shukla told the players to stay off social media before a match and focus on their respective games. "In India, the problem is that 99 percent of the people are experts in cricket... so just try to avoid

social media. There's no dearth of talent in Team India, they are full of talent," said Shukla during his address at the gathering held at the India House

P Kumaran, the Indian High Commissioner to the UK, welcomed the team and highlighted the wide-ranging impact of the India-UK Comprehensive and Economic Trade Agreement (CETA), which entered into force this week. "We are hopeful that it [CETA] opens up many possibilities for business services as well as sports related activities," said Kumaran. "Over the years, Team India has made us proud many times over and over with your achievements," he added.

Kajal bags gold in 76kg, Antim Panghal clinch silver in Budapest Ranking Series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Budapest

Reigning U20 world champion wrestler Kajal clinched the women's 76kg category gold with a commanding performance in the Budapest Ranking Series. Facing USA's Dymond Precious Guilford in a gripping gold medal clash, the young Indian wrestler exhibited immense tactical composure under pressure. The high-stakes encounter ended in a 3-3 deadlock, but Kajal held her nerve to clinch the championship on criteria, securing India's third gold medal of the tournament.

India added two silver medals to its haul through strong campaigns in the 53kg and 57kg weight divisions.

In the 53kg championship final, Antim Panghal was forced to settle for



silver after conceding her gold medal bout against Sweden's Emma Jonna Denise Malmgren due to an injury (VIN). Meanwhile, in the 57kg category,

ry, Neha Sharma put together an impressive run to reach the final.

Facing a formidable opponent in China's Kexin Hong in the title clash, Sharma fought valiantly but sustained a 0-4 defeat on points to finish second.

India secured an additional podium finish in the 53kg division as Nishu claimed a hard-fought bronze medal.

In a fiercely contested tactical battle against Romania's Andrea Beatrice Ana, Nishu displayed immense defensive resilience.

The bout ended in a 2-2 tie, but the Indian wrestler was declared the winner on criteria (VPO1) to secure her spot on the podium.

Now, India have accumulated an impressive 12 medals at the tournament, comprising three gold, four silver, and five bronze medals.

Indian sub-junior hockey teams eye World Cup berths at Youth Hockey5s Asian Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Indian sub-junior men's and women's teams will begin their campaign in the inaugural FIH Youth Hockey5s Asian Championship in Muscat on Monday, aiming to secure berths in the maiden FIH U-18 Youth Hockey5s World Cup.

The six-day tournament will serve as the Asian qualifier for the inaugural FIH U-18 Youth Hockey5s World Cup. The Indian sub-junior

men's team, coached by Sardar Singh, heads into the tournament with confidence after clinching the U18 Asia Cup title, defeating hosts Japan 4-1 in the final.

The squad comprises players from the gold medal-winning campaign and has been placed alongside hosts Oman, Pakistan and Bangladesh in the Elite Pool.

"The players have earned this opportunity with their outstanding performance at the U18 Asia Cup, and the confidence from winning the



title will certainly help us. However, Hockey5s is a unique format that demands quick decision-making, high intensity and adaptability," Singh said in a release.

"The boys have prepared well for these challenges, and our focus will be on executing our plans, maintaining consistency and securing qualification for the inaugural FIH U18 Youth Hockey5s World Cup. We are excited to compete against some of Asia's best young teams and represent

India with pride."

The Indian sub-junior women's team, coached by Rani Rampal, features players who secured the bronze medal at the U18 Asia Cup. The team has been drawn in the Elite Pool with China, Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan.

The Elite Pool follows a double round-robin format, with each team playing against the other twice. The top two teams at the end of the league stage will advance directly to the gold

medal match, while the third-placed team will qualify directly for the bronze medal match. The fourth-placed team will face the top-ranked Challenger Pool team in a qualification match, with the winner progressing to the bronze medal match.

India's campaign begins on Monday, with the women's team taking on Kazakhstan before the men's team faces Bangladesh later in the evening.